# Crown of Night

*The Odiyan Contracts, Book 3*

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Adult (18+). All characters are adults.

## Chapter 1

# The Sea Opens

Thilak tipped the last flask over the horn cup and watched the black thread break in the middle.

"That's it," he said. "That's the third tree."

Nobody spoke. The hearth ticked. Rain dripped from the turf roof into the bucket by the door, as it had dripped for four months. Forty-odd people sat on the packed floor of the pepper hunters' shelter, and every one of them was looking at a cup with less than a thumb of resin in it.

"Noon bark," Thilak said. He wiped his hooked knife on his thigh. "Pachan's map says these three trees run best at midday. They run best. It's still a trickle. Seven more days of rain, by my count, and I can give you a pinch a night, split even. Or I can give the whole cup to the ones whose nails split first and let the rest bear it."

"Seven days," Pavi said, from the wall. Her curled forepaw of a left hand lay in her lap. "Then the roads open and the Resin House groves are ours to tap properly."

"If the sky keeps its word," said Thilak. "It hasn't so far."

Neela counted the room. Habit. Forty-two odiyans, herself and Vellan among them, Vellan sitting by the door where he always sat, turning a lump of pale wood in his big hands. One husband, at the hearth, with his back to the wall. Two exits: the low door and the smoke hole. Three

people with the tired grey look under the eyes that meant the ache was close.

She had that look herself. She had stopped checking the mirror of the water bucket.

"Hands," she said. "Even split first."

Twenty-seven hands went up. She counted twice. Then she asked for the other plan, and eleven went up, and four people looked at their knees and didn't vote at all. Those four were the ones who needed the cup most, and they would not say so.

"Even split," Neela said. "And the four who didn't raise a hand get theirs first, because they didn't raise a hand."

A pause. Then Meenu laughed, a short surprised bark, and the room let out its breath. Thilak nodded and began dividing the cup into forty-two with the tip of his knife, careful as a man halving a pepper berry.

The plank leaned against the wall by the hearth, the lamp-black names in rows down its face. It had come up the hill lashed to a pack-horse, and the hill had not been kind to it. Neela took the lump of chalk from its notch and went down the list. Each name got a mark when its share was set. Thulasi. Kumaran, called Kuttu. Madhavi. Meenu. Pavi. On and on, in the order the forty had asked for, until only the last blank remained, under all the others.

She wrote her own name there. Neela. Then, smaller, beside it, because she was learning to, *Indu*.

"Last," said Kamalakshi.

She said it from the corner, where she sat with her chin on her knees. Kamalakshi had laughed for the first time on this hill, three months back, and had been making up for it since. "Look at her. Twenty-seven years old, and she still thinks if she stands at the back of the line, nobody will notice she's in charge."

"Nobody has noticed," Neela said.

"The goat has noticed. The goat has *written a letter*."

The room went. Even Vellan's shoulders moved. Neela looked at the hearth, because she had learned where to look, and Devan was not

laughing, quite. His mouth had gone crooked at one corner. Thirty-two years old, a man who had given away a fort and an iron seal worn by eleven wardens, and he still waited a full breath to see whether a joke was safe before he let it show.

She loved the corner of his mouth. She filed that thought where she filed all of them, to look at later.

The plank had shifted in the laughing. The crossbar, a split bit of wild pepper vine bound to the top, had loosened again in the damp. Neela knelt, pulled the old lashing free, and tied it anew without looking. Two turns round the bar, a loop through, the second loop doubled back under itself and drawn tight against the first. A fisherman's hitch. The kind that held a net to a boat in a swell and could be undone by one pull on the right end.

Ammu had said a net-mender behind the sheds taught them both. Neela had never remembered the lesson. The knot had simply always been in her fingers, the way her own name hadn't.

She sat back on her heels and looked at it. Her hands had stopped. They did that, lately, when the knot was done.

"Master," Kuttu shouted from the door. "Master, come out. *Come out.*"

*

The cloud had gone.

For four months the hill had worn it like a lid. Now it lay in long grey rags below the shelter, torn open, and above them the sky was a clean washed blue, so sharp it hurt. Neela stepped out onto wet turf and stopped, because the world had grown a floor.

The hills dropped away in ridges, each paler than the last, green going to blue going to nothing. Past the last ridge, a line of silver. It was wide, flat, and brighter than the sky.

And the sea.

"Never seen it from here," Thilak said, behind her. He sounded as if someone had hit him. "Twenty-two years a member and I've never seen it from here."

"It's not the sea I'm looking at," said Vellan.

He had come up the slope with his limping, dragging step, slow, a big man made smaller by something heavier than the hill. He pointed with the wooden bird.

Neela looked at the water's edge.

Sails. White at first, small as grains of rice on a plate. Then, as her eyes learned them, more. They sat in the shallows off a pale curve of beach, and she began to count, because counting was what she did when something frightened her. Ten. Twenty. They overlapped each other. Thirty. Forty. The wind carried a faint sour smell up the slope, and her stomach turned before her mind knew why. She went on counting. Fifty. Fifty-six. Sixty, near enough.

She knew the curve of that beach.

Never from above. Nobody had ever shown her. But the wide bend of the bay, the low headland like a bent knee on its left, the dark smudge of land behind the sand: her body knew them as it knew the knot. Nellimala. Indu, of Nellimala. A day below Kettamala on the coast side, and under the lantana now, a ring of stone footings that nobody had lived in for twenty-one years.

The wind turned. Down in the gully a bank of lantana flowered orange and pink in the first sun, and its crushed-leaf stink rose up the slope and hit the back of her throat.

She breathed through her mouth. One. Two. Three.

A hand settled between her shoulder blades, light, and did not stay. Devan was beside her. He did not touch her again. He looked at the sea the way he looked at ground he meant to hold.

"Sixty," she said.

"Fifty-eight," said Devan. "Two are fishing boats from the beach. They'll be towing." He was quiet for a moment. "Sixty."

"Is that a raid?"

"No." His voice was flat, the voice he used for facts. "A raid is six boats. A good season, twelve. The treaty let them land a few at a time, by the passes the council sold them, so the coast burned a village at a time and the queen could tell herself it was bandits." He nodded at the water. "Nobody controls sixty."

"The treaty's broken."

"It broke." He said it without heat. "Ittan was the treaty's hand, and Ittan is dead. Muthu seals the pass now, and Muthu seals it honestly, with no Keeper's wax to wave a cart through. Every raider's token is a stick of dead wood." He looked at her, brief. "We did that. You and I and a few months of being right. We shut the door the queen kept open, and the Thurai have stopped knocking."

A thought rose in her that was too quick to be kind. *Then it's ours.* She pushed it down, and looked at the beach again, at the sand where a village had been, and saw the first dark threads of smoke lift from the headland.

"The coast is paying for it," said Devan.

"Yes."

Behind them, no one said anything. Forty-odd people stood in the wet turf with the sun on their faces, and not one of them had a name for what they were looking at.

*

Kesu's grandson came up the goat path at noon, running when he should have crawled.

Neela knew him by his legs first, thin brown legs scraped to the knee and streaked with red laterite, and then by the single braid that had been his grandfather's idea of a haircut. He reached the shelter and went straight down on one knee in the mud, chest heaving. Thilak shoved a gourd at him. He drank, coughed, and drank again.

"Burning," he said. "The coast villages. Pazhayangadi's gone. Kalladi's holding, but there are a hundred of them on the road. They came ashore at first light, and they didn't *sneak*. They had drums."

Neela looked for Thulasi without meaning to. She stood by the plank, a salt-boiler's daughter of Pazhayangadi, who had told Neela once, shyly, that she could still smell the pans. Her hand had come up over her mouth. Her eyes were on the boy and did not move. Pavi, nearest, put a shoulder against hers and said nothing.

"The pass villages?" Devan was crouched in front of the boy, one hand open on his knee. He had not raised his voice.

"Loading carts. Every cart. The old men are carrying the little ones on their backs. My grandfather says to tell you he's staying, he'll hold the well and be damned, but my mother's at the foot of the path with the goats and the pot." The boy gulped air. "And the captain won't come."

"Muthu."

"He's on the gate chamber stair with a paper. He reads it to anyone who asks. *The crown holds Kodiyur and the forts.* The garrison stays inside the walls. The hill villages are to bear what comes." He swallowed. "He doesn't say it like a man who likes it. But he says it."

Nobody moved. Neela watched Devan's face, and it did nothing at all, which was how she knew.

"Then there's another," Pavi said quietly, and stepped aside.

Behind her stood a tapper's runner, a long lad Neela had seen at the Resin House gate, with the stained forearms of a boy who cut bark. He had come up the east slope in the same hour and had been waiting politely to be noticed. He held his cap in both hands.

"From Pachan, Master," he said. "He says the groves are quiet. Nobody's come. He says to tell you everyone's fed." He hesitated. Pachan was a careful man who had once given a ten-year-old a sweet at a long table, and it seemed his runners were careful too. "And he says Kirri hardly lifts her head now. She eats when he sets the dish in. She doesn't come to the bars."

Neela said, "Thank you."

It came out in her ordinary voice, which surprised her.

*Kirthika, a boatwright's daughter, sold at five.* A fishing boat of her own, with a basket for her anklet, a sign to send down the coast. Kirri

had cut the bells off that anklet and never taken it off, even to bathe, and was wearing it still, on a civet's thin back leg, in the straw.

Neela folded the thought flat and put it away. There was nothing to do with it today. That was the worst of it. Every grief in the shelter came with a day's walk between it and a hand to reach.

"Thilak," she said. "Give the boys bread."

She had gone three steps when she heard Devan stand.

He had not spoken. He did not speak now. But the room had a way of going quiet around him, even a room that had stopped being afraid of him, and when she turned he was standing in front of the hearth with his hands at his sides, looking, not at her, but past her, at the plank on the wall with its forty-one names.

"I'd like to put something to the Company," he said.

Kamalakshi's head came up. Several people shifted. The word *Company* still sat strangely in the shelter. Nobody had agreed to it. It had started as a joke of Kuttu's about the plank, and then it had stopped being a joke.

"I hold no office," said Devan. "Muthu has the seal, and the queen's order forbids him to send a man down. That order isn't mine to break, and I'd not ask him to. But the Monkey Pass is the only cart road from the coast into the hills, and it is open to anyone who walks it. If those ships put men ashore with any sense, they will be in the gorge in three days. A hundred of them on a road forty paces wide. Behind it are the pass villages, and behind those are the pepper terraces, and behind those are you."

He took a breath.

"I mean to go down and hold the gorge. I won't ask any of you to come. A man who asks that has settled it for you already. I ask only your leave for myself, since I go without leave from a crown that wouldn't give it, and without a garrison, which Muthu cannot spare." He did not blink. "If the hands say no, I sit by this fire and hate it."

Neela stood very still.

He wasn't looking at her. That was the thing. He had not turned his head once. He was speaking to Pavi, to Kuttu, to Thilak with his hooked knife, to the girl called Kamalakshi with Vellan's carved bird turning over in her lap. To forty-two people who held a plank and a cup of thin resin between them, and no power on earth over him.

Asking her would have been easy. She would have said yes, and he would have gone, and nobody would ever have known that he'd needed asking. He could have called on rank, or told them what he'd do. In all the months she had watched men obey him, she had never seen him ask permission to fight, and then bind himself to the answer.

"Is this a vote?" Thilak said slowly.

"If you'll have it as one."

A short silence.

"Then you'll want it carried by hands," said Kamalakshi, and stood up, brushing damp straw from her skirt. "Everyone who thinks the warden of nothing should walk down a mountain and stand in front of sixty ships."

"Fifty-eight," said Vellan.

"*Fifty-eight.*" She raised her own hand first.

Neela watched the hands go up. Not all at once. Thilak's, then Pavi's, then Meenu, who was pressed against the wall as she had been pressed against another wall once, then Kuttu's, slow, with his jaw working. Thulasi's, last of that row, with the other hand still half over her mouth. Madhavi, who had once closed her teeth on Devan's thigh. Hands, and hands, and hands. Four did not rise. She did not count them yet.

Devan stood and waited, and didn't move his eyes. The corner of his mouth was no longer crooked.

Her own hand went up last. She felt every eye in the room go to it.

"Carried," said Thilak, rough. "Go on, then."

Devan nodded once. Then, finally, he looked at her. It was only a look, a plain question with a plain answer in it, and she gave it back to him with her hand still in the air.

*Yes. Go. I'll be a hand behind you.*

By the door, Vellan got to his feet, the wooden bird fisted at his side. "Forty paces wants more than one man," he said. "I'm slow on a hill. I'll start now."

"Pachan's tappers know the scree," said Thilak, already reaching for the sack. "I'll send a runner."

Nobody had asked either of them. Devan looked from one to the other and, for once, had nothing to say.

*

The sun went early behind the western ridge, as it always did on that hill, and the long gold light went the colour of watered honey.

Neela sat on the flat stone outside the door with a bowl of cold rice on her knee and did not eat. Below the shelter the goat path wound down through the thorn in a pale thread. Devan and Vellan were working out the gorge between them with a stick in the mud, the heads of two old soldiers bent together, one grey, one not yet. Thilak was packing hooked knives into a sack. Somewhere behind her Kamalakshi had started a song, a rude one, and been told to stop it, and not stopped.

She was watching the path because she always watched the path. So she saw the woman first.

A long way down, a pin of green against the grey scree where the path left the thorn. She climbed steadily. She did not hurry, and she did not rest. She was alone. Neela looked for the second, the third, the rest of the shape behind her, the way you look for the hunters behind a hare. There was only the one.

*Not a hunter's pace. Not a runner's.* A tapper's? No. Too even.

At the last bend, where the path became rock, the woman stopped and held out both hands, empty, palms forward. She had meant to be seen doing it. The light caught her sash, bright green, knotted at the left hip, and under it the pale grey of a travelling cloak.

Neela's bowl slid off her knee and rolled.

The woman came on. Closer, her face sharpened: a long plain face, a few years past thirty, a mouth held very still. Her sleeves came down to

the knuckle on each hand. She had pulled them there, deliberately, and held them with her thumbs, the way a girl holds her cuffs against the cold.

Neela had seen that woman before, at the padippura of Kettamala, on a wet evening, with a sash that same green. She had said two words in passing, quiet, to a girl with split nails, and walked on as if she hadn't.

*It passes.*

Neela stood. Behind her the song broke off. A stick scraped on stone as Devan came up beside her, and she felt rather than saw his hand go to the place at his hip where a sword would be, and find nothing.

The woman reached the last flat slab of rock before the shelter door and stopped there, six paces off, hands still open. She did not look at Vellan. She did not look at Devan. She looked at Neela, directly, for the length of a long breath, and her face did not change at all.

Then she lowered her hands, slowly, and let go of her cuffs with her thumbs. They rode back up her forearms.

At the left wrist, in the last gold light, lay a single seam, pale and flat, a finger long. Neela had seen a great many wrists like it, every one of them her own kind. They were never smooth.

## Chapter 2

# It Passes

Devan stepped between the woman and the door before Neela could, and he did not apologise for it.

The sun had already gone behind the western ridge. What was left lay on the scree in a thin copper wash that would last a quarter hour. When it went, the forty would want the dark, the cup and the low room to themselves. He had said three words to the room the moment he saw the green sash: *Nobody smears tonight.* Kuttu had groaned. Nobody had asked why. They were learning what he was afraid of.

The woman stopped on the flat slab, six paces off. Vellan stood a pace behind Devan's right shoulder and said nothing, which for Vellan was loud. Neela was at his left. He had not asked for that either, and he did not move away from it.

"I am alone," the woman said. "I carry no resin and no flask. You may look."

"I will."

She pushed her sleeves back, left and then right, and held out her wrists in the last of the light. The left bore the single flat seam he remembered from the passage outside Ittan's guardroom, where a cuff had slipped for the length of a breath. The right bore its twin. Both had been pared, and neatly. Somebody had cut away a girl's worth of layered ridges and left a line a finger long.

Vellan breathed in through his nose, slow, twice. Then he gave one small shake of his big head. No tamarind. No scorched pine. She was clean.

"Your name," Devan said.

"Usha."

He waited for the rest of it. There was no rest. She had given it the way a person sets down a knife, handle first.

For three days her escort had slept in his south range and eaten Janu's rice. They had answered to First, Second, Third and Fourth. Janu had tried each of them with a plate and a scolding and got nothing back. Not one had offered a name to anyone at Kettamala. This one had walked up a mountain to hand hers over, and he did not know what it was meant to buy.

"You came to give us a name," he said.

"I came to give you this." She took a letter from inside her sash. It was folded square and tied with green thread, and the thread was sealed under a thumb of green wax. "I was told whoever holds the hill would take it. The Company, if there is one yet."

*Company.* So the word had climbed down the hill ahead of her, or she had guessed it. He filed that, and took the letter.

Even in poor light the wax was clear. The sunbird was pressed deep, wings spread wide, and at the tip of the left wing sat the little chip he knew as he knew his own scars. The same chip marked the payment writ in the oilcloth at the bottom of his pack, which he had carried up the hill rather than leave it in the shutter frame. That seal had bought his death. This one was asking for something.

He turned the letter to the last of the light. Where the thread crossed the wax, a second bird had been pressed so lightly that he nearly missed it. It was smaller and faint, wings folded close to its body. He had seen that bird in the margins of Ittan's tally book, and on the stubs of thirty cut leaves. He kept his face still.

"Read it aloud," Neela said quietly. "They should hear it."

The doorway behind them had filled. He could feel the forty stacked in it, breath held. He broke the wax. It gave with the soft crack of a leaf.

The hand was a clerk's, round and even. The words were not a clerk's.

*To those who came down from the Resin House and have no master: I, Nirmala, Queen of Varanad, greet you. I do not call you rogues. I offer a pardon under my seal for every name on your plank, and the crown's vouching in place of a master's, so that no one need hunt you. Come to Kodiyur as my night-guard, and be fed, and be sworn, and be safe. The war will end. When it ends, those without a vouching will be hunted, and I will not be able to prevent it. I would rather you were mine than anyone's prey.*

*The crown will hold Kodiyur and the forts. The hill villages must bear the raiders as they always have.*

*I wait on your answer.*

Nobody spoke. Devan read the last lines again in his head, and then once more, slower, and the cold started in his hands.

*As they always have.*

Six boats. Twelve in a good season. A village burned at a time and a purse of silver coin in the right hand, and the queen telling herself it was bandits. *As they always have* was the treaty written in her own words, a line she must have thought no one could read. She wanted forty knives behind her walls. She had sixty ships on the beach, and she had written that the hill would bear it. Nobody in that sentence had been counted but him.

His goal, which had been a vote at a fire an hour ago, went hard as set mortar. He held the Monkey Pass, with no office and no seal and no leave from the woman whose chipped sunbird lay in his hand. Nothing in that letter would change it, and nothing in an answer could.

"The pardon is real," Usha said. "I would not say it if it weren't."

"I believe you believe it."

Her mouth moved, not a smile. "That is a careful way to say it, warden."

"I've no office. Devan will do."

He folded the letter along its creases. "How did you find the shelter?"

"The pass-village watcher walks the hill edge at dawn and reads the scent-posts." She said it like a woman reciting a route. "His log goes to a cell at Kettamala, and from there to whoever opens the prisoner's post. That is the queen's household. Every Resin House post went cold in a single night. Forty horses left dung on the goat path." She glanced at Vellan. "A child could have followed it. So I did."

"And Rema's escort left by that path."

"We did."

He waited again. She gave him nothing more, and he could not say whether that was discipline or a wall.

Behind him a boot scraped grit. Neela had moved, no more than a step, and now she stood level with Usha, close, her bandaged left hand held loose at her side. Her voice came pitched low, but the evening was still and the slab was small.

"It passes," Usha said to her.

The same two words she had spoken in the padippura at dusk, about a girl's split nails. Devan had not been meant to hear them then, and he heard them now. Neela's head tilted. Her face went careful.

"Does it," she said.

"Not the ache. The rest." Usha's thumbs had found her cuffs again. "I heard a page burned of itself, at the Resin House, two nights past the new moon. In the household that is not a thing one hears twice. What did the naming cost?"

Devan did not move. He had never told Neela he would not speak of it. He had simply not known anyone would ask her aloud.

Neela did not look at him. She could have said *that is mine to keep*. She could have lied, as she had lied for twenty-one years to anyone with a face and a question. She answered in her dry flat voice:

"He cuts himself, I get the welt. I cut myself, he gets it. Nicked his chin shaving three days back and I found out over my rice." A short

breath. "A deep wound goes both ways. A mortal one drags the other down with it. For life, both of us."

"All of it?"

"That's all of it. It's also everything."

She said it to a stranger in the open, on a rock, in front of forty people and a bear. She said it the way one reports the weather in one's own body. *My hand. His hand. The same hand.* Usha's face did a very small thing at the eyes and then stilled. She turned half away to look down the dark path, and Devan stood holding the folded letter and looked at her back, the green sash knotted at the hip.

He had known about the welts since the Resin House wall. He had felt a hook clip Neela's ribs and said *then it's mine*. That was not new. What was new was that the queen's own agent now held it, in Neela's voice, and would carry it back down to a woman who wrote *prey* in a kind hand. His body was a known lever on hers. A spear that went through him in the gorge was a spear aimed at Neela, and the queen's household could now count on that as surely as he could.

Usha turned back. "Understood," she said.

"I doubt it," said Neela. Her tone was not unkind.

The copper had left the scree. The first stars came out thin and grudging over the sea. Devan saw Usha look once at the doorway, at the faces there, and he stepped half a pace to the left so she saw him instead.

"You'll sleep under the lee wall," he said. "Thilak will bring you food. Nobody crosses the slab after dark. It's not a threat. It's a rule of the house."

"I know the rule," she said. "Better than you."

"Then you'll keep it better than we do."

She almost smiled again.

*

The fire burned low and the shelter slept in lumps. Thilak had given Usha rice and a blanket and watched her eat it. Vellan had gone to sit across the slab from her, his back against the stones, the pale wooden

bird turning in his fingers. Neela lay on her side at the far end of the hearth with her hand under her cheek. Her breath hitched on the ninth count. He had learned it by heart.

Devan went out behind the shelter.

A roof post stood at the back, where the lean-to for the packhorse met the wall. It was a squared length of old chestnut, silvered and cracked, set deep in the turf, and it reached about a man's throat. In the dark he could not see the grain. He had no need to.

He stood square. He took a breath through the nose and let it go. Then he raised his right hand, flat, the first two fingers joined and the others folded under, and began the slow drill.

He had made it up at twenty-five, the winter after the ford, when he had stopped hitting living things and could not stop hitting wood. It was a stripped form: one strike, a stride in, a turn of the wrist. Each step took a count of ten. At the end the two fingers stopped a hair short of the post, at the place where on a man the notch below the ear would be. A hair. He knew exactly how wide it was, because he had spent seven years measuring it.

He did it again. And again. He was not thinking of the queen, or of sixty ships. He was thinking about the width of a hair and how it differed from nothing, and how his hand, tonight, wanted to close the gap.

*Not yet,* he told it. *Not on a post.*

He finished the tenth strike and lowered the hand. His breath was even. The chestnut had not been touched.

The pack lay under the lean-to eave. He knelt beside it, undid the flap and found the oilcloth by feel. It was the size of two palms and tied with red thread. He did not unwrap it. He knew what lay inside without a lamp. A strip of hide, a chit split in two, and the queen's payment writ with its green wax and its chip at the left wing tip.

*Death by beast, in the warden's chamber, before the pass closes.*

He pressed his thumb on the knot of red thread, the way a man tests a scar to see whether it still hurts.

It did. The same woman had written *I would rather you were mine than anyone's prey*, and had meant it, probably. She answered every widow's petition with her own hand. Rema had said so. She signed death writs for loyal servants who got in the way. Both were true, and he had spent a night with his head full of the second, and tonight he knew the first as well.

He tied the flap and sat back on his heels. The hill was quiet. Somewhere far down, past the dark of the scree, a red smudge lay on the edge of the world, low and steady. Pazhayangadi, or what was left of it.

He went in and lay down at Neela's back, careful of her left hand, and counted her breaths until his own fell into step with them. He did not sleep for long.

*

He woke before the light and did not move.

Through the smoke hole the sky had gone from black to the flat grey that came before colour. The shelter was a heap of blankets. Through the gap of the door he saw a figure already up and quiet at the lee wall, boots in her hand. Usha put them on without a sound and straightened her sash at the left hip.

Devan eased himself clear of Neela's sleeping weight. She was awake. He knew it by the way her breath did not hitch, deliberate and even. Her eyes were shut and she was listening, as he was, with the whole of her skin.

Outside, the cold had a bite. The turf was soaked grey and the sea lay under a mist, and the green sash was already at the lip of the slab. Usha did not turn to look at the door. She walked three steps and stopped, and Neela came past Devan's shoulder in her wrap with her bare feet on the wet rock. She had not asked leave to go first and he had not offered it.

They stood a pace apart. Usha said something. It took no more than a breath or two, and her lips moved too little for him to read from the doorway. Neela did not answer. Usha dipped her head, once, and then

she was gone down the thorn path as lightly as she had come up it, a pin of green going to grey.

Neela turned and walked back to him. Her face had nothing in it at all.

"Tell me," he said.

"She said, *The leaf sleeps in the queen's room.*" Neela's voice was low and even, the way she spoke when she was counting something. "And then, *If you come, come by the sea stair at the noon gun.*"

"The leaf."

"A leaf of pages. One that could be read." She wet her lips. "The crown leaf. She means the thirty."

The wind lifted the corner of the letter in his pocket. He had not known he was holding it.

A woman who had given her name to a stranger and shown her scars on a bare hillside. A woman who had asked what the naming cost, and listened to the answer as if it were the only thing in the world she wanted to know. She had come alone, with open hands, and left a door.

Or a snare. The same hinges served both. He had been in the border service long enough to know that, and married long enough to know that Neela knew it too.

He looked at the path where the green had gone. The mist was thickening into the gorge, and there was no knowing what waited at the bottom of it.

"Door or snare," Neela said.

"Kodiyur is four days at a hard ride," she went on, flat, counting. "The raiders are in the gorge in three."

"So the door costs the pass I swore to the fire I'd hold," said Devan, "or it costs you going alone."

"Yes."

He looked at her bare feet on the wet rock, then at the path.

"I can't tell," he said.

It was the truth. It was the only kind of answer he had ever given her, and she took it, as she always did, and put her cold hand into his.

## Chapter 3

# Two Votes

They laid the plank across two hearthstones and sat round it like a table, forty-three people and a bowl of cold ash.

Devan drew in the ash with a stick. A long crooked line, the gorge, and across it a short bar. "The shelf," he said. "Forty paces wide at the mouth. Narrower under the shelf, where Raman died. A hundred men in single file can be held there by a few who know the ground, and not by many who don't. Behind that line are Kesu at his well, the pass villages, and Parukutty's children. Minnu is six. Chandu is nine." He set the stick down. "I hold the narrows. I ask the Company to hold it with me."

He said it plainly. He had bound himself to their hands, and everyone in the room knew what it cost him to ask.

Neela waited until the ash stopped moving. Then she took the stick.

"I want to go south," she said.

She made a second mark, well away from the first, at the bottom of the hearth. Not a line. A cliff. "The queen sent a letter and a woman with open hands, and she sent a door. *The leaf sleeps in the queen's room.* Thirty pages of the night-guard, in one place, while every eye in Kodiyur is on the sea. She will never watch her own room less than she does this week." She tapped the cliff. "Once the war ends, she can send those thirty anywhere. They'd be hers, or they'd be the raiders' bait. I want a small party, by the sea stair, at the noon gun."

"Four days there," said Thilak. He was a broad man who spoke slowly and meant every word. "Four back, if all goes well. The raiders are three days off. Neela, I'm a tapper. I tapped nightbark beside the sons of half the pass villages. If the narrows fall while we're counting stairs in a palace, I don't know how we look them in the face."

"They'll look at our backs," said Pavi, from the wall. "While we hold the gorge with forty and thirty sit in cages made of paper. Thilak, you were twenty-two years a member. You know what it is to have your name in someone's drawer."

"I know it better than you."

"Then you know it won't wait for spring."

It went round the plank. Kuttu said the villages were people, and the thirty were people, and he'd hold a gorge or climb a stair but he would not be asked to weigh them. Meenu, who rarely spoke, said she had been in a cage the width of a hunter's arm, and would give a season of nights to see the door of another one open. Somebody answered that doors did not matter to a village that had burned. Somebody answered that doors were all that mattered to those behind them.

Madhavi leaned forward. She had once closed her teeth on Devan's thigh, and he had not held it against her.

"Say it's a snare," she said. "The queen wants forty-one knives behind her walls. She sends a clean-wristed woman with a pardon, and a hint of a way in. Why send the hint? Because she wants us in the palace, where she can use the word." She looked at Neela. "She has seen every one of those thirty turn. She doesn't need a page to cage them. She won't need a page to keep *us*, once we've walked in."

"Or," said Pavi, "Usha is one of the thirty. Her wrists were cut. Her cuffs came down over them like a girl hiding a bruise. A prisoner sent that message, and it is the one hinge she could reach."

"Or she's both," said Kuttu. "Snare and door. It happens."

"Or the queen means the door and means the snare," said Thilak. "She can want both. She has wanted both for twenty years."

"Then answer me one thing," Madhavi said, still looking at Neela. "Who knows the stair?"

The ash had gone quiet. Neela made herself answer without turning it.

"Usha's sentence."

"Which is?"

"*The sea stair at the noon gun.*"

"That's all of it?"

"That's all of it. It's thin." She did not look away. "I'd want better before I put a foot on it. But the vote is whether we go at all."

Madhavi sat back. "That's honest," she said. "I don't like it any better."

Neela let them argue on. Every guess was a good one. None of them could be tested before the noon gun. She looked at Devan across the ash and found him watching her, not the room, with the face he wore when he was seeing something exactly.

"Neela."

It was Kamalakshi. She had not spoken since the argument started. She sat with her knees drawn up and the carved wooden bird turning in her fingers, and her voice came quiet.

"If I hold my own page," she said, "can anyone else ever hold me?"

The room went still. Neela had read her page to her in the shed, with Pavi at her shoulder, and Kamalakshi had stood in the sun afterwards for a long time and then eaten two bowls of rice without a word. She had a girl's face still, and she was asking a plain question, as if the answer would be a floor she could stand on.

Neela said the rule as she had learned it, word for word, because anything else would be a lie in a kind coat.

"A page held by its own subject cannot be read against her by anyone else."

Kamalakshi nodded slowly. "Anyone else."

"Anyone."

It sat right. It was the same answer Ammu had given her in the straw, and Neela watched it settle into the room and take. Yet something under it rang wrong, like the eleventh step of the west stair, where her foot had come down and found a hollow. A page, a reading, a voice. She turned it over once. There was a gap in it somewhere, and she could not name the shape of what was missing.

She let it lie. The room had moved on.

"I'll say one more thing," Vellan said, from the door.

He had not spoken all morning. He stood with his shoulder on the frame and the pale wood bird gone from his hand, because Kamalakshi had it. He looked tired and old and very large.

"A gorge wants a wall," he said. "I'm a wall. I'm no use on a palace stair, and no use to a sneak, and no use at all with my leg to a woman who needs to be quiet." He rubbed his jaw. "I go where I'm useful. I go to the gorge. Don't ask me to like the stair."

Nobody did.

"Hands, then," Neela said.

She said it before Devan could, and he did not look as if he minded. In front of forty others, neither of them said husband, or warden, or master. Neither had those words left. They had been handed the same two words, *vote* and *hands*, and they used them.

"Those who say the whole Company holds the narrows, and none goes south."

She counted. Twenty hands. Devan's was among them, steady and open, and he did not look at her as it rose.

"Those who say a party goes south for the thirty, and the rest hold the narrows."

She counted twice. Twenty-two. One person had not raised a hand either time, and it was Thulasi, who was looking at her knees.

Neela put her own hand up for that one, and kept it there, and felt it shake.

"Carried," said Thilak, rough. "By two."

Nobody cheered. Pavi let out a breath and put her forehead on the heel of her curled left hand. On the far side of the plank, Devan folded his arms and looked at the ash, where his short bar and Neela's cliff sat eleven inches apart.

*

They sorted the rest in a quarter hour, because there was no time to do it slowly.

Six would go. Neela, because she had asked and knew the lanes of that city, or thought she might. Pavi, because the thirty were hers in a way Neela was only learning. Thilak, who said he would go with a face like a man swallowing a nail, because he had twenty-two years of knowing what a master looked like and the guard would trust it. Madhavi, because she distrusted the whole plan and would catch a lie in it. Kuttu, because he could carry. Meenu, because she asked, and had never asked for anything before.

The resin came last, and was nearly a quarrel.

"The gorge is cold and long," said Kamalakshi. "Thirty-six hold it. They'll need every pinch."

"The stair is a dark stair," said Pavi, "and a palace hasn't got the cover of a wood."

"The noon gun's daylight."

"The night after it isn't."

Neela raised a hand. "Even, as before. Every pinch the same. The six carry theirs in a leaf. Nobody takes a double for a good reason, because everyone has a good reason." She let them look at one another. "Hands."

The count came out thirty-six pinches for the gorge and six for the road. Devan took none, and nobody mentioned it. She wrote the marks on the plank herself, and Thilak cut the cup. Meenu, who had cried over a roll leaf in the Resin House, laughed out loud for no reason anyone could name. It ran through the room like a spilled dish. For a moment they were only people eating and arguing in the rain's last week, with their heads full of ships.

*

Devan found her on the slab at the edge of the turf, with the lamp-black plank lashed on her knees and a coil of Thilak's twine in her hands.

The mist had cleared to the edge of the thorn. Down past the last ridge the sea was a long pewter bar, and the smoke over Pazhayangadi had thinned to a thread. A packhorse stamped somewhere behind the shelter. Someone swore at it in a rude song.

He sat down on the stone beside her, a hand's width off. For a while he said nothing.

"I voted against you," he said.

"I know." She did not look up from the knot. "I counted your hand."

"I counted yours." A pause, dry as chaff. "You voted for yourself."

"Somebody had to."

He made a sound she had heard him make three times: low, in his chest, hardly a laugh. "Pavi was almost sorry for me, I thought. She doesn't look at me like that."

"She looks at you like a wall she's decided to like."

"That's worse."

"It's the same."

Neela drew the twine tight, and the plank went flat against its backing, and she sat with her hands on it. The fisherman's hitch looked back at her.

"I didn't think you'd lose it so well," he said.

"I didn't think you'd lose it at all." She looked at him then. "The minute it went against you, you stayed in your seat with your hand where I could see it."

"I told them I'd keep to it."

"I know what you told them. I wondered what it would cost."

"Four days," said Devan, and the dryness went out of his voice as if a hand had closed on it. "You'll be on the road to Kodiyur and I'll be in the narrows. If a spear opens me there, you'll know it sitting in an inn with a cup in your hand."

"And if a stair finds me, you'll know it with a sword in yours."

"Yes."

Neither of them said the rest. It was in the plain facts: they had chosen, in front of the others, to put a hundred miles of country between two bodies that could not be hurt apart. It would have been simpler to stay. It would have been simpler to tell the room.

"One question each," Neela said, "and no passes."

"That's not the rule."

"I'm changing it. You first."

He considered the sea. "Did you want me to say no?" he asked. "When you stood up. Did you want me to take it, and say I'd come with you, and leave the narrows to Vellan?"

"Yes."

He took that without moving.

"And I'd have hated you for it by the second day," she said. "I wanted you to offer, so I could be the one to refuse. Does that make sense?"

"It does." A breath. "Your turn."

She turned the plank over in her hands.

"Ammu would have told me not to go," she said. "She thought being unseen was the only safe thing in the world. She might have been right, for her. If the thirty don't want it—if they've been given a comfortable cage and a green sash and told it's mercy—" She stopped. "Do I have the right to walk in and open the door?"

He did not answer quickly. He had a habit, which she had learned, of answering a hard question only after he had held it a full breath.

"No," he said. "You have the right to *ask*. That's different. If you ask and they say no, then you walk out and leave a lamp." The corner of his mouth was crooked again. "I learned it from someone who counts servants."

Her face went hot, and she looked away at the sea. Four days at a hard ride. The noon gun. The sea stair.

*Usha's sentence.* She had said it in the council, and called it thin, and the room had still given her the vote. Now it sat in her head with noth-

ing around it. Where did the stair start? Which side of the rock? Did it have a gate, a hunter, a drain? Was it one stair or a dozen, cut into the face of the cliff? She had walked the lanes behind the Kodiyur fish market once with a stick of cinnamon in her pocket and a dead man's name in her mouth. She had never seen the palace except as a pale shape from the quay.

And the only one who had given them the stair was the queen's own woman. If the sentence was a snare, it would be a good one, and a map drawn from it would be worse. Pavi would not know. Thilak would not know. Whatever Neela built on it, she could not check it against anything.

One person alive could. One person had sold the crown thirty pages over twenty years and must have carried them through that house himself, up whatever stairs the house had. He knew the doors, and the sound each one made, and the hour the guard changed.

Chathu.

She had last seen him gagged against the dusk, a soft grey man with an uneven foot and a stare like a ledger. After the assize Rema had ordered him south in a closed cart, with her roll, to wait for the high court. Neela had watched the cart go. Then Usha had said that a cell's post at Kettamala ended in the queen's household, and that the leaf slept in the queen's room. A man the household could read was a man the household could keep. He was under the palace rock, then, or near it. She could not be sure. But if she was right, he was the one man who had climbed the stairs she meant to climb.

She sat with the plank in her hands and the sea in front of her, and remembered a tin of jaggery-sesame sweets, still warm, sitting on a gatepost.

*A gift is the start of a bill.* Twelve tins, and then a thirteenth. Every kindness of his had come with a ledger line.

"What is it?" said Devan.

He had seen it. Of course he had.

"Nothing yet," she said. She had never lied to him since the night she told him about the other one. She did not lie now. She said, "I've found the hole in it."

"Tell me."

She looked at him, at the grey in his hair, the seven pale scars across a right hand that would be four days of road away from her by the end of the week.

"Not yet," Neela said. "Let me see whether I can bear it."

## Chapter 4

# Walls Only

The bay went over the lip with his forelegs folded, and his scream came back off the rock a breath after.

Neela had the rope. Everyone near the first bad place had the rope. It ran from a thorn stump through Thilak's fists and round Devan's back, and it burned through Neela's palm before she knew she had closed it. Down on the scree the horse found his feet. Kuttu laughed once, high and cracked, and then there was only the sound of forty-three people breathing hard.

"Next," Devan said.

His voice was level. A red line was rising across the palm of his right hand. The matching sting in her own palm throbbed, and neither of them mentioned it.

Rema's escort had strung three ropes on the goat path, in the dark, on the night they climbed to Kettamala. Neela had hated them for it. Now she could have kissed each knot. The first place was the lip. The second was a chimney of loose laterite where the horses went down on their haunches and the people went down on their backs. The third was the thorn shoulder above the old well, where the path narrowed to a foot's width with air on the left.

She counted all of it. Forty-one steps to the first rope. Nineteen horses, borrowed from the pass villages with a promise written on a tally stick. Two hundred and six breaths on the chimney. She counted the five

who would go south with her, too: Pavi, Thilak, Madhavi, Kuttu, Meenu. They were meant to peel off at the fort by first light and take the sea road to Kodiyur. She watched each of them over the rope, one by one, like coins she could not afford to lose.

At the third place Madhavi stood with her back to the drop, talking to a grey mare in a low steady stream. It was a made-up song about turnips. The mare walked down it.

Vellan went last of the people. He took the third rope one-handed, his bad leg dragging, and said nothing the whole way down. Thilak waited at the bottom with a hand out. Vellan looked at it for a moment. Then he took it.

They slept one night under the thorn, with no resin and no fire. Devan walked the line twice in the dark. The second time he stopped by Neela's blanket, said nothing, and put his hand flat on the stone beside her head. She put hers over it. His palm was hot and raw. So was hers.

In the morning the langurs were gone quiet.

She heard the silence on the long last slope, with the roofs of the lower village a smudge below. Every day for months the troops had barked their warnings off the gorge wall, a racket she'd learned to sleep through. Now the cliff gave back only the wind. Devan had stopped before she had. He stood with his head turned toward the cart road, which lay out of sight past the shoulder.

"Strangers," she said.

"On the road." He started walking again. "Walk faster."

*

Kettamala came up out of the red hill at dusk, the laterite walls the colour of old blood. Neela felt her shoulders loosen before she could stop them. She had never wanted to come back to this place. She had married into it with a leopard's tooth sewn in her waistband.

The padippura gate stood shut. A horn sounded from the wall: one long note and two short, the code for unarmed strangers, not many. It

was Bhaskaran's horn, and Bhaskaran's lungs, and it was the least welcoming music she had ever loved.

The wicket opened. Muthu came out alone.

He was the same big, broad man, with a grin already on his face and his arms already wide. "Fort's open! Come and be fed, you thieves, you walking disasters, you—" His eye went down the line of forty-three strangers, the lamp-black plank on its packhorse, Vellan at the back with his hood up. The grin held for a count of three and then it slid off.

The iron seal hung on a cord at his belt, a disc cut with a hill and a gate. Eleven wardens had worn it. It looked wrong on him, as a borrowed coat does.

"Devan," he said.

"Muthu."

"You look terrible."

"I've been told."

Muthu laughed, short, and the laugh did not last. He took a folded paper from his sleeve instead. Green wax, with a sunbird pressed deep. "I'd rather you heard it from me than from the wall."

"Read it to them, Muthu. They should hear it too."

Muthu held the paper at arm's length, like a man holding a snake by the neck.

"*Kettamala shall hold its walls only. The garrison shall make no sally beyond the padippura. The garrison shall harbour no rogue, unvouched, or odiyan under pain of the crown's displeasure.*" He lowered it. "It's signed by the queen's household, not by her. I'd like to tell you that makes a difference."

"Does it?"

"It makes me feel better."

Behind Neela somebody drew a short sharp breath. She did not turn. She was the rogue. They were all the rogue, forty-two of the Company, standing on the road with their own free names on a plank. Muthu knew it. His eyes passed over her face without catching, the way a man's do when he has decided not to look at a thing.

His mouth had gone flat. She watched it. This was not the stillness of his lying. She'd learned that tell from Devan, and she knew it. This was the other quiet, the one in which a man stands between two doors and holds his breath.

"The lower court is the garrison's yard," Muthu said at last, to the air above their heads. "Drovers pass through it on their way up to the pass in a season like this. Drovers with horses, who want feeding. Nobody's put a drover on the rolls in my time. I'll not start tonight."

It was a hole in a wall, and a narrow one. Devan inclined his head.

"Thank you."

"Don't." Muthu turned, and the gate swung wide. "I'm not doing it for you."

*

Janu fed them as if she were feeding a wedding.

Neela had not known there could be so much rice in one place. It came out of the kitchen in cauldrons carried by a line of girls and Chinna with her bad hip, and it spread across the lower court under the wall in the last of the light. There was curd. There was a fish stew that smelled of tamarind and made Meenu cry before she had tasted it. Janu stood in the middle of it all in a stained white mundu, scolding everyone she could reach.

"Sit. You, sit. Not there, there's a drain. Eat."

Neela held out a hand for a bowl.

Janu put it down on the stone beside her.

She did it quickly, and kindly, and she did not look away. It was only that her fingers had stayed on the rim, and the rim stayed between them. Her right hand was wrapped in a cloth, and she said that was a burn from the pot. The bandage was clean, and the burn was not fresh. Neela marked that, and the way Janu's eyes dropped, once, to the plain gold bangle at her wrist, and came up again.

*She kissed me on the forehead before we left.* On the forehead, then, and not the hand. Neela knew what that meant. She had stood at the

foot of the west stair and told this woman about the hands that had held the lamp that morning, and the hands that had found the body. Janu had forgiven what she could carry. A hand taking a bowl from Neela's was more than she could carry yet.

It hurt, and it was fair. Neela did not ask. She bent and lifted the bowl off the stone herself, so Janu would not have to hand it over twice.

"Eat," Janu said, and went away to scold someone else.

The well stood at the north end of the court, with its low coping and a ring of wet stones. Neela had walked past it sixty times as a bride. Now she saw that it was ringed with people.

Not garrison. Women, mostly, with a cloth spread under each cluster and a child or two asleep on bundles. There were about thirty of them, and they sat in the exact posture of people who had been told to wait and had not yet been told for what.

She took her bowl across to them. Devan watched her go, and did not follow.

"Sit," said a stout woman with a baby, and moved a bundle for her. "You're the warden's wife."

"Neela."

"Chellam. My man tapped toddy on the Kalladi road till the raiders came up the coast." The baby spat. "We got out. That one nearly didn't."

Neela asked who else, and was told, one by one: Gouri, whose mother was somewhere on the road still; a carter's widow who gave no name but gave her a rice cake; an old man called Saroja's father, who wasn't Saroja's father at all but liked to say so, because Saroja sang at the pass-village well and he was proud of it. Neela said each name once under her breath. They went into her like pegs into a board.

She had reached the far side of the well when she saw the small face.

Minnu, six years old, with a rag doll under her chin and a smear of curd on her lip. Beside her sat a thin woman with a cough, holding a nine-year-old boy's hand in both her own.

Parukutty looked up and knew her at once.

"My lady," she said, and began to stand.

"Don't." Neela put out a hand, palm down, as if to a goat. "Please. I'm only eating."

Parukutty sat. "The pass-village men told us the Thurai were two days off. We left our house last night."

Chandu stared at Neela's bandaged left hand. "Is it true my father's spot is in the gorge?"

"Yes," she said. She had never lied to a child, and she wasn't going to begin now. "The warden's going to stand there."

Chandu thought about this. "All by himself?"

She looked across the court. Devan stood at the foot of the wall with a bowl he wasn't eating, talking to Thilak, the grey in his hair gone silver under the torches. He had no seal, no office, no men beyond the ones the road had given him.

"No," Neela said. "Not by himself."

*

Muthu came for them after the bowls were stacked.

He led them up the east stair, not the west. Neela noticed, and said nothing. He took them through the long dark of the gate chamber and shut the door behind them, and only then did he drop onto the bench under the arrow slit like a man who had been holding a wall up with his back.

"I can't do it," he said.

"I know," said Devan.

"Don't *know*. Argue." Muthu rubbed his face with both hands. "Sixty men on the rolls. I can order them to sit on a wall, and I have. I can't order them out of it. Half of them are Bhaskaran's lads with mothers in the lower village, and none of them has seen an army." He looked up. "I keep my oath to the border. I swore it, on this iron, with you standing there. But I can't hand the garrison to a man who has no office, not even if it's you. They'd follow me, and they'd be hanged for it, and the pass would still fall."

"I haven't asked you to."

"No. You haven't." Muthu's mouth twisted. "That's what makes it hard."

Neela stood against the door and counted its hinges. Three. Devan did not argue. Then he laid his palm flat on the table, with the rope-burn red across it, and said:

"Then I won't ask tonight."

Muthu's eyes closed. "Ask me again," he said, "when you have a reason I can write down. A writ, a count of ships. A thing the high court would read and not laugh at. I'll hold the pass for you, Devan. I'll hold it with a pen if I can't hold it with a spear."

"I'll bring you one."

"Don't bring me a speech."

"I never have."

Muthu laughed, finally, a rough bark. Then he stood and went to the door. He stopped with his hand on it, not looking at Neela.

"Janu's put the cloth on the south bed," he said. "I wasn't told. If anyone asks I've given the warden's guests a roof for one night as a courtesy to the border."

"Guests," said Devan.

"For one night. It's all the word will stretch to."

*

The guest room off the south range was the one Rema's escort had used. Someone had swept it and put fresh straw in the corners, and left a lamp. There was one bed, with a clean cloth on it.

Neela checked the door. One door, and the window on the north side, at a drop she liked. She sat on the end of the bed and unwound her wrap.

He did not come in at once. He stood at the doorway with his shoulder against the frame and looked across the court.

The warden's chamber was at the end of the north range, up its own stair. From here she could see only the stair door at the top, shut, with

one thin line of lamplight under it. Muthu slept there now, in the bed that had been Devan's. Devan did not look at the door. He looked at the well, at the sleeping women, at the dark where the horses were tethered. He looked everywhere except at that line of light, like a man walking round a hole in a floor.

"You haven't looked at your door," Neela said. "Not once. Why?"

"I won't answer that."

He said it flat and quick, and she let it lie. They'd made the rule. One pass each, once in a life, and she'd spent hers on the worst question she could think of. He had a right to his. She turned and started on the knot of her sash.

Behind her, the doorframe creaked as he shifted.

"I miss the creak," he said.

She stopped.

"The third slat. Of the shutter." He was not looking at her. He had his hand on the wood of the frame, and his voice sounded as if it had been handed to him in the dark and he was reading it by feel. "For six years I slept with my back to the wall and listened for something at that window. Then you came, and it was you. I heard it every night. The slat, and then the sill, and then nothing." His thumb moved. "And at dawn it creaked again, and I knew you were home."

"I pressed it on purpose," Neela said. "The first night. To see if you'd wake."

"I know."

"You didn't."

"I was awake."

"I *know*, Devan." It came out less dry than she meant. She got up, crossed the straw and stood in front of him. He still hadn't turned. "I was a thief in your house for forty days, and I rang a bell on your window every night."

"It was the best sound in the fort."

She took his rope-burned hand. She did not hold it carefully, and her own palm stung where it lay against his. He let out a breath that was almost a laugh.

"You told me you wouldn't answer."

"I know what I said." He looked down at her then. "I thought you ought to have it anyway. That's all I've got that's not a plan."

She did not say anything clever. She stood with his burned palm pressed to hers, raw against raw, and put her forehead against his collar. It was a poor sort of home. It was the only one she'd chosen.

*

She woke to red.

It lay across the ceiling in a long shaking bar. She was on her feet before she had finished the thought, with a borrowed knife in her hand. She'd given hers away in a different life.

The beacon on the shoulder had gone up.

Bhaskaran's lads laid it each dry season, a stack of resin pine on the hill edge below the lightning boulder, to be lit if anything came up the gorge. A pass-village boy sat watch beside it. She had never seen it burn. Now it blazed, orange and wide, in the black square of the north window. Beyond it, at the foot of the gorge, a second smaller flame winked and went out, and winked again.

A horn started on the wall. Bhaskaran's. It began a long note.

Devan was already at the door.

He'd taken a spear from the rack by the lintel, one of Bhaskaran's, left as a courtesy and not a gift. His boots were on. He moved with his shoulder turned from her, fast and quiet, the way he did everything that mattered. He didn't mean to go without telling her. He meant to be in the court before the horn finished, and tell her from there. She had watched him decide things that way for forty days.

She dropped the knife on the bed, crossed the room in three steps and caught his wrist.

He stopped, half through the door.

"Tell me before you go," Neela said.

The horn ended. In the quiet, she could hear the cistern chain clank once on the wheel, and the long dull roar of the fire on the hill.

Devan turned in the doorway with the spear in his left hand. His wrist was hot in her fingers. Behind him the lower court was filling with faces.

"The advance guard," he said, quick and low. "They're in the gorge already. Three days was wrong. I'm going to the boulder. I've no leave, and I've no seal, and I've a Company I can ask." His throat moved. "I'm asking you first."

It hit her chest like a dropped stone. Not the order. The asking.

Five people were sleeping in the south range who were meant to be on the sea road by first light. Thirty pages lay in a queen's room four days away, and every hour spent in the gorge was an hour off the stair. Neela let that cost stand in her mouth for one breath. Then she let go of his wrist.

"Then I'm coming," she said, and turned back to the bed, her hand already out for the knife.

Beyond the window, the second flame in the gorge winked out again, and did not come back.

## Chapter 5

# The Lightning Boulder

Corporal Kandan came over the wall without leave, and he brought nine men to prove it.

Devan heard them before he saw them, ten sets of boots on the cart road above the boulder. They did not hide. They came down from the dark with spears held crosswise and the beacon burning orange on their faces. Kandan walked in front, the scar through his brow bright as a split in wood.

Devan waited in the road with a borrowed spear and no seal. He felt every inch of that.

"Sir," Kandan said.

"Not tonight." Devan kept his voice level. "Muthu didn't send you."

"Muthu told us to sit on the wall. We sat on it till the beacon went. Then we got down off the other side." Kandan's jaw worked. "He'll be shouting by now."

"I won't order you to stay."

"I know you won't. That's why we came."

Behind Devan, the scree shifted with a long, soft, shingling noise, like rain on a roof of loose slate. Thirty-six shapes lay along the slope above the lightning boulder, low and still, their eyes catching the fire. They had slipped behind the rocks while the nine were still on the stair. Devan had asked them first, in the lower court, and every hand had gone up before

he finished the question. At his right shoulder stood a spotted shape with a long tail that moved once, slowly, against his knee.

He didn't look at it. He looked at the nine.

"I'll say what I mean to do," he said. "Then you'll tell me yes or no. I'll take no. Anyone who goes home tonight goes home with my thanks."

Kandan's eyes flicked past him to the scree and came back. He said nothing. He had called Neela a witch to her face once, at a barracks door, the week Raiu burned. Devan did not ask him to take it back.

Devan drew the gorge in the dust with the spear butt. "Twenty-odd men, an advance guard. They came faster than I thought. I was wrong about three days. There's a picket where the cart road narrows, here. And somewhere along the lip a man holds a bronze mirror. At first sun he answers the ships, and the ships learn the road is open."

"Somewhere?" Sankaran said.

"The lip is half a mile of scree. Too long a front to search before dawn." He glanced up the slope. "If the mirror stays dark, whoever commands the ships has to decide whether to land the rest into a gorge that's gone quiet. It buys a day. I need a day."

"And if he flashes?" Vasu asked. He was the young one with ducks for a mother. Devan knew that because Neela had written it on a roof tile, and he had read the tile twice.

"Then we've lost the pass. So ten of you hold the road at the cut, with spears, and nobody chases past the boulder. I want one of them alive, to talk."

"You want us to hold a road while they go up a hill," said Sankaran. "Alone."

"I want you to hold it with me."

Nobody spoke. On the hill the beacon popped and threw a spark.

"Behind me are things you were told not to look at," Devan said. "They're on your side. Face the road. If you turn round, you may carry what you see for the rest of your life, and so may they. I'd rather you never did."

Kandan stared at him. Then he grounded the butt of his spear in the road and said, quite slowly, "Raiu held the stair at your door."

"Yes."

"You sent him for oil."

"Yes."

"I'd have asked you why, if you'd come back to the wall to be asked." Kandan's mouth twisted. "I'll hold your road."

One at a time, the others grounded their spears. Sankaran. Kuttan, who could not write and had had a letter written for his mother. Vasu, last of the three he knew, and then six more. Devan said each name aloud as the butt struck stone. He had never learned the names of ten men in an hour before. He had a woman with a lamp-black plank to thank for it.

Kandan turned his back on the scree. The rest followed.

Devan bent his head toward the spotted shape. "The lip," he said, very low. "Look. Don't take him yet."

She went up the scree without a sound, and the dark closed over her.

The bear had come down the slope to Devan's left side. It was breathing through its nose.

*

The picket stood where the road pinched between the rock and the drop. He was a short man in a dark coat with one hand on a fire-basket he had not lit, and he looked toward the beacon, not toward the boulder. They had not yet learned to look behind.

Devan walked out of the dark into the orange light with the spear low, where the man could see it.

"Kettamala holds this road," he said, in the coast tongue every trader half-spoke.

The picket's head came round. His hand left the basket and went to his hilt.

Eight years was a long time to keep a rule. He had sworn on the west stair never to hold a throat. He had no oath about this, and that was the

worst of it. There was only the spear in his hands, and the road, and the choice.

He knew a hundred places on a man's body. He knew the door under the skull, and the notch below the ear. He turned the point away from every one of them.

The thrust went in under the collarbone, high and to the side, where it would bleed and hurt and kill nobody if the man was lucky. It pinned the coat to the rock behind him. The picket cried out, short and furious, and Devan let go of the shaft before the man's knife came up.

It came up anyway, from a second man he had not seen, crouched in the lee of the basket. The edge went across Devan's right forearm, a hot thin line. He took the second man's wrist in his left hand and turned it until the knife dropped, and the bear came out of the dark past his hip like a landslide.

It did not kill. It put the man down and stood on him. That was all.

Devan stood with blood running into his palm and the picket pinned beside him, groaning. He had struck first, openly, on a stranger's road, with nobody's life on the edge of it but his own choice. He felt it down to the soles of his feet, and what he felt was not shame.

Behind him, Kandan said hoarsely, "That was clean."

"It was meant to be."

The bear's flank pressed warm against his left side. The thing that had killed his sister, and Raiu, kept the dark off him. Devan did not move away. He had decided that on the hill above the Resin House. Deciding it again was harder.

*

The bear's head swung toward the thorn before Devan heard anything. A low rumble ran through its ribs.

"You've taken the door man," said a voice from the scrub. "That's the smaller half of the work."

Every spear came round. Devan raised his hand, and they stopped.

The man who came out of the thorn was old and bent, in a grey wrap, with a staff he did not seem to need. He kept to the edge of the firelight and held his empty hands out from his sides. He smelled of woodsmoke and dried fish.

"Koman," he said. "From the village above the gorge. I walked the hill edge for the Resin House eleven years, reading posts that weren't mine to name. The House has not paid me since the wood fell, three moons back." He sniffed, a long dry dig of the nose. "My nose is nobody's. I thought I might offer it to somebody."

Devan looked at him. A watcher. The man who had logged Neela's bare nights and carried them to Chathu. He could say it, and it would be fair. He could also see a thin man who had stood in the rain for three moons with nothing coming, and who had walked down a dark road to a stranger's spear.

"What does it tell you?"

Koman turned his face up into the wind off the coast. His eyes were half shut. "Twenty-three men, counting the two you hold. Twenty below the bend, sweating the long sweat of men who've marched three days. Fish, tar, unwashed wool." He stopped. "One more, not on the road. Up the lip, left of the cut. Cold sweat, and brass. A man holding a thing he's afraid to drop."

"Your mirror," Vasu breathed.

"What do you want for it?" Devan said.

"The House's wage. Seven panam to the moon." The old man smiled thinly. "I do not expect it."

"You'll have it. From my pocket, not the crown's. I've no office to pay you from, so it's my word." Devan held out his hand, palm up, cut and bleeding. "It's cheaper than coin."

"I've found it holds better," Koman said, and put his dry hand in the blood and shook.

Devan turned his head toward the scree, not his body. "Left of the cut," he said. "Alive, if you can."

The slope breathed out, and thirty-five shapes went up into the black.

*

The slope was empty.

Devan could not see them. He could hear them: the slide of loose stone, a pad of paws, then nothing. A good deal of nothing. He stood in the road with Kandan at his right and the dead basket cold in front of him, and counted. Six hundred. He had set the number in his head at the boulder, because dawn would not wait for a man to feel ready. The sky over the pass went from black to the colour of wet slate.

At first sun the mirror would flash. At first sun, too, every odiyan on that hill would stop being what she was, in plain sight of anyone who looked up. He had thought that through at the boulder, and he'd asked no one to hurry. They knew.

Five hundred and forty. The east went from slate to pearl.

At five hundred and ninety the top of the cliff took a thread of gold. And on the lip, small and bright as a dropped coin, something winked.

It winked again, stuttering, half uncovered. Devan's hands shut on the spear. Six hundred. His count ran out, and the glint was still there, swinging toward the sea.

Then it went out.

The lip stayed dark. The gold crept down the rock above it and found nothing to strike. There was a short grunting cry up there, a clink of metal on stone, and a hush that went on too long. The spear shaft was slipping in his sweating palm. He set the butt on the road to keep hold of it, and started breathing again.

Nothing flashed. A little while later a soft chuffing came down off the scree, and a scrape, and a leopard came out of the shingle with something wrapped in leather held in her jaws. She walked up to Devan and set it at his feet.

It was a bronze disc, the size of a plate, wrapped in oiled hide. He turned it over. On the back, scratched small and neat beside the handle, was a bird with its wings folded.

He did not know what he was seeing. He put his thumb over it, and put the mirror in his belt.

The leopard sat down against his leg. Her flank was shaking. The sky behind her turned gold at the edge.

"Face the road," Devan said. "All of you. Now."

*

They came down from the cold light on two legs, in the cloths he had brought on Kuttu's packhorse and left wrapped behind the boulder. He heard the rustle and the muttering and Meenu's laugh, shaky and surprised. He did not turn his head. Kandan kept his eyes on the road and the veins stood in his neck.

When Devan did turn, it was because he heard a heavy tread on rock.

Vellan sat on the lightning boulder, wrapped in a grey blanket, his bad leg stretched out and his big hands hanging between his knees. His face was grey and old and very tired. He was looking at Devan, who had not asked him to look.

"The lad on the road," Vellan said. "Your corporal. He's the one who stood with Raiu."

"Yes."

"I could smell the grief on him." The big man's mouth shifted. "I'll not ask him to forgive me. I'd not ask you."

"Don't."

"No." Vellan rubbed his jaw. The gorge wind lifted the edge of his blanket. "She said something, your sister," he said. "At the end."

The spear slid from Devan's hand and rang on the stone.

He had waited six years for any word. He had a drawer of notes in a camphor chest and a slate with Unni's name on it. He had never had her voice, her last sentence, the one sound that was not in a box. And the man who had it was sitting on a rock in a blanket.

"Say it," he said. His voice did not sound like his.

"When I've earned saying it."

"You don't get to set a price on my sister's words."

"I'm not setting it on you." Vellan's eyes did not waver. "I'm setting it on me. I'll tell you when I've earned the right, and not before. If I'm dead first, I'll find a way."

Devan stood with his fists shut. He could have forced it. There were a dozen ways to force a man. He opened his hands.

"Then earn it," he said, and turned his back, because that was the only answer he could give.

*

His forearm had opened while he wasn't thinking. The sleeve was dark and stiff to the wrist.

"Sit," said Neela.

She had come up beside him in a cloth the colour of dust, her hair wet at the temples. She had a new bruise on her cheekbone and a look he knew, tired and amused and furious all at once. She held out her right arm. Along the outside of the forearm, red and raised and weeping at the edge, ran a thin shallow line.

"Third thing I felt on the lip," she said. "I had the mirror man's wrist in my teeth when you took that knife. I nearly dropped him."

"You didn't."

"I nearly did." She dropped to her knees on the stone and took his arm. "Sit, Devan."

There were ten men within five paces. Kandan had half turned. Vasu was staring, Sankaran had an elbow in Vasu's ribs, and old Koman leaned on his staff with his head tilted like a bird's. Devan had been taught how to take a wound. Take it alone. Wrap it behind a door. Let nobody see you need the cloth.

He sat down on the stone.

Neela tore a strip from the hem of her cloth. She cleaned the cut with water from Kandan's gourd, which Kandan had held out without being asked. Her hands were quick and rough and did not tremble. She wound the strip twice and tied it, and her thumb pressed once, hard, on the knot.

"It will stay," she said.

"It will."

She stood. She did not go back to the others. She walked to Kandan with the gourd in her hand, the man who had called her witch at a barracks door, and held it out to him.

"Kandan," she said.

Aloud. His name, and nothing else. Sankaran stopped breathing. Vasu's grin went out of his face.

Kandan looked at the gourd, and at her. He took it. He did not look away. He turned it once in his scarred hands, and said one word.

"Neela."

It was all he said. Devan watched Sankaran lower his eyes from the pair of them, and then lift them again, and not look at his boots. Not one of the nine turned from her.

"Done," Neela said, and went to stand at Devan's shoulder.

*

The man from the road sat propped against the rock with a rag stuffed under his collarbone, grey-faced, glaring. Koman had named him in a murmur: a sergeant, going by the cord at his shoulder. Devan crouched in front of him with the bleeding arm resting on his knee.

"You'll live," he said, in the coast tongue. "If the wound is kept clean. I'd like to know what you came for."

The sergeant spat. Then he looked at the bandage, and at the woman standing at Devan's shoulder, and at the old man with the staff. Perhaps it was the fact that nobody had yet hit him again.

"Cutting-saws," he said at last, thick-tongued. "Mortar lime. Barley for seed. Not for burning."

"For what?"

"For the hills." The man shifted. "The admiral's orders were plain. Take the pepper hills and hold them through the dry season. Not strip them. *Hold* them. We were told to leave the vines standing, and the villages that gave way."

Devan did not move. He had spent three days bracing for a raid, for fire on the coast and a quick hard push up the gorge. A raid came and went. It went back down to the ships with what it carried.

This one had come with seed.

"Hold them against whom?" Neela said quietly, in the same tongue.

"Against whoever comes." The sergeant looked up at her. "Your queen is a sensible woman. We were told she would not come."

Nobody on the road said a word. Kandan's face had gone white under the scar, and behind him the first sun cleared the east wall and fell full on the stones.

"Then they don't go home in spring," said Vasu, very small.

Devan looked down the gorge to the sea. It was forty paces wide at the mouth. He had ten men, an old nose, thirty-six who changed with the dark, and a day.

## Chapter 6

# Lantana

The resin was thinner than lentil water, and Neela spread it as if it were gold.

Thilak had coaxed it out of the three noon trees before the Company left the shelter. One finger-width for each pair of wrists, and not a drop to waste. She tipped the pinch the Company had voted her onto two fingers and set them against the scars at her throat. The old burn woke at once. She breathed through it, and smeared the inside of each wrist, and slid the plain gold bangle up her forearm out of the way.

Dusk was coming down the gorge like water poured into a bowl. Below the lightning boulder, Kandan's nine stood on the cart road with their backs to her and their spears grounded. Nobody had told them to face away tonight. They did it anyway.

Devan sat on the foot of the boulder, with Kannan's white pebble in his cheek.

"Say it back," he said. It came out round and slow, as if he were talking through a plum. He had never once complained of it.

"You sound like Muthu with a cold."

"Say it back."

"Count what I can. Tents, horse lines, anything with wheels. Don't fight. Don't stop to be clever." She tied off the thought with a count of her own, three breaths. "Be at the cache by grey."

"And?"

"And if I smell your mirror man's friends, I run."

"You count first."

"I'll count while running."

His mouth moved around the pebble. It was not quite a smile, but it was kin to one.

She looked at the stone in his cheek. Once it had been the one thing standing between her and a cage. A sleeping man says things, and Devan had seen her turn. Now there was no cage left to open. Since the night at the Resin House, nobody could close one on her without her own voice beside theirs. The pebble was only a habit now, the way you keep a door propped that no longer sticks.

"You don't need it," she said.

"I know." He shifted it with his tongue. "I like having something in my mouth that isn't an opinion."

Muthu had asked for a thing he could write down. A count of ships was no use from a leopard's mouth, but a count of tents was. Pavi and the others would go south as soon as the gorge let them. Tonight there were numbers to fetch.

She pulled her sash off over her head and laid it with the day cloth in the crack under the boulder, where the stone made a dry shelf. Then she stood in the last of the light and let the burn climb.

It always began in the wrists. The skin went tight and hot, and then her spine remembered it was a rope. She dropped to her hands. Her ribs bent. The ground came up, and with it the smell of the whole hill, a hundred things at once, one of them Devan. He had not looked away. He never had.

A warm hand rested between her ears for the space of one breath.

Then she was gone down the road, low and quick, with the dusk in her mouth.

*

The coast road ran downhill all the way, and the dark ran with it.

She kept to the verge. A leopard on a cart road is a rumour, and a rumour is better than a sighting. She passed a burned byre, then a well with its rope cut, then a village that was only a smell of wet ash and a dog gone feral in the ruins. It watched her go by with its ribs showing and did not bark.

The sea wind blew inland. It carried the camp up to her long before she saw it: tar, fish, wet wool, horse dung, cook-smoke and old sweat. It carried her own scent away, up the hill. She had come at the one angle that mattered. She had not planned it. Her body knew.

Then a second smell came across the first.

It was green and rank and slightly sweet. It was crushed leaf, with a sharpness under it like a bruise. She stopped in the middle of the road with one paw lifted.

Lantana.

She had hated that smell all her life. She had hated it in the Resin House yard where it grew along the drain, and again on the east path to the kalari. She had never known why. She had put it down to being a person who hated things.

It rose from a long slope of orange-and-pink flowers on the left of the road, and it was not a smell. It was a house with the door open. She did not remember a house. She stood very still in the road and understood that her body had been remembering one for twenty-one years.

*Nellimala.*

She had the name from a page. She had never had the place.

She put her paw down and went on.

*

The footings lay where the slope eased toward the shore. Low stone rectangles, thigh-high, dozens of them, laid out along what had once been lanes. Lantana had grown through every doorway. A cart's width of beaten earth ran down the middle, and the Thurai had made it theirs.

She went in on her belly through the flowers. She counted.

Sixty-three tents. They stood in rows, grey canvas pitched across the old hearths, some of them with a corner pegged to a threshold stone. Three horse lines ran down the far side of the lanes: twenty-two beasts, twenty-six, twenty-four. Two sentries stood at the track end with their backs to a fire-basket, talking about a woman in some other port. A third sat asleep against a barley sack. There were forty or fifty sacks stacked under a hide roof. Seed, then. The sergeant had told the truth.

At the south end of the camp a frame rose out of the dark.

It stood three men high. Its ribs were ship timber, curved and still smelling of tar, and it had been bolted to a cart bed with iron straps. Two shaped planks were nailed along one side. Adzes had worked on it by lamplight, and the chips lay pale and fresh on the ground. It was not finished. It was a siege tower, and it was being built to stand against a gate.

*Kettamala's gate.* The padippura. She counted the rungs of its ladder: nine so far, with room for ten more. She made herself note the wheel hubs, and the greased axles, and the pegs where the hide screens would go. Muthu would want the pegs.

She was working her way along the lantana toward the horse lines when the wind brought her something else.

It came from a sleeper.

He lay on his back on a blanket by the tower's foot, outside any tent, with a cloak for a pillow and one arm flung wide. He was a lean man, no older than Devan. His sleeve had ridden up to the elbow. She was close enough to hear his breath whistle.

Salt. That came first. Then clove-bark, dry and sharp, cutting through the tar like a blade through cloth. It was a resin, she knew it as she knew her own hands, and it was fresh on his skin. It was not nightbark. Nightbark smelled of scorched tamarind and pine sap. This was something else, from some other tree, on some other coast.

She came forward a hand's breadth at a time until she could see his wrists.

The skin on the inside of each was ridged. Pale lines, laid over one another, old and thick. She knew the pattern as she knew her own face.

Hers looked like that. Ammu's had. Every girl in the Resin House had worn it.

*Who are you?*

She could not ask. She had no mouth for it. She could only lie in the flowers with her heart going like a fist on a door and know that if she woke him, there would be a shout, and the camp, and no more numbers. Dawn was hours off, and she could not turn back before it.

That was the rule. It had never bitten harder.

She memorised him. The long jaw, the clean-shaved chin, a ring on his left thumb. Then she backed out of the lantana, a hand's breadth at a time, and did not breathe until the horse lines had put forty paces between them.

*

The bank above the footings was her only shelter.

She went up it in a long loop and lay down in the lantana where it grew thickest, with her chin on her paws. The camp lay below her, a smear of low fires. The tower stood over it like a rib cage. Salt and clove still reached her, thin as a thread, though the wind had turned.

The grey was a long way off.

She could do nothing with the hours. She could not go back and she could not speak, and she could not tell the hill what she had seen. So she lay there with it, and the lantana filled her nose, and she let herself go on smelling it.

*I was here.*

She tried to find a door, and there was no door. She tried a wall, a hearth, the face of anyone. She had a hand's worth of sounds: someone knocking a net-weight against a post, and a woman's voice, low and cross. They might have been real. They might have been the tide.

Everything else had been taken at six years old. A cart. A rope. A blindfold. The Resin House had cleaned her out so thoroughly that she had never known what was missing.

*Indu.*

It was her name, and it meant nothing to her, and it was hers. Somewhere in this ruin, a woman had stood over a net in the dark and said it. It had been a good name. It had been said in a good voice.

She pressed her face into the earth.

A leopard cannot weep. She found that out lying in the dark above her village, with her whole body shaking and nothing coming out of her at all. She was mourning a place she could not picture. She was mourning people who had no faces. She thought she was a fool, and the thought did not help.

She stayed there until the sky began to grey.

*

The cache was where she had left it. She came down the last slope with her legs shaking under her, and she barely made the crack in the boulder before the dawn took her.

It always tore. She had come to expect that. It left her on all fours on the cold earth, with every muscle cramped and her stomach folded in on itself like a fist. The hunger came behind it, hollow and sick, and her hands would not stop trembling.

"Here."

Devan stood three paces off with his back to her, one arm held out behind him. Over it lay her day cloth. He had warmed it. She could feel the heat of it on her skin before she touched it. He must have carried it inside his coat all night.

She took it and wrapped herself. He turned.

He had a leaf packet in his other hand. Rice and curd, still faintly warm, folded tight. He put it in her lap without a word, sat down on the stone across from her and spat the white pebble into his palm.

"Eat," he said, in his own voice.

She ate. It was the best meal she had ever had, which she was beginning to think was true of all of them. When the packet was empty he took it from her fingers.

"Numbers first," she said. Her voice came out cracked. "Sixty-three tents. Horse lines of twenty-two, twenty-six, twenty-four. Three sentries on the track end, one asleep. Barley sacks, forty or fifty. A tower." She described it, rung by rung. He did not write. He said the figures back to her under his breath, once, and she saw them go into him like coins into a purse. "Muthu can have those."

"He can."

"There's more." She held the cloth closed at her throat. "A man by the tower. Sleeping. He had a resin on his wrists. Not nightbark." She found the words as she said them. "Salt and clove-bark. Sharp. And his wrists were scarred. Ridged, like mine."

Devan's face went still. It was not the stillness of a man hiding something. It was the stillness of one holding a very full cup.

"The same scars."

"The same kind. I don't know." She shook her head. "I couldn't ask him. I couldn't turn back. I lay there six hours with it in my head and no mouth to put it in."

"You have a mouth now."

"I know." It came out as a laugh and broke in the middle. "That's not all of it. That's not even the main thing."

She stopped. He waited. He did not fill the quiet with a question. After a moment, he moved a little closer, which was what she needed. She had not known it until he did it.

"It smelled like lantana," she said. "The whole slope. It's the smell I've hated since I was small, and I never knew why. It's my village, Devan. I walked down the road and my body knew it before I did." She pressed the heel of her hand against her eye. "I lay there all night and tried to remember one thing. One door. I couldn't. It's gone, and I'm grieving it, and I can't even say what I'm grieving. It's stupid."

"It isn't."

"It's a smell."

"It's a place." His voice was flat and level, and it was the kindest thing she'd heard in weeks. "I've had six years of a stair. It doesn't need a picture to be a loss."

She did not answer. She could not.

The lantana grew right up to the boulder's foot, a thick orange bank of it, bruised pink where the dew had settled. Devan looked at it. He did not say a single word about the Thurai, or the tower, or the scarred man. He leaned across, took a handful of leaves and crushed them in his fist. The sharp green reek rolled out over both of them.

He held his hand open between them, and breathed it in.

Then he slid down off the stone and sat beside her in the lantana, shoulder against shoulder, and did not try to make it better. The sun came up over the hills and found the two of them there. It did not seem to mind.

*

They walked up the cart road when the light was full.

Her legs held, mostly. His arm stayed close enough that she could have leaned, and she did not need to. She marked that, and put it away to think about later.

The nearest pass village lay where the road bent. It was one of the Monkey Pass villages, Kesu's among them, a handful of mud-and-thatch houses with a well in the middle. Refugees from the coast had filled every doorway. They sat on cloths in the early sun with their bundles and their children, saying very little, as the women at Kettamala's well had done.

Neela slowed without meaning to. She was saying names under her breath, as she did, and gathering faces like a woman gathering fallen fruit.

At the end of the row sat an old woman with a net across her knees.

She was mending it with a bone needle, her fingers dark and quick and knotted at the joints. A tear ran along the lower edge. The thread went through the mesh, looped, and came back under itself. Looped twice. Drew tight.

Neela stopped walking.

She knew that knot. It was a fisherman's double hitch. It was the one Ammu had tied round every pepper packet, the one a net-mender behind the sheds was said to have taught them both. It was the one that had always been in her own fingers.

She looked down. Her hands were working at the end of her sash. She had not told them to. A loop, a second loop, and a pull. The same knot.

The old woman's needle stopped.

She looked up, not at Neela's face, but at her hands. A long look. The net slid down off her lap and lay forgotten in the dust, and her mouth came slowly open on a word she did not say.

## Chapter 7

# Ammini's Girl

The old woman's needle did not move, and neither did Neela's hands.

Eleven people sat in the doorways of the village. She counted them without meaning to, and counted the two men by the well and the child on a hip. The knot had fallen out of her sash. Her fingers had made it again and stopped halfway, like a guilty dog.

Ten paces back, Devan stood with Kesu at the well. He had seen her stop. He did not come. He turned his head and said something to the one-eyed old man, and the two of them became very interested in a bucket.

"Again," the old woman said, in the coast tongue. She did not look up. "Slowly."

Neela undid the hitch and tied it. Loop, loop, pull.

"Who taught you that?"

"A net-mender," Neela said. "Behind the sheds, where I was raised. That's what I was told."

"Told." The old woman's mouth worked. "Sit down, girl. Sit like you're buying fish. Nobody here is watching a woman buy fish."

Neela sat on the cloth beside her with her knees drawn up. The woman picked the net off the dust and laid it across both their laps, so that two pairs of hands bent over one tear in the mesh. It was a neat trick. From the doorways they were two women haggling over thread.

"Ponni," the woman said. "Fishwife. Nellimala, till I was put out of it. Now I sleep in Kesu's cattle shed and he says I snore."

"Do you?"

"Like a boat on shingle." The needle went in and out. "You ask questions fast. Ammini did that. She'd answer a thing with a thing, and you'd walk away having told her your whole week."

Neela's throat shut. She made herself breathe through it. "Who was Ammini?"

"The best net-mender on that coast. She had hands like yours. She'd tie that hitch on a fishing line, a pepper sack, a child's shoe." Ponni glanced up at last. Her eyes were clouded at the edges, and very sharp in the middle. "She had a girl who'd copy her. Sat on the sand at four years old with a bit of cord, tying and tying. Cross as a cat when it came out wrong."

"What was she called?"

"You know what she was called."

Neela did not answer. Across the road a woman rocked a baby, and a boy fed a crust to a thin dog. The well chain clanked. She said, "Tell me anyway."

Ponni looked at her for a long moment. Then she bent over the net.

"Indu," she said.

It went through Neela like cold water. She had read it off a leaf in the dark. She had said it to Devan across a lamp. She had never heard it said by a mouth that had said it before.

"The second harvest," Ponni said, low and even. "You'll want that, I think. Twenty-one years back. We were drying fish on the racks. Pepper was in. The boats came at dusk, two of them, straight over the bar at slack water with no pilot. Nobody crosses that bar without knowing the marks. They knew the marks." Her needle stopped. "They came in like men who'd been told the way. Like men who were expected."

"Expected by whom?"

"If I knew that, I'd have said it to somebody." Ponni's lip curled. "Nobody asked. The women got the children up the goat path. The old

ones stayed with the fires so the raiders would go for the fires. I had my own two boys by the collar. I ran with you in my arm for the first bend, and then Ammini took you."

*I ran with you in my arm.* Neela's hands lay dead on the net.

"And at the top?"

"That's what I've carried." Ponni's voice dropped further. "There were men at the top. Not raiders. Raiders came from the sea, in hide and bronze. These were men in grey, standing in the road, quiet as posts. They had a cart. A big flat cart with a tailboard. A little bird was painted on it, yellow and small. The paint was new."

Neela said nothing. The word *grey* sat in her chest like a swallowed stone.

"They didn't hurt anyone. That's the thing I can't set down. They took the youngest, the ones who'd stopped crying out of shock. They lifted them like sacks of rice. One of them counted. I remember he counted. And I ran, with my boys, because I was a coward." Ponni's face did not change. Her hands did, a small tremor in the left. "I never saw where the cart went."

"I know the path," Neela said.

It came out of her without leave.

"I know it. Left of the lightning boulder, up the scree, across the shoulder, down through thorn to an old well. I've walked it twice this year without a map, and I couldn't say how." Her voice thinned. "I was carried up it. On someone's back. I remember the thorns on my legs. Somebody was breathing very hard."

"Ammini," Ponni said. "She went up after you. She had her net weights still in her apron. I heard them clink."

"And she came down."

Ponni's eyes met hers. They were wet, and she let them be.

"She went up," she said. "She did not come down."

Neela sat quite still. A fly walked along the net. Somewhere a pot lid rattled. She had thought she would have to ask for a mother, a name, a

face, and she had been handed all three in the same breath. They sat in her like stones in a bag.

"My name is Indu," she said.

Her voice shook, and she let it. "I was Indu. They gave me a number. I've been a number for twenty-one years. I have not said that name to anyone who knew me before."

"I know," said Ponni gently. "Your hands said it. You needn't have."

"I wanted to."

"Then it's said." The old woman slid the net aside and put her knotted hand over Neela's. "I'm not telling this to the village, girl. You've the look of a woman who has to be somebody else by evening. Go and be her. I'm here. I snore, but I'm here."

Neela turned her hand over under Ponni's and held on.

*

The Company read its rolls by the fire at the lightning boulder, because nobody could sleep.

It had started with Thulasi. She had her page and the long strip fastened to it, and she had sat with it in her lap through the whole of supper, not reading, only holding. Then Kuttu had said, "Well? It's your village," and she had unfolded it with Pavi's help and said *Pazhayangadi* aloud as if it were a coin she feared was false.

Now forty people sat in a ring with scraps of leaf. Thilak had burned his own. He listened, one hand flat on his knee. Meenu read hers with her lips moving, a letter at a time. Neela went from one to another with the lamp, helping where the cipher stuck.

She was good at it. She could hold a stranger's loss in a lamp's yellow circle and keep her hand steady. She had got through the evening so, with Ponni's voice in her ear: *a little bird, yellow and small.*

She had told the gorge nothing. A pass village could hold its own secrets, but she could not ask it to hold hers.

"Mine's gnawed," Kuttu said. He held up the roll. A corner was missing, ragged as a torn cheek. "Rats. Look. They've had my father's name."

"Let me see."

She took it. The edge was chewed through a line, and the leaf was thin at the break. She turned it to the lamp.

And a locked door shut in her head.

She was twelve. Perhaps thirteen. Chathu's room smelled of lamp oil and jaggery. The door stood a hand's breadth open, because she had been told to wait with a tray. Inside, Kirri sat on the stool with her chin up, seventeen and proud and white about the mouth. Chathu was bent over a table. A rat-eaten page lay in front of him, brown at the edges. He uncorked a pot of resin-ink and wrote, line by line, in a hand she could have read from the passage.

"There," he'd said, so softly. "Not to worry, child. A master who saw you turn can always write you again."

Kirri had smiled up at him.

Neela blinked. Kuttu was staring. The lamp had tipped, and she righted it.

"It's mended in my head," she said, "that's all. Chathu did it once for a sister. Wrote a page out fresh, after rats."

"Kind of him," Kuttu said, without any irony at all.

"Yes." She handed the leaf back. "He was kind."

She filed it where she had always filed it. Under mercy, under the soft hands that wrote the cage. Chathu was in a cell in Kodiyur with his sweets taken away. It was an old kindness and he was a cell's worth of mercy. She did not look at it again.

When she raised her head, Devan was watching her across the fire.

*

He found her afterward at the edge of the light, sitting on the ledge of the boulder where the stone was still warm. The pebble was gone from his cheek. He sat a hand's width off and stayed quiet as long as it took her to realise he meant to.

"You went somewhere," he said.

"Kuttu's roll. A memory." She dragged her thumbnail along her forefinger. "Nothing. Chathu once mended a page. It's nothing."

"You counted at the well."

"Did I?"

"Lips moving." There was no smile in it. "And you sat with the old woman an hour. Kesu says she's called Ponni. I didn't come over."

"I know. Thank you."

"I want it said I could see you from where I stood."

"I know that too." She drew breath. "Her name's Ponni. She's a fishwife from Nellimala. She knew my mother. My mother's name was Ammini, and she mended nets, and she tied my knot." It came out in a rush, in order, like a list of exits. "The boats came over the bar at dusk without a pilot, as if they'd been told the marks. The women sent the children up the goat path. At the top there were men in grey, with a cart. A tailboard with a little yellow bird painted on it. They took the youngest. And my mother went up after me, and Ponni never saw her again."

She had said it all in one breath. Afterward she sat with her mouth shut, nails dug into her palm.

Devan did not move.

"Men in grey," he said.

"Yes."

"I'll say what I thought of, and then I'll say what it's worth." He was looking at the dark where the road ran down to the sea. "The man who came to Muthu the winter Asha died. He wore a grey cloak. He asked for a monthly letter *to keep the warden safe*. That's what Muthu told me, in the kalari pit, after Ittan." He turned his head. "But the Kettamala garrison wears grey. Half the wardens' men in the hills do. Half the pass villages dress their ploughmen in the same cloth. It's cheap and it takes the dye."

"So it means nothing."

"It means I thought of it, and you should know that I did. I don't know more." He said it slowly, each word set down like a stone on a wall. "I won't build on it. I won't ask you to."

She let out the breath she had held since the well. It was not a shout, or a laugh. It was something near both.

"You could have said it was the crown."

"I could have. I'd have been guessing, and you'd have had to carry my guess as well as hers."

"Twenty-one years ago," she said. "You'd have been eleven."

"I was learning to fall off a pony."

"I was learning to be Seventeen."

He took that in. After a while he said, "Tell me the rest, if there's any."

"There's the path." She looked at her hands. "I knew it the way I know my own teeth. I walked it for the first time this year and I knew where the thorns were. Somebody carried me up it and I didn't remember. My body did. The lantana, the knot, the path." She laughed, dry. "I've been tripping over my own childhood for months and calling it luck."

"It isn't luck."

"No."

The fire popped behind them. Down the bank someone was singing, low and off the note, the way Ammu used to. It might have been Pavi. It might have been the wind.

"Devan."

"Yes."

"We leave for Kodiyur at first light. Six of us. I don't know what's at the end of that road. I don't know who is at the end of it." She made herself look at him. "If I don't come back—"

"Neela."

"If I don't, I want somebody to have it. Not on a slip. Not in a ledger anyone can seize." Her voice cracked. "Someone who'll keep it as it was said. My mother's name was Ammini. She was a net-mender of Nellimala. She went up the goat path after her daughter, and she didn't come down."

It was a gift, and it cost her. A name could be written down. A name could be read aloud against you. Every leash she had known began with someone knowing a thing and holding it. She held it out anyway, on the open palm of her mouth, and did not look away.

He took it as if it had weight.

"Ammini," he said.

He said it right. He said it once, with the broken vowel at the front of it, as Ponni had said it, as if he had been listening at the well after all. Then he stopped. He did not say it again, to be sure of it. He did not make it a promise, or a ribbon, or a lamp.

"I'll keep it," he said. "You'll take it back from me yourself."

"That's not a promise."

"No." He looked at her, level, grey-eyed. "It's what I'd like. I won't swear to what I can't make true. But I'll keep this. Nobody will have it from me."

She leaned until her shoulder was against his. The stone was warm beneath them both.

Far down the road the sea wind came up through the gorge, bringing salt, and under the salt a thread of green and bruised sweetness, rank and ordinary and her own. She breathed it in. She did not hate it.

*Ammini. Indu.* A yellow bird on a tailboard.

Someone had counted the children as they were lifted. She lay awake a long time wondering who had held the tally, and for whom.

## Chapter 8

# The Shelf

"Fourteen hundred," Devan said to the rock.

The rock did not argue. It sat in the cut above the lower narrows, a slab the size of a cart bed, and Thilak's pry-bar was under it. Devan put his shoulder to the bar beside the tapper's. The slab groaned, tipped, and went down the scree in a long grey roar. Dust rose from the shelf and hung there.

Raman had died under that shelf. Eleven riders in single file, a bow on the lip, and a man with a nine-year-old boy at home. Devan had ridden past it every day for a week and had not looked up. Today he looked up all the time.

He had put a lookout on the lip for that reason. Biju, a volunteer with a red headcloth, sat up there on a flat rock with a horn across his knees, facing the road and the sea. Every few breaths Devan found the red cloth against the sky, and every time it was there.

"Fourteen hundred what?" Kandan said.

The corporal stood below with a rope round his waist and a spear across his back. The scar through his brow was white with dust. Forty garrison volunteers worked the face behind him, cutting and prying and hauling. Muthu's order had said the garrison stays inside the walls. Kandan's forty had not found that order interesting.

"Thurai." Devan wiped his palms on his thighs. "Sixty hulls on the water. Twenty-odd to a hull."

"And us?"

"Forty-two odiyans. Six ride south this morning. Thirty-six who stay." He kept his voice flat, as he would for a ration count. "Thirty-six and forty. Seventy-six."

"Fourteen hundred over seventy-six," Kandan said slowly.

"Eighteen."

"Nineteen if the six don't come back."

"They're out of the sum already."

"Then nineteen once we've buried the first of us." Kandan did not smile. "Count like that, warden. It's more honest."

"I count like a man who wants the wall." Devan tipped his head at the shelf. "Look at it."

The lower narrows ran forty paces from cliff to cliff. On the east side the shelf jutted out over the cart road, a stone lip with loose scree piled behind it. Raiders could not climb it from below. But if the face came down, the scree came with it, and a bank of broken rock would choke the road chest-high across the whole gorge. Spears on top of that bank, stones thrown from the lip above, and eighteen Thurai for each defender trying to climb.

Not a wall. A bad day made of rocks. It was the only one he had.

"You want to bury the road," Kandan said.

"I want to make them climb it."

"Under spears."

"Yes."

Kandan chewed that over. He did not ask what happened when the number went past eighteen apiece. He was an honest man, and Devan was grateful for it.

Thilak set the bar again. He was a broad, quiet man, a member of the Resin House twenty-two years and a tapper before that. When he leaned, the rock moved. Vellan worked on the far side of him, hauling slabs from the cut in his arms like a man carrying sleeping children. He did not talk. He had not repeated Asha's last words since the pass, and

Devan had not asked. They had the work between them, and that did for now.

Devan's spear leaned against the pry-pole at his elbow. It had been within arm's reach every hour since Raman died. He no longer noticed putting it there.

Down the road, on the verge where the gorge opened toward the sea, Neela's six stood by a pack pony. She had come as far as the shelf with them at first light and then stopped, head tilted back, looking up at the lip. *Show me what you mean to do,* she'd said. He had shown her. Then the sun had climbed, and no one had left. She had checked the pony's girth. She checked it again, one eye on him, and then a third time, though the strap had not moved.

A pebble ticked.

Devan heard it as a soldier hears a cough in a quiet hall. Scree falls down. This one had rolled sideways, then dropped, from the high side of the cut where nobody was working.

He looked for the red headcloth.

The flat rock on the lip was empty. A horn lay on it.

*

A man stood beside the horn.

He was thirty paces off and a body-length above, a lean shape in hide and bronze with a short bow already drawn. The arrow pointed down at the work gang. Beyond him, on the slope, two more were coming down the scree at a run. They went light-footed, stepping on the stones that did not slide.

"Down!" Devan shouted. "Scouts, the lip, left of the cut!"

Men scattered. A volunteer named Vasu was too slow, bent over a rope with his back to the slope, and the nearest runner came for him with a sword held low. Devan took the spear from the pole and went up the scree.

It was twelve steps. He had counted them that morning, because he counted everything now.

He had not struck first at a living man in eight years. He had trained the habit out of his hands. Let them come. Hold the line. Stand and be the wall. And a man had died under this shelf while he stood and was the wall, and the wall had not been enough.

The runner raised his blade in a clean, practised motion. He had not yet turned toward Vasu's back. He was still a body in the air, between one stride and the next.

Devan drove the spear into him under the ribs.

It went in the way it was taught to, and stuck, and he let go of it. The man looked down at the shaft. Then he sat down on the scree, quite gently. He was dead before the stones he'd dislodged finished rolling.

Something bright bounced from his belt and spun on the rock. A small coin. It flashed in the sun and lay flat.

The arrow from the lip sang past Devan's ear and cracked on stone. Then Vellan went up the slope on all fours with a roar that had nothing human in it, and Thilak was a half step behind him. The bowman dropped his bow. He tried to go back over the lip. He did not make it.

It was short. When it was over, four Thurai lay on the scree, and two had run up the slope toward the cut, and Kandan's men were already after them.

Devan stood over the man he had killed. The weight he'd expected did not come. Instead a coldness touched his left arm, and he looked down. A strip of skin was laid open from shoulder to elbow, thin and shallow, where the bowman's second shot must have grazed him. He had not noticed it. It began to bleed freely, and he pressed his hand over it.

*Neela.*

"You struck first," Kandan said.

The corporal had come up beside him, breathing hard, his spear dripping. There was no accusation in his face. He looked like a man who had waited a long time to see something and had now seen it.

"Yes," said Devan.

"Eight years, the garrison says. You never killed a man first."

"I did today."

"Aye." Kandan looked at the dead man. Then at Vasu, who sat on a rock with his head between his knees, alive. "Better you than him."

A shout came down from the lip. Two of Kandan's men were standing over the flat rock. Devan climbed to them with his hand clamped on his arm.

Biju lay behind the rock, on his side, with his red headcloth pulled half off. His throat was opened. There was hardly any blood on the stone. The scouts had come up the back of the cut while he watched the road, as he had been told to, and he had not made a sound.

Devan stood there. He had counted seventy-six that morning.

"Seventy-five," he said, to no one.

He knelt, straightened the headcloth, and put the horn into the boy's hands. When he stood, his hand had begun to shake against the cut. He pressed harder until it stopped.

*

He was kneeling beside the dead scout again when Neela reached him.

She had run the whole length of the narrows. Her left hand was clamped to her upper arm in the same place as his, and her hair had come out of its knot. Pavi was two paces behind her, with her bad paw of a hand held out as if to catch something.

"It's nothing," Devan said.

"I felt it open." She dropped beside him and peeled his fingers off the cut. When she pushed back her own sleeve, a welt ran from her shoulder to her elbow, red and weeping, mirroring his. She looked from one to the other, and her mouth went tight and level. "Shallow. Good." Then, quieter: "You killed one."

"Yes."

"Openly."

"In front of forty men."

She said nothing to that. She took the strip of cloth from her sash and bound his arm and her own, one after the other, with quick sure turns.

"Look at his wrist," Devan said.

He had pushed back the dead man's cuff before she came. He had meant to look for a tally, or a brand, or a mark of rank. What he found stopped his breath.

Pale, ridged lines ran across the inside of the wrist. They were old and thick, laid over one another. Every odiyan in the Company wore the same pattern.

"Thilak," he said.

The tapper came over, wiping his hands. He crouched. He turned the arm over and put his nose close to the skin, as Devan had done, and breathed in. Then he wiped his palm on his mundu. He looked at the wrist, and wiped it again.

"Salt," Thilak said. "Clove-bark. Dry and sharp." He straightened. "Not nightbark. There's no tamarind in it, no scorch. I've smelled nightbark on my own hands for twenty-two years." He frowned at the dead wrist. "I don't know this tree. I'd say it's been put on this man more than once, though. And a long time."

Devan looked at Neela. She was staring at the wrist.

"The one by the tower," she said. "Same smell. Same scars."

"Same *kind*," he said. "We don't know what he is."

"A Thurai who burns himself."

"Or a man who was made to." He did not know what a Thurai odiyan would mean. It might mean nothing. It might mean that every fear he had tried to count was too small. He put it down in his mind next to the grey cloak and the yellow bird on a tailboard, and he did not build on any of them. "We'll hold it. We won't guess."

Thilak went to tell Kandan. Vellan had been standing a little way off, saying nothing, with his back to them. He turned his head once, looked at the scarred wrist, and turned away again. His shoulders had gone strange.

*

The purse on the dead man's belt held eleven coins.

Devan poured them out on the flat of a stone. They lay in a small bright heap, with the sprig on one face and a sharp milled edge round every rim. They had not been handled. He had seen coins like them in a satchel once, under the lip of this same cut, and had taken them for evidence.

"New silver," Neela said.

"Varanad's."

"Look at the sprig." Her voice had dropped. She reached into her sash and drew out a cord with a single coin knotted on it. It was bright, too. "Parukutty's. Rema paid it to her. I traded her a worn panam for it, and I told you I was being sentimental."

"You said you wanted to weigh it."

"I weighed it. It weighed the same as the scouts' coin, to a grain." She laid it beside the heap. "Turn them over."

He turned over three. The lowest leaf of the pepper sprig was doubled on each, a small stamped stutter, as if the die had slipped when it struck. He turned over the fourth, and the fifth. Then he picked up hers and held it to the light.

The same doubled leaf.

"One die," he said.

"One die." Her voice was careful. "The scouts had it in spring. This man had it now, and the widow's gift. Rema's coin, from the crown's own chest." She breathed out. "The crown paid them."

"Once."

"What?"

"The crown paid them once," Devan said. "The coin tells us where it was struck. It doesn't tell us who put it in his hand." He set her coin down beside the others. "Rema's chest was filled from the same mint as the scouts' purse, and that's all we have. The mint is the crown's. Everything else is a guess." He looked up at her. "Who pays them *now*?"

She held his gaze. He saw her turn it over, the way she turned over a door before she crossed it.

"Someone who has the die," she said at last, "and the tally book and the cart with a yellow bird. And a man who wore a grey cloak to Muthu's door the winter Asha died."

"And grey is cheap."

"And grey is cheap." She let it go. It was not quite a smile that crossed her face, but it was kin to one. "You'd make a good clerk."

"Rema says I'd make a bad one."

He gathered the coins back into the purse and tied it. He took a long breath. Then he said what he'd carried for days, since the night at the Resin House, when he'd lain awake and listened to the wounds on his body rise up on hers.

"Neela."

"Yes."

"I killed a man today. First. I took a cut for it, and you took the same cut." He kept his eyes on her face. It was harder than the spear had been. "It's not the first wound I've put on you. I put the Company on this shelf, and the Company is on the shelf because I decided, and every fight I choose is chosen for your body as well. You never agreed to it. I let it sit because I didn't want to hear no."

She did not blink.

"So I'm asking. Straight." His voice stayed even. He didn't know how. "Do you consent? To what my war puts on you. The cuts, and worse than cuts. Because I'll hold this pass whether you say yes or no. I'm not asking so I can feel clean. I'm asking because you have the right to say it to my face, and I've been careful not to give you the chance."

A wind came down the gorge, carrying dust and the smell of crushed lantana, rank and green. Pavi had retreated twenty paces and was studying a pony's hoof with enormous attention.

Neela looked at the coins, and at the dead man's wrist, and at his bound arm and hers. She drew in a breath.

"Devan." Her voice was low and sure. "I chose that the day I—"

A horn sounded.

It came down the gorge from far above, from the gate of Kettamala, a mile and more up the cut. It rolled along the cliffs, and the langurs on the east face went silent all at once. Two long notes. A short. A long.

Not one long and two short. Not unarmed strangers.

Bhaskaran's code for the queen's riders.

Neela's mouth was still open on the end of her word. Devan was already on his feet, with the purse in his fist and the cut on his arm bleeding through the cloth. He was thinking, absurdly, of Muthu. He was thinking that Muthu held that gate.

## Chapter 9

# The Unsealed Letter

"Said it," Neela panted, "the day I—"

"Climb first," Devan said. "Finish it at the top."

So she climbed. The cart road up from the lower narrows ran a mile and more, and they took it at a half run, with Pavi and the rest of the six behind them and the pony's hooves clattering. The horn had not sounded again. She counted her steps instead. Four hundred and twelve to the first bend. The wounds on their two arms pulled at each other with every stride.

She had not finished the sentence. She knew how it ended. I chose that the day I said the word to you. But there was no breath left in her for it, and she was glad. Some answers wanted to be said standing still.

At the padippura the gate stood open to its width. In the yard sat a grey horse with a green sash across its saddle and a boy holding its bridle as if it might bite. The boy was Kannan. Beside him stood Pepper, the white goat, studying the saddle with the face of a creature planning.

The rider was a thin man in a dusty green sash. He stood on the gate chamber stair with a leather case in one hand, and Muthu stood two steps above him with his arms folded.

The Company had come into the lower court from the barracks side, forty-odd people in drovers' cloth, very quiet. Garrison men filled the rest of the yard. Neela found Kandan's face, then Janu's at the kitchen door, then Bhaskaran's. Everyone was listening.

"By the crown's order," the rider said, in the voice of a man who had said it three times already that morning, "Captain Muthu, holding the seal of Kettamala, is to bring forty men of the garrison to Kodiyur for the harbour wall. Kettamala's walls to be kept by twenty. The captain to ride at the head of the forty. Departure at first light tomorrow."

He held out the case.

Muthu took it. He broke the green wax with his thumb and unrolled the leaf. He read slowly, with his lips moving on the hard words. Neela watched his hands. They did not shake.

Halfway down the leaf his thumb stopped on one line. He read it again. His eyes dropped to the brass-cornered pouch at his belt, and came back up. Neela marked it and put it down to the hard words. The clerk's hand was round and crabbed, and she would have stumbled on it too.

Then he finished, and went still. The stillness came from the chest outward, as if someone had lowered a lid.

Muthu was loud. He laughed from the belly and cursed the weather, the cook, the pass, and himself with the same relish. She had never seen him silent for longer than a breath. Now the yard waited on him, and he said nothing at all.

"He's lying," a man behind her muttered.

No, Neela thought. She had seen Muthu lie, at the feast, over a letter. That quiet had been thin and quick, like a hand drawn off a hot pan. This one was heavy. It had two weights in it.

On one side were six years of grey wax and a woman held in a household somewhere. On the other, Devan in the yard with a bound arm, and forty men at the shelf who had not found his order interesting.

He was not hiding a choice. He was standing between two. She knew exactly what that looked like from inside.

Her first impulse was knife-fast. She could drop a pot, start a quarrel, make the rider's horse bolt, and buy an hour. She dismissed it in a heartbeat. Any hour she bought him would be an hour in which he had not

chosen. The crown would call it a plot, and it would stick to Muthu for good.

Don't push, she told herself. Let him stand there.

Devan had stopped at her shoulder, breathing hard from the climb. She kept her eyes ahead. She felt him decide, as a person feels a change in the wind.

He stepped out into the yard.

No one stopped him. He was not the warden, and no one called him by it. He walked to the middle of the court where the sun lay on the stones, a man in a sweat-dark shirt with a blood-stiff sleeve, and spoke to Muthu on the stair.

"I need nothing from you."

The yard went still.

"I'll tell you the cost, so that you choose with your eyes open." He did not raise his voice. He never had to. His eyes went once to the rider, and came back to Muthu. "There's a host three days off and the Company on the road between. This morning we lost Biju, who was seventeen. If you take forty men south, the road has fewer. If you keep them, it has more. I'm not asking for either. The seal is yours, and the oath on it is yours. I wanted you to know what stands on the other side of it."

He stopped. He did not say please. He did not say remember. He never glanced at the garrison to see how it landed.

Neela noted what he had left out. Not where the cut was, nor how deep, nor when it would come down. He had given the rider's ears a price and nothing a rider could carry south. She thought of the coin with the doubled leaf, and her chest eased a little. He was still counting.

He turned his back on the stair and walked to the edge of the yard, and stood, with his hands open at his sides, to wait. It was the hardest thing she had ever seen a man do with his hands.

Muthu stood motionless a moment more.

Then he said, quite quietly, "Bhaskaran. Give the rider a cup of buttermilk and a stool in the shade. He'll want an answer in writing."

"Yes, Captain."

"And find me the black wax," Muthu said. "Not the grey. The black."

*

The gate chamber over the padippura was small and hot. It smelled of lamp smoke and tallow. A table stood under the shuttered window with a stone inkwell on it, and above the table, on a peg, hung the iron seal of Kettamala. The disc was cut with a hill and a gate and had been worn by eleven wardens. Muthu had hung it there to write; it had ridden on his cord since Devan put it in his hand in the hall.

She had followed because no one had stopped her. Devan stood at the back, against the wall. Bhaskaran watched the stair. Muthu sat down and drew the ink toward him.

He wrote for a long time. Neela did not stand where she could read it. She watched the pen instead. It did not stall once.

When he finished, he sanded the page and folded it in half, and no further. He took a stick of black wax from Bhaskaran, warmed it at the lamp, and let one dark bead fall at the corner. He lifted the iron disc down from its peg. His hand shook as he brought it to the page, and he waited until it stopped. He pressed. Hill and gate came up clean in the wax, plain as a coin.

Beside the inkwell lay the grey stick he had carried for six years. He did not look at it. It lay where it was.

"Come down," he said.

They went down together. The rider was on his stool in the sun with the buttermilk in his lap. Muthu held out the letter open, with the fold lying flat across his palm.

"Read it," he said. "Here, in front of the yard. I'd rather you didn't carry it blind."

The rider glanced at him, then read. It took him half a minute. Neela read over his shoulder, because she was close enough, and because Muthu had asked.

From Captain Muthu, holding the seal of Kettamala in trust, to the crown's household. I have your order of this day. I keep my men at the

pass. I swore to hold this seal for the border and the villages, and that is the oath I answer to. A host is on the coast road and this garrison stands between it and the hill farms. When the road is clear, I will bring the forty to Kodiyur myself and lay the harbour wall brick by brick. Not before. This letter is open. Let any man who wishes read it. —Muthu.

Black wax. Hill and gate. No grey.

She let out a slow breath. Around her the yard had begun to murmur, a low and ragged sound like a field of barley turning.

"The household will not like this," the rider said.

"No," said Muthu. "Tell them I said so."

He sounded like himself. The loudness was back in it. It was not quite a laugh, but it lived in the same house.

The rider folded the letter along its crease. He went to his horse and gathered the reins, and then he stopped and swore. Pepper stood at the saddle with her neck stretched. The green ribbon that had tied the order case lay in the dust, and the goat was eating it, steadily, in long silk strands that hung from her mouth like a fisherman's moustache.

"Get away, you filthy—"

Pepper bit him on the hand.

The yard broke. A gasp came first, then a snort, and then Kandan, at the back, let out a bark that set off Vasu, and the whole garrison went up together. Kannan clapped both hands to his face. The rider swore again, in a thin high voice. The goat went on chewing, with an expression of perfect virtue.

Neela laughed until her side hurt. Beside her, an arm's length off, Devan laughed too. She had not heard it in days. It was low and short and a little hoarse, as if it needed oiling.

The rider mounted with a dignity he did not have. He rode out under the padippura with Muthu's open letter in his fist and one hand wrapped in his sash.

"Thirty to one that goat is stew by evening," Bhaskaran said.

"Take the wager," Janu said from the kitchen door. "I'll hold the stakes."

*

Supper was rice and a hot green curry in the long hall, with the Company along one wall and the garrison along the other and the middle left empty by a kind of courtesy. Janu moved between the tables with the pot braced against her hip.

She set a bowl before Devan, then Muthu, then Thilak. When she came to Neela she put the bowl down on the board without looking at it. Then she put down a second bowl beside it.

"For whoever comes after," Janu said, to the air. "There's always someone."

Her eyes stayed on the pot. She did not speak to Neela. She went on down the board, her bandaged hand tucked in against her ribs as if she were holding something small.

Neela sat looking at the second bowl. In all her weeks in this house she had never seen Janu set out a bowl for someone who might come after. She understood it. Forgiveness would have come with words. This was a door left on the latch.

She ate slowly, with both bowls in front of her.

*

Muthu found her afterward on the west landing of the barracks, where the light from the kitchen made a yellow square on the boards. He had a cup of toddy in one hand and had not drunk from it.

"A word," he said. "Not here. Come along."

He took her to the lee of the water jars. The cistern chain clanked the hour above them and they let it finish.

"You watched me in the yard," Muthu said.

"I did."

"You didn't say a thing." He rubbed his jaw. "You could have. A word to Devan, a nudge. I've watched you move people by a hair, my lady. You stood still."

"You weren't lying."

"No." He said it heavily. "I wish I had been. Lying's easy." His eyes slid to the toddy and back. "That wax is dry by now. Somewhere a woman is kept on my silence, and I've just spoken. I don't know what they'll do with that. I'll say the rest of this while I can still say it. You're going to Kodiyur."

"Yes."

"Into the palace, if the door Usha spoke of opens."

She said nothing. He nodded as if she had.

"Then listen. The escort were three days in the south range, and every night they took a cup at my table. I counted their cuffs, because that's what I do with men I don't trust. Look." He set the cup on a jar and pulled his own sleeve to the wrist. "Buttoned to the knuckle. Two pegs, never one. A stiff cotton band, pale green. They don't push the sleeve up to drink or to wash. They turn the wrist in toward the body when they take a cup." He showed her. The motion was neat and soft, a habit worn smooth. "If a cuff slips they don't snatch at it. They close the hand and let it lie."

She watched. She had seen all of it before, in the First Guard's hands, and had not read it.

"There's a surgeon at the palace," Muthu said. "I don't know her name. The escort's second was drunk on the last night, and he said it as a joke. She pares the guards' wrists each season. Takes the ridges down with a thin blade, until there's one flat seam and no more. She keeps their throats pasted with lime and ochre." He looked at her sleeve. "She'll know your wrists before she knows your face. Whatever else you are, you won't pass at an arm's length."

Neela opened her hand in the lamplight. The ridges stood thick and layered, the way a tree shows its years. Eleven years of nights, burned and scarred again. She had never been ashamed of them.

"Thank you," she said.

"Don't." He picked up the cup at last and drank. "I wrote that letter today with the whole yard looking. I'd like one thing in this fort that I did on purpose." He wiped his mouth. "That's all. Go on. He's waiting

at the cistern, and he's been waiting an hour, and he'd sooner swallow his spear than say so."

*

Devan sat on the rim of the cistern housing with his sleeve rolled and the bandage off. The cut on his arm had closed to a long dry line. Hers had closed with it, a pink thread from shoulder to elbow. They had both stopped bleeding at the same time, without saying a word about it.

"The yard didn't want you to apologise for the plan," she said.

"I didn't."

"I know. I was there." She sat beside him, a hand's width off. "I'm finishing something."

He turned his head.

"On the road. 'I chose that the day I said it to you.' That's the end of the sentence. I chose it, and I choose it again, and I'll tell you if that changes." She breathed in. "But that isn't what I came to say."

"Say it."

She had rehearsed nothing. She picked at the edge of her bandage. "When I came here, I thought you didn't touch me because you were afraid. Of me, of what I'd do. Of yourself. I counted your restraint as fear, because mine was." The chain clanked above them, one, two. "I watched you stand in that yard today with your hands open and ask for nothing, and I knew I'd had it wrong. You hold your hand back because the thing it would take belongs to someone else. You ask, and then you wait. You asked me about the cuts. You asked Muthu for nothing."

"Neela—"

"The kindi is full every night with the spout turned left, because I reach left-handed. The knife under my mattress, you've known since the second week, and you never moved it. I read both as a hunter's patience. They were you keeping your hand off what was mine." She shook her head. "Nobody did that for me. They had a number, and they had a leash." She made herself lift her eyes. "I'd like you to hear it said. That's all."

He didn't answer.

He looked at his hands. He turned the scarred right one over on his knee and looked at that too. A long time went by. The langurs in the east cliff started up again, one by one.

"I haven't anything ready for that," he said at last.

"I know."

"I thought I'd have something."

"I know," she said, and found that she was smiling. "That's why I said it."

He gave a sound, short and rough, halfway to the laugh he had given the goat. He did not reach for her. He moved his knee until it touched hers, and left it there, and let her decide.

She leaned.

It was not enough. It would do for tonight. She would be gone by first light, up a hill road, down a coast, into a palace where a surgeon with a thin blade was waiting for wrists like hers.

How, she thought, and held her hand up in the dusk, and looked at it for a long time.

## Chapter 10

# Before the Road

Rain came onto the south range after dark, thin at first and then steady, drumming the tiles over the guest room like a hundred fingers counting.

Neela sat on the edge of the cot with the leaf of resin open on her knee. Six pinches, black and glossy, folded in a square of banana leaf. Six for the road. The Company had voted them, hand by hand, and she had been the last to raise hers.

She did not fold the leaf shut. She said it aloud, because said things were harder to cheat.

"One pinch saved if I stay human tonight. One bare night on the count." She touched the first fold. "The ache comes a moon after the last turning, and Nellimala was the last. So tonight costs nothing yet."

"Yet," Devan said from the door.

"Yet." She tipped her head at the leaf. "Kodiyur is roofs. Palace roofs, sea wind, a cliff. Every roof is a night, and every night is a pinch. If I turn tonight, I'm one roof short in the palace." She folded the leaf. "So I stay a woman. It's a cheap night. The expensive part comes later, and I'm writing it down now so I can't call it a surprise."

He came in and shut the door. The lamp on the sill threw his shadow long across the floor. He had washed. His hair was wet, and the grey in it showed at the temple.

"You've never spent a pinch for me before," he said.

"I haven't spent one. I've saved one." She laid the leaf under the pillow. "It's an old guild habit. Name the debt before it names you."

*

He sat on the stool, not beside her. She marked it and filed it, then laughed at herself, because she had stopped filing his distances weeks ago. Twenty-seven years, and she had never once chosen a night slowly. She meant to learn it before the road.

"Say it plainly," she said. "What it does. Once, before we go."

"The share." He rubbed his thumb along the old white line at the base of his other hand. "You'll be in the palace, climbing. Walls, drains, the cliff stair. Anything that cuts you opens on me as a welt. At the shelf I'll be fighting, and you'll carry my cuts. They'll come at the worst moment. You'll be hanging from a ledge with a guard below and feel a spear go in my thigh."

"A welt," she said. "Not the spear."

"A welt, if it's a cut. If it's worse—" He stopped. "You know the rest. You felt the poison."

She did. She remembered the tearing along her own side in the Resin House yard, when his ribs had gone. She remembered not understanding it and understanding it all at once.

"Then we say what we do when it comes," she said. "Before it comes. So neither of us has to decide in the dark."

"You first."

"If I bleed, you don't come." She said it flat, like a count. "You've a pass to hold and thirty-six who'll die if you leave it. A welt on your arm means I scraped a wall. It does not mean I'm dying. If it's dying, you'll know, because it'll be your own breath failing, and you still don't come, because by then it's four days and you'd arrive for the burying."

His jaw worked. "And you?"

"You bleed, I don't come. I stay in the palace roof until the work's done." Her voice stayed level, and she was proud of it. "Whatever opens on my arm, I finish the job."

"Unless the vote sends me."

She looked up.

"The Company's hands put me at the gorge," Devan said. "If the hands send me somewhere else, I go. That's the only door I leave open." He met her eyes. "I won't promise you more than I can keep. I told you that once."

"You did." She nodded slowly. It stung, and it was right, and she would not have trusted him if he had said anything else. "Then say it again, so I know it's one bargain and not two."

"If I bleed, don't come," he said. "If you bleed, I won't. Unless the vote sends me."

"Unless the vote sends you."

They each said it twice, as they had with the ledger. It was becoming a ritual, which frightened her more than a knife would have. A ritual meant you expected to need it.

*

"We'll want a signal," she said.

He had already thought of it. She could tell, because he looked at her, then at the lamp on the sill, and did not speak. He was waiting to see if she would get there by herself.

"Noon," she said. "Every noon. A prick, so small it's nothing, so nobody could mistake it for a fight." She dug in the pouch at her hip. "I've thorns. Lime thorns, from the bush by the kitchen well. Three each."

She laid them out on the blanket, dark green, as long as her little finger and sharp as stitching needles.

"Three pricks on my thumb at noon," she said. "Three welts on yours."

"And I've the tooth." He reached inside his shirt and drew out the leopard canine on its cord. It was yellowed, no longer than a thumb joint. She had moved it from her waistband to his neck herself, the last

night at Kettamala, and he had not taken it off since. The guild had meant it for his wound. He wore it against his chest.

"Three small welts means alive," Neela said.

"Three means alive."

"Fewer means—"

"Fewer means I'm busy. Not that you're dead." He frowned. "None is the thing I won't think about."

"Then think about three." She picked up a thorn and held it out. "Practice. Now. So neither of us panics at the first one."

He took the thorn. He did not prick himself. He held it between finger and thumb and looked at her, the rain loud on the roof.

"Do it," she said.

He pressed it to the pad of his thumb, once, twice, three times. Three beads of red. She did not look at his hand. She watched her own, laid open on her knee. Three small stinging dots rose on the ball of her thumb, bright and hot.

She breathed out.

"That's what alive feels like," she said, and was surprised how thin her voice came.

He put the thorn down. He crossed the floor, knelt on one knee in front of the cot, and took her hand in both of his. He put his mouth to the three red dots, one after the other. She felt it on his thumb too, a warmth on a wound he did not own.

"Still goes both ways," she said.

"Still."

*

She pushed him back onto the blanket and followed him down. He let her. His hands stayed open on the cloth, as in the yard, until she put them where she wanted them, and then they were not careful at all. She kissed the corner of his mouth, the hinge of his jaw, the grey at his temple. She went slowly. She had decided to be slow, in this one room, before the road. She was good at fast. She was done with fast.

His shirt came off over his head and she sat back to look.

Eight years of drilling alone had made him lean and hard, and he wore it the way another man wore a coat. But the rest held her eye. The white seam at his ribs from the ford, puckered and shiny. The scar through his brow. Seven flat pale marks across the knuckles of his right hand. The ropeburn on his palms from the goat-path rope, healing in stripes.

"Let me," she said.

He didn't ask what. She laid her fingers on the seam and followed it from the ribs to the hip. Then the brow, the knuckles, each mark, one at a time, the way she had once learned every servant in a strange house. She named them in her head. Ford. Stick. Wood. Stone. A man who had stopped hitting anything that hit back.

"You're counting," he said, very low.

"I'm learning." She bent and put her mouth on the seam. His breath caught in the hitch she had listened for all those nights, a third of the way through the long count. "Ford," she said into his skin.

"Neela."

"I know where they are now. All of them. If anyone opens one, I'll know it's yours."

He made a sound she had not heard from him. It broke off in the middle. She felt it in her own chest, as if she had made it herself. When his hand slid up her ribs and found her, warmth ran from his palm to hers and doubled back. She gasped. She could not tell whose skin was whose.

"It still does that," she said, unsteadily.

"It does." His voice had gone rough. "I don't think I'll get used to it."

"Good."

She laughed against his shoulder, helplessly, and then she stopped laughing.

She led for a long time. She took him in and held still and let it be slow, and watched his face, which he did not hide. He looked at her the way he looked at the whole fort from the wall-walk, as if it were a thing

he had decided to keep. When his hands tightened on her hips, she bent and whispered against his ear, "Now you."

He turned them over with great care. He did not rush. He asked with his eyes first, and she answered with hers, and then he moved, and the room narrowed to the creak of the cot and the rain and the heat of him. Whatever he felt, she felt too, an echo rolling down her spine and out into the dark. She told him so, in broken pieces, and heard him say her name like a word he was learning.

At some point she set her teeth in his shoulder. She did not break the skin this time. She pressed hard enough to leave a pink crescent, and a matching crescent bloomed on her own shoulder, hot and sweet.

They both stopped. They looked at each other.

"Last time that was play," she said.

"Last time you drew blood."

"Tonight it's practice." She grinned up at him, wild and breathless. "Bite me. Then don't move."

He bent his head and bit the curve of her neck, gently. Pain flared on his own, and he lifted his head, startled, and she saw him wait for the old reflex to rise. The one that said hurt meant help, that his body should already be gone, up the stair, out the door. His hands braced either side of her. His whole back shook with holding still. He stayed.

"Not a summons," she said.

"Not a summons." It came out like a vow.

"Again."

He laughed, shaken, and did.

*

Afterward the rain was still going. She lay with her head on his arm, the blanket kicked to the foot of the cot, a pinch of cool air from the window across her legs. His heart beat under her ear, slower now. The lamp had burned down a thumb's width.

He spoke into the dark. He did not usually begin things. She waited.

"I'm not afraid of dying," Devan said.

"I know."

"I thought you might think so. It isn't that." His chest rose and fell. "I'm afraid I'll stand at the shelf with the line bending, and a welt will open on my arm that is yours, and it'll be the kind that means you're on a ledge with nobody below you. I'll know it. I'll feel it as a fact. And I'll have to pick." He did not say between what. "Your welt, or the line."

She lay quite still.

She had expected a lot of things from him. A comfort, an apology, a vow. Not this. It had cost him to say it, and she could tell he had said it in the plainest words he owned.

"Then choose the line," she said.

His arm tightened.

"That's what I married," Neela said. She lifted her head so she could see his face in the lamplight. "A man who holds. Not a man who runs after every bleeding thing. I know exactly what it costs. I've counted." She laid her palm flat on his chest, over the tooth on its cord. "I'll do the same. If your welt opens, I'll stay on my ledge and hate you, and finish, and come home. And you'll be at the door."

He said nothing for a time.

"You'll hate me," he said.

"For about a day."

"I can bear a day."

"I know you can." She put her head down again. "That's why I picked you."

*

She woke at the middle watch with the rain gone. The room had that scoured quiet it gets after a downpour, when the tiles tick as they cool. Devan was asleep on his back, the hitch in his breath coming steady as a clock.

She slid free of him and went to the door for no reason she could name. She wanted to count it. She always counted the door.

She opened it a hand's width.

The corridor lamp outside was lit.

She stood and looked at it. It was a plain clay lamp, the kind that hung from a hook by the stair, and it burned with a low, even flame. Someone had trimmed the wick. Someone had filled the cup to the brim, so it would last until dawn without a hand near it. A smell of sesame oil hung in the draught. At the bottom of the stair, under the door of the north range where Muthu slept now, a line of yellow showed.

In the first weeks of the marriage the lamp outside the warden's door had been kept dark, and a boy posted at the stair. The boy was Raiu. Nobody had said why. A dark corridor had been Devan's kindness, once, so that nothing could see.

Now Raiu was ash, and a lamp burned in a corridor, and nobody had said a word.

She knew whose hand. She had watched that hand set down a second bowl at supper and look at the air instead of her. There would be no word about it in the morning, and no thanks possible. It was a door left on the latch.

Neela touched the cool clay of the lamp with one fingertip.

"Thank you," she said, to the corridor.

She went back in and shut the door gently, and left the flame burning.

*

They rode out at first grey.

Five waited in the lower court with the horses, and the pack pony stood among them, looking put upon. Pavi had a spear across her saddle and her curled forepaw of a hand tucked in her sleeve. Thilak sat his brown cob like a rock set on a pillar. Madhavi, Kuttu and Meenu were pale and quiet, with the look of people who had said goodbyes the night before and did not mean to say more.

Janu stood at the kitchen door, her hands wrapped in her apron. She did not come across the court. She nodded once, short, and went back inside.

Devan stood by the mare. He had not slept much. He held out a leaf packet of cold rice and curd, and a folded cloth, still warm from the brazier.

"For the first night," he said. "In case."

"I've a cache plan for the road."

"In case." He put the bundle in her hands and kept his own on it a breath longer than he needed to. Three small dots showed on the pad of his thumb, healed to pink. Hers had faded the same.

"Noon," she said.

"Noon."

She did not kiss him in the yard. She would have fallen apart. She mounted instead, gathered the reins, and rode out under the padippura with her back straight, counting the horses behind her until she had five.

The hill road dropped away in loops, wet and shining. Langurs barked on the cliff and then, as they passed, fell silent, and she put it down to the rain-sodden morning. A mile down the cut she heard the dull far boom of the gorge below, water running over the broken rock. The sun came up red behind the ridge.

An hour down the hill road, her left forearm began to burn.

It came slowly. First a prickle at the inside of the elbow, then a line of heat, thin as a thread, running from wrist toward the crook. She pushed back her sleeve with one hand and looked.

A welt was rising. Narrow, red, shallow, about the length of her hand. As she watched, it beaded at one end.

She knew where it came from. She knew it the way she knew her own number.

Far behind and above her, in the cut he had spent a week making into a bad day of stone, he was already fighting.

Her horse walked on. The mare's ears flicked back. Pavi, three lengths behind, said sharply, "Neela?"

"It's a graze," Neela said. Her voice came out level. "His. Shallow."

"Do we—"

"No."

She did not turn her head. She did not slow. Her fingers closed on the rein, and the welt pulled with the movement, and she let it. If I bleed, don't come. If you bleed, I won't. She said it to herself in the rhythm of the hoofbeats, once, twice. She counted the bends in the road instead of the welts, until the cut was gone behind her and the sea showed, a grey seam at the foot of the hills.

Another line rose, lower on the arm. Then nothing.

She rode down toward the coast with his blood hot on her wrist, and she kept the bargain.

## Chapter 11

# Ask Me Again

The first ladder came out of the grey at the hour Neela's horse would be reaching the third bend of the hill road.

Devan saw it from the lip. It rose out of the scree below the shelf, lashed ship-timber with a hook of black iron at the head, and it swayed there until the hook bit the stacked stone of the wall. Behind it came another, and another. Along the whole slope men bent under timber, and the grey showed their bronze caps and the white of their eyes.

Three hundred, by the count he had made through the night. Seventy-five on the lip, now that Biju was gone.

"Hold," he said. He said it once, flat, as he had said it to eleven riders in single file under this same shelf in the spring. He did not shout. The men near him heard it and passed it on.

Kandan's volunteers held the right of the wall with their spears grounded and their faces set. The Company held the left, the odiyans in daylight cloth with spears in their hands. They were thirty-six now, all of them human at this hour, and none of them looked like what the night made of them. Thulasi had a salt-boiler's wrists and a stance she had learned from Kandan two days ago. Vellan stood at the far end where the wall bent, dragging his left leg a half step behind him, in a grip that had nothing of the kalari in it. It had been learned somewhere harder.

The hook bit. A man's head rose over the stone.

Devan took the spear in both hands and put the point through the gap under the man's arm. It was a clean thrust, and the man went back off the ladder with the press of the whole line behind him. He did not look to see where he fell.

The spear was a wall's weapon. It gave him a length of ash between himself and everything that wanted him. His right hand stayed on the shaft, the two fingers that could kill a man in a breath folded into the grip like a pair of knives he had decided not to draw. He had not drawn them in eight years. Not since the captain at the ford. Not now.

The second thrust took a shoulder. The third was parried, and the parrying blade came sliding down the ash and over his left forearm. It was a light stroke, almost polite. Heat ran along the skin, from wrist toward the elbow, and beaded.

He knew exactly where she felt it.

An hour out, he thought. The loops of the road, wet and shining. She would have pushed back her sleeve. She would not turn her head. She would count the bends.

He drove the butt of the spear into the man's face and the blade fell away.

"Left!" Kandan's voice, hoarse. "Left, they're over at the bend!"

Devan did not look. He took the next ladder on the point of the spear, set his shoulder to the haft and pushed. The ladder went over backward with six men on it, slowly, like a tree.

Somewhere under all of it he was saying: If you bleed, I won't.

He kept the line.

*

At midday the line bent.

He felt it before he saw it, through the soles of his feet and the drag in the men on either side of him. The Thurai had stopped trying the whole wall. They had found the elbow where it turned at the east end, the place Vellan held, and they were stacking men against it as water finds the low place in a bank.

Two hundred and sixty down, perhaps. Devan had stopped counting the dead and counted the living. Sixty-one on the lip that could still lift a spear. Of the Company, three had come off the wall with arrows in them and been carried back to the sheds. Kamalakshi was among those who had not. Her white face turned his way and then turned back. She was not forgiving anyone yet. She was fighting.

He did not think the line would break. He did not think it would hold. Ask him for a number and he would have said a quarter hour, and he would have been wrong either way, and the men would have known he had said it.

"Warden!" Thulasi called it from close by. She was bleeding at the temple and did not seem to know it. "They're through at the corner."

"I see them."

He went. He did not run. He put the spear between two men who were not ready for it, and for a long time there was nothing but the push and the grunt and the hot red breath of someone's face an arm's length off.

Then, behind and above, the horn.

It was Kettamala's horn. He would have known it with his eyes shut: a long plain note, no code in it, the rally call that Bhaskaran blew at festival gates and at funerals alike. It came down the cut from the fort, a mile of rock throwing it back, and it did not stop. It went on and on, until a bad horn-player might simply have been leaning on the thing out of spite.

The Thurai heard it. A ladder-man at the corner raised his head like a dog.

Down the cart road came thirty men in grey. They came at a jog in good order, spears level, and at their head ran Captain Muthu with his sword out and his mouth open, bellowing.

"Make way! Make way, you lot, escort coming through! Refugees!"

He ran straight into the gap at the elbow, where Vellan stood. He put his shoulder against a Thurai spearman and shoved. Behind him the thirty went into the line like a wedge into a log.

Devan said afterward that he did not remember how the next quarter hour went. He remembered Muthu's voice above it, bawling the same word over and over, with perfect joy.

"Refugees! Refugees on the shelf road! Mind the refugees!"

By the time the sun stood two hands past noon, the ladders had gone down to the scree and stayed there. Bronze caps went away along the slope, many of them dragging one another. Nobody on the lip cheered. They sat down where they were.

Muthu came over wiping his sword on a dead man's sash. His grey tunic was black from collar to belt. He had a cut across his chin and seemed delighted by it.

"There are no refugees," Devan said.

"It's in the post book." Muthu squatted beside him and looked at the line of living and dead with a face that had lost some of its roundness. "Black wax, plain ink, my hand: 'Captain Muthu sends thirty men down the shelf road to escort refugees from the pass villages.' The crown said the garrison stays inside the walls. It said nothing about what comes out of them to walk a woman and her goat home." His eyes were on the dead. "A pen is a good shield, my friend. Refugees are the reason I can write it down. If I'd written 'to fight,' I'd have had to hide the page."

"You'd have been hanged for the page."

"I'm still the one holding the seal." He grinned, a short mean grin. It faded. "I counted thirty of our men on the road up. I'd like to count them again later and not like the number."

"Bhaskaran?"

"Holds the wall with every cook who can lift a pole. Janu's got the pot on. I told her to feed anyone who looks like a refugee." Muthu got up with a grunt and held out his hand. Devan took it and was hauled to his feet. "And you owe me a seventh-day round."

"It isn't the seventh day."

"It's the seventh day somewhere."

Devan nearly laughed. His face had forgotten how, and all he did was breathe out through his nose.

"After the pass," he said.

"I'll hold you to it," said Muthu. "Out loud. In front of the cook."

*

At the evening count, three volunteers were dead.

Kandan brought the names on a broken roof tile, chalked in his own square hand, because the tile was what Neela had left in the barracks and the men had taken to it. Devan read them standing on the shelf with the last light on the stone.

Sankaran. Chami, who had been a drover. A boy from Kalladi called Rajan who had arrived with a spear taller than himself.

"Sankaran took one at the corner," Kandan said. "Before the horn. He was in front of Vasu. I don't think he saw it come."

"His mother's at Neerattu."

"She came back to the village after the husband died." Kandan did not look up from the tile. He still had not forgiven the warden for the order he'd defied, nor for being right about it. But he said, in a low even voice, "You'll write her. I'd write her myself, but my hand's a sergeant's. It goes to the point and stops."

"I'll write it."

He wrote it that night in the stone sentry hut at the back of the shelf, with a lamp and a board across his knees. He had Asha's trick of the board in his head and none of her hand. She had written his letters for him from the age of fourteen. He had said what he meant, in six words or less, and she had dressed it in a clerk's cloth and sent it off, and nobody had known it was Asha speaking from behind him.

Now there was only the stick of charcoal and a clean leaf.

*To the mother of Sankaran, at Neerattu.*

He looked at that for a long time.

*Your son held the corner of the wall on the second day. He was in front of the man behind him. He did not suffer long. I did not know him as well as I should have, and I will say what I do know. He carried water for the others without being told. He laughed at the goat. He wrote his name large.*

He scratched out *large* and put *plainly*. He scratched out the next line, which began *He was a brave*, because Sankaran would have laughed at that too.

*I am sorry. I cannot give him back. The wall held because he stood where he stood. That is the whole of what I have.* He signed it with his name and no title, since he had none now. He sat with the leaf on his knee and thought that Asha would have fixed every line and made it worse.

He folded it small and gave it to Kandan for the next rider.

*

At noon the next day he was on the lip, and the sun stood straight above the shelf.

A small bright sting caught the ball of his left thumb. Then another, and another.

He stopped in the middle of an order, with the words half out. The men near him went on looking at the scree, because a warden stopping was not worth a look. He sat down on the nearest rock, a low flat boulder lichened over, and turned his hand up on his knee.

Three red beads, one beside another. Small, neat, a hand-careful row. They were thorn-sized, from a bush by a kitchen well.

Yesterday's noon had come and gone inside the line bending. He had felt a sting somewhere under his thumb with a spear in both hands and the wall giving way, and he had told himself two or three. He had told himself busy. All through the evening count he had not let himself ask which.

Three. Alive.

He sat there with the sun on the back of his neck and watched the beads fade from red to pink, and from pink to nothing. It took less time than he'd thought. It seemed a good deal longer.

He did not say a word, and nobody asked. When the last of the pink was gone he stood up, shouldered the spear, and went back to the wall.

*

That night Kandan found him in the pit they had cleared behind the shelf, a patch of packed scree and a post set in stone. Devan had been drilling alone, because there was nothing else to do with his hands.

"Warden." Kandan stood at the edge in the dark, with a practice staff on his shoulder and a gourd in his fist. "You'll teach me the guard you used at the corner? Left foot back, shaft low?"

Devan looked at him. Months ago Kandan had called Neela a witch at the barracks door.

"Yes."

They worked in the dark by the light of one shuttered lamp. The staff cracked on the staff. Kandan had a drover's patience and a sergeant's anger, and both made him good. After an hour he was nearly as fast as Devan on the low guard, and Devan said so. Kandan looked as if he'd been handed something heavy.

"Rest," Devan said. He walked to the post at the end of the pit.

He had no reason to. It was the end of the drill, as he had ended every drill since the winter after the ford. Open hand, slow, from the hip. He took the form through the pivot and the turn and set the last stroke at the post, two fingers extended, aimed at a place on the wood that was not marked and did not need to be.

He stopped a hair short.

He held it there, the fingertips a thread off the grain, until his shoulder burned.

When he turned, Kandan was watching with the gourd halfway to his mouth.

"That's the one," Kandan said slowly. "The one from the ford. Muthu told us. Everyone knows."

"Yes."

"You used the spear at the corner. Three days, you've never used it. You had that in your hand every time, and a man came at you with a blade." He didn't sound accusing. He sounded like a man who has found a rock in his rice. "Why don't you use it?"

Devan lowered his hand. He looked at the two fingers, as though they might answer.

"Because it works," he said.

Kandan said nothing. The lamp ticked as the oil settled.

After a while he drank from the gourd and held it out. Devan took it. It was sour toddy, and it was the first time anyone in that fort had passed him a cup without being told to.

*

The days ran together after that.

The Thurai tried the ladders twice more and found the corner closed. They tried the back of the cut at night, with six men and a rope, and found Koman's old eyes waiting on the lip, and Thulasi's spear, and something that moved through the dark on four feet and was not looked at afterward. Devan kept to his orders. He did not watch the dusk on the shelf. He let the night belong to those who owned it, and in the grey he took the news from Vasu in a low voice with his back to the slope: three men taken, two ropes cut, a boat-sized timber dragged away.

Each noon he sat on the boulder. Three. Three. Three. On the fourth he found his hand shaking and put it under his arm until it stopped.

The burn on his forearm closed. The count of the lip went to seventy, then sixty-eight. A dead man's cloak became a bandage. Muthu's thirty settled into the line as if they had always stood there, and went home each night with wet faces to a fort that sent down hot rice in a cart. Once a goat was seen on the cart road, ahead of the rice, and Kandan swore it had been sent as an auditor.

On the fifth evening the Thurai herald came up the narrows.

He came alone, on foot, under a white rag on a pole, and he stopped a long bowshot below the shelf, on a flat of stone where the cart road bent. He was a small man with a big voice. He called up in a hill accent, so that no one could say they had not understood.

"Warden of Kettamala!"

Devan came to the lip. He stood in the red light, spear in his hand, and the whole wall behind him went still.

"The admiral sends this. He is a patient man. He has sat five days and lost his ladders, and he is tired of it." The herald paused for the echo to finish. "There are villages on this road. Seven are in his reach. At dawn he will burn the first. At the next dawn, the second. He will go on burning one a morning until the pass is open."

Nobody moved.

"The first is Kesu's. The one-eyed man's, at the foot of the goat path. The admiral hopes the warden remembers the way."

He lowered the rag. He turned and went down the narrows in no hurry.

Devan stood there while the last of the red went out of the stone. Kesu's was a half day below the shelf, behind the Thurai lines. There was a well in it, and a cattle shed, and an old man who had said *I'll hold the well* and meant it. It was thirteen hours to dawn.

Behind him, Kandan said very quietly, "Warden."

Devan did not turn round. He looked down at his left thumb, where nothing showed, and thought of the next noon, nineteen hours away.

"I know," he said.

## Chapter 12

# The Noon Gun

The noon gun fired while the thorn was in her thumb.

Half the quay ducked. Neela, who had been waiting for it, only pressed. One. Two. Three small stings, bright as pinpricks of lamplight, and she dropped the thorn into the gutter and curled her hand shut. Four days behind her, in a cut full of broken ladders, a man would be sitting down on a rock.

*Three. Alive.*

The echo rolled off the harbour tower and out across the water. Kodiyur went back to its shouting.

Four days of road had gone by in a page of dust. The sea road was dry, and the horses were good, and she had counted the milestones because counting was what her mind did when the rest of her wanted to turn round. Pavi rode close and said little. Meenu snored under the cart. Every noon Neela got down in some roadside field, pricked her thumb three times, and climbed back up without a word. Nobody asked. By the second day Kuttu had started to look away at noon, the way you look away from a person praying.

Now the road had run out at salt water.

Kodiyur stank gloriously. Split pepper sacks, tarred rope, drying fish racked on poles to the horizon. A clove-and-wet-sack smell drifted from the north warehouses, where a Kunjan Chirayil had once kept a ward who never existed. Cranes of rope and timber leaned over the quays.

Across the mouth of the harbour, a chain as thick as a man's thigh hung out of the water on its floats, with grey sails waiting beyond it. She counted eleven before she stopped.

Thurai, sitting off the mouth like crows on a fence.

Nobody on the quay looked at them for long. A porter spat. A fishwife crossed two fingers over her basket.

The five had gone in at the Salt Gate that morning behind a pepper cart, with Thilak driving and the rest in the sacks. They would lie in a salt store near the tanneries until she sent word. Neela had taken the Hill Gate alone. At first grey she had knelt over a pool in a gully and done her face and wrists.

Lime from the pass village, ochre from a potter's cutbank, mixed with water to a grey-gold mud. She had smeared it thick across her throat, over the ridged scars, and let it dry. It went chalky and tight. It cracked when she swallowed. Over her wrists she had buttoned two stiff cuffs of green cotton, starched with rice water, pegged at the knuckle the way Usha's were. The wedding bangle sat under the left one, a hard gold line against the bone.

*Don't touch it,* Usha had said, at the shelter. *Not once. A hand at the throat is a tell.*

Neela kept her hands down and walked.

*

The woman who sold dried mackerel at the third stall from the weighing house was called Rukmini, and her scale-boy was Pappu. Neela knew it before she reached them. She had stood at the next stall for a quarter hour, buying nothing, listening to the boy being scolded. The guild had never broken her of the habit. A woman who needed to stay unseen should know no one's name. She knew all of them.

"You're early," said a voice at her shoulder.

Usha wore her green sash at the left hip and a plain brown wrap over it, like any palace servant on an errand. Her sleeves were pulled to the knuckle. She didn't look at Neela. She looked at the mackerel.

"The roads were dry," Neela said.

"The chain's been up eleven days. Nobody's coming in by sea, and nobody's going out." Usha took up a fish by the tail, sniffed it, and set it down. "Don't turn your head. Two men by the salt-weigher. Port watch. They're counting who walks in from the hill."

"I counted them at the gate."

"Good." Usha almost smiled. "Walk with me. You carry yourself like a woman with a sword. Lose that."

They went up through lanes so narrow the washing hung across the sky. Neela dropped her shoulders. She let her stride go short and pinched. After forty paces Usha grunted, which she took for approval.

"The others call me First," Usha said. "I'll bring you to three of them. They'll want to see you before they decide anything. They won't use names."

"I will."

"You'll have to ask."

"I'll ask," said Neela.

A drying shed stood at the end of a lane behind the fish market, long and low, hung with split fish gone amber in the dark. Salt and smoke lay on the air like a second roof. Off-duty guards used it, Usha said. It was the one place in Kodiyur the palace did not listen. Nobody who valued their dinner went near it.

Neela went in and counted the doors. Two. A third in the back wall behind the nets.

Three people waited among the racks.

*

A man sat on an upturned basket with his sleeves down to his knuckles and a face like a closed shutter. A woman a little older leaned on a post and looked at Neela's throat. The third, younger than both, sat apart on the floor with his arms round his knees. He had the sulky, scrubbed look of a boy who had been told to wait outside.

"Second," said Usha. "Third. Fourth. This is Seventeen."

"Neela," said Neela. "And you are?"

The man stared. "We don't—"

"I know. Tell me anyway."

A silence. Fish swung overhead on their strings.

"Sajan," the man said at last, as though handing over a coin.

"Lata," said the woman.

The youngest drew a breath. "Sanu."

"Sanu." Neela went down on her heels in front of him. "Usha says you've something to tell me."

He looked at the floor. His hands pulled at his cuffs. "I carried notes," he said, in a small cramped voice. "For a year. Not to the palace. Out. A man in a grey cloak gave them to me in the lower court. I sealed each one in a pot of salve, and I gave the pots to the ninth-day post rider bound for Kettamala. They were always for the physician at the fort. Eravi." He swallowed. "I only went up myself once, with the escort the queen's clerk sent. I had a blistered heel. I left a pot at his dispensary, as thanks, and I never read a note. I swear I didn't. I thought they were medicine orders. The Keeper's wife was sick."

"Which pot?"

"Green clay. Bark salve. It smelled of..."

"Scorched tamarind and pine sap," Neela said. "I kept the pot."

He flinched. Sajan looked at her sharply.

"I was glad of the salve," she said. "I'd have used it either way."

It did not seem to help. Sanu pressed his forehead to his knees. "A man died at Kettamala," he said, muffled. "On the stair, in the dark. I've done sums on it. The lamps. If I'd read one note..."

"His name was Raiu," Neela said. "And you'd have read one note. They'd have found another boy." She had said it often in her head, over Ammu. It was as flat and true as a floor. "Eravi's held. He's told us what he sent. You're the first of them to say it to my face. That's worth something."

He lifted his head. His eyes were red.

"What did the man in grey say?" she asked. "When he gave you the notes."

"Nothing. He never said anything." Sanu shook his head. "He just counted me. Every time. Like I was a coin."

*Counted.* She put it away with the rest.

*

The front door banged and a woman came in with a leather satchel. She was fifty or so, brisk and broad, grey hair scraped under a cloth, and she carried herself like one who has put her hand in a great many wounds and thought nothing of any of them. She looked at Neela once and past her.

"Thankam," Usha said, with no warmth and no coldness. "Palace surgeon. She sees us here. The infirmary has ears."

"Everything with a roof has ears." Thankam set the satchel on the basket Sanu had left. "Lata, your arm."

Lata rolled back a green cuff. The forearm beneath was a mess of angry red, split along the muscle by a bad scrape. Thankam washed it, humming, then opened the satchel and took out a knife.

It was small. A hand's length, the blade thin as a leaf and curved at the point like a claw. The kind of knife used for peeling fruit or paring a hoof. Neela watched it come out of the leather, and her whole body went still.

Thankam did not use it on Lata's arm. She laid it on the basket beside her gently, as one might lay a spoon. While she bound the wound she talked of the tide, and the price of linen, and the bad temper of the Keeper's widow, who still kept his window open in the rain. Her bare forearms showed under the rolled sleeves. There was no seam on them.

But Lata's other wrist had slipped from her cuff as she shifted. Neela saw it. A flat pale line, a finger long, no ridge to it, no layers. Smooth as a stitched silk edge. Somebody had cut away twenty years of burned skin and sewn the rest back neat.

Her own scars lay thick on the inner wrist, ridge on ridge, the first laid down at sixteen. She felt every one now, under green cotton.

"Looser at the wrist," Thankam said, without turning. Her eyes stayed on the bandage. "That cuff will chafe. It'll chafe worse on the next fortnight, on a hard wall."

It was said to Lata, and it was not. Neela kept her face still. After a moment, Thankam picked up her knife and wiped it, clean and unhurried, on a cloth.

"You'll want a fortnight to heal after," she said, to the room. "The palace is not generous with that." She shut the satchel and went out, humming, and the door banged behind her.

Nobody spoke for the length of a long breath.

"She's kind," said Lata, rewrapping her cuff. "People forget that. She is."

"She is," Sajan said. "She cut it off me with a clean hand and told me I'd feel better." His voice had gone flat. "I did feel better. That's the worst of it."

*

They sat on baskets. Usha poured water from a clay jar and gave Neela the first cup. Lata drank hers standing.

The thirty, Neela learned, were not one mind. She had hoped for it on the road without quite saying so. Within the first quarter hour she heard the shape of it: the thirty were close to evenly split, and not about courage.

"Some want their pages," Usha said. "They've heard what you did at the Resin House. Some have heard it as a rumour, some as a hymn. They'd go to you at a run if they thought the gate was open."

"And some want to stay," Neela said.

"Some love her," Lata said.

Sajan made a sound. Lata turned on him.

"I'm not a fool. I know what she is. I know what I am." She spoke quickly now, like one who had said it in her head a hundred times. "But

she answers every widow's petition herself. In her own hand. Every one, from the border, from the pepper villages. When my brother's wife wrote about the death-gift, it came back in a week. A letter, Neela. Not a clerk's. I know her hand." She stopped. "That is the woman who kept me out of a kennel. That is the woman I'd be sending to a gallows."

"She also signs the writs," Sajan said.

"I know that too."

"She held the lamp," said Sajan. "Ask them that. Ask them what she held."

Neela looked at Usha.

Usha was quiet a moment, turning her cup. "She watches each of us turn," she said. "The first time. In her own chamber, with the shutters closed. She holds the lamp herself. She won't let a servant do it. She holds it high so she can see every moment, and then she sits the night through in a chair and says nothing at all. Not a word. At first light, when you're a woman again on her floor, she kneels down and tells you your shape."

"To you," said Lata. "Gently."

"So you know what you are," said Sajan. "And so she does. And so you're caged by the only person alive who's ever held a light to you."

"She's never said it at night," Lata said.

"She'd never have to start. She only has to open her mouth after dusk."

Nobody answered that. Neela felt her own scars drag under her cuffs. She thought of Chathu, a long time ago, sitting a girl down at a table. A kindness first. Then the lamp.

"Tell me about the sea stair," she said, because the room needed a different floor.

"It leads from the lower cells to the water gate," said Usha. "There's a landing halfway where the cliff bends. Two guards stand it. They change at the sixth bell." She answered at once, like a woman reading it off a wall. "The change takes sixty breaths. The new pair comes down from the top while the old pair goes up by the chain stair, and for the last

twelve breaths there's a gap where no one stands the landing. It's twelve if the rain's off and nine if it's blowing."

Sixty breaths. Twelve. Nine. Neela noted it. It was an uncommonly exact thing to know, and Usha had said it with no pause to count. She turned it over once, the way you turn a coin to see which side the maker pressed hardest.

She did not ask.

She had a number for every door in this city already. If Usha wanted her to have this one, Usha could say why. In the guild, a woman who asked too early was a woman who got told lies.

*Later,* she thought. She put it at the back of the shelf, beside the green-sealed quire and the man in grey who counted children.

*

It came as she lifted the cup.

A line of fire opened across her back, shoulder blade to hip. It wasn't a prick or a scrape. It was long and hot, as if somebody had drawn an iron down her spine and then down it again.

She did not drop the cup. She set it on her knee, very carefully, with both hands. She breathed through her teeth.

*Devan.*

Not a graze. A blade, or a ladder-hook, laid across his back in a long clean pull. The welt rose under her shirt, stinging, pushing at the cloth. It went on being cut, a slow count of five, then six.

Then it stopped.

Nothing followed. No second line, no tearing. No pull toward the dark. Only the welt, swelling, and her pulse beating in it. Whatever it was, it had not been the kind that kills. It might still be the kind that does.

"Seventeen." Usha had put down her cup. "You've gone grey."

"It's nothing."

"Is it him?"

Neela gave no answer. Sajan's shuttered face turned toward her with a new look in it. Lata glanced from one to the other.

If you bleed, I won't. She had said it in a warm room with rain on the roof. She had said it twice, so that it would stay said. Now she sat on a basket in a shed full of fish, with her fingers dug into the starched cotton of her cuffs, and for a long, awful moment her whole body leaned toward the door. A hundred miles of road. Four days of it. She would arrive for the burying.

She did not stand.

"He's living," she said. Her voice came out odd and low. "If he weren't, I'd be on the floor. It's a cut. It's long. It isn't deep." She looked at her hands. "I can't send him anything. There's nothing to send but the thorns, and the thorns are for noon. Three, tomorrow. That's all he'll get."

"That's all?" said Sanu, in a frightened whisper.

"That's the bargain." She lifted her head. "It's a good one. It's holding."

Usha was watching her. For a moment Neela thought that watchful face went very soft and very sorry, and then it was gone, as if a hand had passed a cloth over it.

"There is another thing," Usha said slowly. "I wasn't going to say it till tonight."

"Say it now."

Usha looked at Sajan, who looked at the floor. She drew a long breath through her nose, like a woman about to lift something she knew was heavy.

"Chathu has asked for Seventeen," she said. "In his cell. Three days now, to anyone who'll carry it. He won't say why." She turned her cup a quarter turn. "He says you'd come."

## Chapter 13

# A Gift Is the Start of a Bill

Usha went down the cell stair three steps ahead and did not look back.

Neela counted anyway. One hundred and four steps cut into the cliff, wet at every turn, and the sea working at the rock somewhere below like a slow tongue. The green cuffs rubbed her wrists. The lime paste on her throat had dried tight enough to pull when she swallowed. She wore a guard's boots from Usha's locker, a size large, and she put each foot down flat so they would not slap.

At the bottom a lantern hung from a hook. Under it sat a turnkey with a bowl of rice and a face the colour of tallow.

"Mani," Usha said. "The new girl. She carries his supper tonight."

Mani looked at the sash on Usha's hip, then at the paste on Neela's throat. He had seen both on a hundred palace guards. He went back to his rice.

"Eighth cell. The lamp's lit. He won't give you trouble." He wiped his fingers on his knee. "He gives nobody trouble. It's the worst of him."

"I'll stand the turn above," Usha said, low. "Two knocks if anyone comes down. Don't be long."

"How long is long?"

"Sixty breaths longer than you think." Usha's mouth twitched. Then she went back up into the dark.

Neela took the bowl and walked the passage. Eight doors, plank and iron, five of them dark and open on nothing. Seaweed smell. Lamp oil. Under it, faint, a thing she knew in her sleep: warm sesame and burnt sugar.

Her stomach turned over once, like a fish.

She stopped at the eighth door. It stood ajar. She counted her own breath to four, and went in.

*

The cell was a cut in the rock, three paces by four. A cot, a bucket, a slit window with the sea behind it. A lamp on a ledge. And on the cot, with a grey blanket drawn to his chest, sat a man who had lost the softness he'd had at the Resin House.

Chathu had been round in the shoulder, and his hands had always moved as if smoothing a cloth. They still did. But the cloth had gone slack on him. His wrist bones stood out. Someone who did not care for it had shaved his hair close, and it showed the shape of his skull.

He looked up and smiled with his whole face.

"Seventeen," he said. "Come where I can see you. My eyes are not what they were."

She stayed by the door with the bowl in both hands. "Neela."

"Neela." He tried it as if tasting. "It suits you. I did not know you would keep it."

"You'd have known if you'd asked."

"Yes, child. That is the oldest of my faults." He nodded at the bowl. "Put it down. Mani will listen for the dish, not for us."

She set it on the floor. Her foot found the cell's one dry spot and stayed there.

"You asked for me," she said. "Three days."

"And you came." He looked pleased and a little ashamed of looking it. "I said you would. I said it to the steward, I said it to the guard. I began to wonder whether I was only talking to myself."

"I didn't come because you said."

"No. You came because you want something." He spread his hands, palm up, in the old gesture of a man laying out his accounts. "I would not insult you by pretending otherwise. Ask."

She had planned this on the road and in the shed and on every step of the stair. A bargain had two sides. She would not let him set the other.

"There's a leaf," she said. "The queen's. Thirty pages. I want to know where it's kept."

"Ah." Not surprise. Something nearer a sigh. "And how to reach it, I imagine."

"The way. Nothing else."

"Nothing else," he said gently. "Very well."

He told her, without hurry and without being asked twice, in the soft, patient voice she had heard all her childhood across a long table.

"This passage ends at the water gate. The sea stair starts there and climbs the cliff, a hundred and ten steps, roofed against the spray. Halfway up, a landing where the rock bends. Your friend's guards stand it."

*Usha's landing.* Usha had called it the way from the lower cells to the water gate. It was one stair, named from its other end. Neela filed it as true, and filed beside it that Chathu knew where Usha's pair stood.

"At the top, a door of black wood in a passage lined with screens. The queen's room is the third door beyond. I sat in it four nights. She had me write at her table, by the window. Beneath the window, a low chest. Red lacquer, a bird picked out in gold. A farm lock, of all things. She keeps the leaf in it. You opened worse than that at fourteen, I recall."

Her skin crawled. *Of course he recalls.* Then the rest of it caught.

"Four nights. You've been in the cells longer."

"These four nights past, she has had me brought up each evening, and sent me down again before the lamps burned low."

"By the stair you've just described."

"With a guard before me and a guard behind." He tilted his head. "You are thinking it is a strange road for a prisoner."

She was. A caged man did not walk to the queen's table by the queen's back stair unless the queen's own hand had opened every door on it. The way in was her gift too. Neela turned that over and did not like either side.

"And the queen?"

"Sits audience in the long hall at noon. From the gun till the water-clock turns." A thin smile. "The gun is a mercy. It shakes the whole rock, and for the length of it a footstep on that stair is the least sound in Kodiyur. A patient woman might walk the last flight inside one report."

Noon.

It landed in her like a stone in a well. Three small stings in her thumb, and a man four days away sitting down on a rock to count them. If she climbed under the gun, she would be on a roofed stair with her hands full of wall. There would be no thorns. Devan would sit on his rock and wait for a word that did not come.

He would not know if it was a day lost or a death.

"You've picked the one hour I can't spend," she said.

"Have I?" Chathu's eyes were mild. "I only said when the queen sits."

"You know what I do at noon. Usha's friends carried it to you, or you guessed it. You always guessed."

"I guess a great deal, child. I am not always right." He drew the blanket higher. "But you will want the gun. You will want it badly, when the time comes. I only mention it."

She said nothing. He did not need her to.

*

The tin sat on the cot beside his thigh.

She had known it was there since the door. A round flat thing of dull brass, its lid dented at one edge where it had once been dropped on a flagstone. She knew the dent. She had run her thumb along it eleven times, in eleven rooms, the night before eleven deaths.

He saw her looking. He did not hurry. He took the tin on his knee and thumbed the lid, and it opened with the small flat sound she remembered, and the smell came up. Warm. Still warm.

Somebody had warmed it. In a cell with no fire. She did not ask who.

"You always pay your debts, child," Chathu said. "It is the best thing about you. I wish I had taught you nothing else."

"What do you want for it?"

"Take a sweet."

That was all. He held out the tin in both hands, the way a man offers water. Nothing in his face asked for anything.

She had learned around the fifth tin what it was. A gift is the start of a bill. Not a trap, which has teeth you can see. A gift has a soft mouth. It is warm in your hand and sweet in your teeth, and a year later it is a ledger line in a good hand: *one kindness, given.* You never remember agreeing. At the Resin House they had never needed to say *you owe us.* They gave you a sweet, and you did the arithmetic yourself.

In the kennels she had refused to touch the tin. She had thought the refusing was a victory. It had been a way of saying, *I am still afraid of you.*

She could walk out now with the route in her head and her hands empty. Chathu would let her. He would smile and say, *Of course, child,* and the debt would sit on her anyway, because he had given first. A refused gift was only an unpaid one.

If she took it, she would at least know the size.

*Let it be a thing I picked up,* she thought. *Not a thing sewn on me.*

She crossed the dry spot, put two fingers into the tin and took one.

It was a small round sweet, the size of a thumbnail. Jaggery, sesame, a bit of grated coconut. Her fingers came away shining.

His hand was close to hers as she lifted it, and she looked at his fingertips because she looked at everyone's hands. They were stained. Grey-brown, dry as dust, flaking in the creases. Not black. Not tacky.

She knew resin-ink. It was black as a beetle's back and it clung to skin for days. She had never seen Chathu's hands without it. This was only ink. Common ink, the sort a clerk uses for a petition.

She put the sweet in her mouth.

It was perfect. That was the thing she could not forgive. Sugar breaking, sesame going to oil, the warmth of someone's hands still in it. For an instant she was ten years old on a bench with her feet not reaching the floor, and a big gentle man was telling her she had done well.

She swallowed. It went down like a coin.

"There," Chathu said softly. "That is all."

"It isn't."

"No." His eyes were wet. He did not hide it. "But it is all I will ask tonight. Paper is the least of it, child. You will see. But you have asked for the paper."

*

She put the tin back on the cot with the lid shut, so that her hands had something to do.

"Your fingers," she said. "No resin-ink."

"No." He turned his hands over, regarding them with mild interest. "The cells are poor in everything but quiet. They allow me a pot of common ink, and a reed, and a plank to lean on. The queen asked me for the forty again."

Neela went still.

"She sent the steward with a list on the second day, in a clerk's hand. The forty names, and beside each a blank." He said it in the tone he used for sums. "She would like them written fresh. A master who saw a girl turn can always write her again. I said that to you once, without thinking what it was."

*A master who saw you turn can always write you again.* She had stood at his door at twelve, and he had mended Kirri's rat-eaten page in a quarter hour.

"And you said?"

"I have not answered her."

"Not yet?"

"Not yet." He folded his stained hands in his lap. "I find that I am not in a hurry. A very odd thing, at my age."

She waited for the rest. A man who is angling for pity says more. Chathu said nothing. He sat in the lamplight with his shaved head and his uneven left foot drawn up on the cot, bare and grey against the blanket, and he was so small that she could have put her hand round his throat.

"You could write them," she said. "You've done it before."

"I could." He considered it. "The queen is not unkind. She asks and does not command. It lets one go on thinking oneself a free man." He lifted his eyes. "I held every key at the Resin House, Neela. I held every cage in this world that mattered to me. And now I sit here and understand that I am the last cage I hold."

It went into her like a splinter.

She had come down the stair expecting hatred, and she had it, it was all there. She remembered the tin in the kennel. She remembered the paddle coming down, and the resin burning on her throat. That man was real.

So was this one. The old man with his knuckles gone to string, who still folded his sweets in a tin.

Her hand had moved before she knew it. It had gone to the edge of the grey blanket, to draw it down over that cold bare foot. She stopped with the wool between her fingers. Her teeth hurt. She opened her hand and let the blanket fall.

*No,* she thought. *You do not get that.*

His eyes had followed her hand. He said nothing. That was almost worse.

"I wept for Ammu," he said quietly. "You should know it. I wept in this cell, the first night. I do not say it to be forgiven."

"Good," Neela said. "Then you know what it's worth."

He nodded as if she had paid him a compliment.

She turned to the door. Behind her the thing she had been avoiding was waiting, and she faced it with her hand on the cold iron.

She had taken a debt. For the first time since a stone and a pebble and a vow in a warm room, she had taken one alone, and she had told no one. It was a small debt, a sweet and a stair. She knew exactly how it would grow.

"The gun," she said, without turning. "You set the stair at noon on purpose."

"I set nothing, child."

"Then hear this, because you'll try to collect on it." Her voice came out flat. "If I climb under that gun, a man sits on a rock four days from here and gets no word. That's his cost, and it's yours to carry too. I'll say it to his face before I pay you anything. Not you. Me."

A pause behind her. When he spoke it was almost tender.

"Then you will have to say it soon," he said. "The queen sits every day."

She had her hand on the latch when she heard the boots.

*

No knock. That was the first wrong thing.

Usha had said two knocks. Neela listened, and the stair above sent down nothing but the slow beat of the sea and, under it, one set of boots coming down. Unhurried. Measured. A good leather sole.

And a light. A lamp swinging on a hook; she saw its yellow tongue lick the turn of the passage.

She moved before she thought: back across the cell, behind the open door, into the angle between the plank and the wall. The lamp ledge threw its glow in a half circle, and the dark behind the door was thick and bare. She put her shoulders to the rock. She stopped breathing in the way the guild teaches, by counting.

One. Two.

Chathu did not look at her. His hands lay folded on the blanket, and he looked at the open door with the mild, attentive face of a man waiting for his supper.

The boots came to a stop outside.

The steward stood in the passage with a lamp held at the height of his shoulder. Through the crack at the door hinge Neela saw a slice of him: a grey cloak, a clerk's round shoulders, a hand that held the lamp so steadily it might have been nailed there. He did not come in. He stood where the light reached the cot and no farther.

*Grey.* A man in grey who counted children onto a cart. A man in grey who counted a boy like a coin.

"Master Chathu," he said. A dry, careful voice, round at the edges. "I did not wish to wake you."

"I am awake."

"So I see." The lamp shifted a finger's width. The glow slid across the floor and touched the edge of the bowl of rice. "Has she come?"

Neela did not move. Her pulse knocked in her ears.

Chathu looked at the steward for a long moment. His face was kind. It was the face of a man who had told her that the kennel was a mercy.

"Not yet," he said.

The lamp did not move. The sea breathed in the rock.

"The queen would wish to know when," said the steward.

"When she comes," Chathu said gently, "you will know it."

A pause. Neela counted it. Four. Five. In the dark behind the door she could see one hand of the steward's, and the lamp, and the stained fingers of an old man laid in his lap, quite still.

She did not know.

He might have looked past her, and kept her. A man who sells a debtor does it with exactly that face. Or he might have said *not yet* because he had taken a sweet's worth of her side, and meant to see the bargain through. Both were Chathu. Both always had been.

The steward's lamp stayed where it was.

## Chapter 14

# The First Village

Vasu came up the cut at a run and did not lower his voice.

"Torches," he said. "On the lower road. A mile below the mill ford, coming up."

Devan was already on his feet. He had not been asleep. He had been sitting against the shelf wall in the black before grey, with yesterday's ladder-hook cut pulling across his back every time he breathed, watching the east for a colour it did not yet have.

"How many?"

"I stopped counting at sixty." Vasu bent over his knees. His mother kept ducks at Kalladi, and Kalladi had stopped answering. "Warden, the village. I got to the well. Thirty of them won't leave. Old Kesu sat on the curb and said he'd held that well sixty years and wouldn't be told by a boy with a spear. The rest won't go without him." He wiped his mouth. "And the fishwife. Ponni. She sat down in the dust beside him. Said if he stayed, she stayed. She'd done her running."

"Did you tell them what the herald said?"

"I told them. Kesu said a herald was a man who had never held a well."

Devan looked down the dark of the cut. The herald had named that village first to burn at dawn. Torches a mile below the ford meant the Thurai would reach the thatch at first grey. The goat path was half a day

up and a hard two hours down in the dark, for a man who did not mind his knees.

He had thirty-six odiyans. He did not have one to spare.

"Wake the Company," he said.

*

They came to the dead fire in ones and twos, hair flat on one side, blankets round their shoulders. Kandan's volunteers stood off to the edge. They were not part of the vote and knew it. Nobody asked them to be.

Devan said it plainly, because he had no other way to say anything.

"Two choices. We hold the shelf as we are, and the people in that village burn with their well. Or fifteen go down in the dark, in shape, and break the Thurai horse lines at the ford while the rest of us go round by the goat path and bring them out."

Nobody spoke. Somewhere a pony shifted.

"I want to go," he said. "I'll say that first, so you can weigh it. Now the cost."

He counted it on his fingers because he trusted his fingers more than his voice.

"One. Fifteen pinches of resin. We've no spare in this week. Tomorrow night's wall is fifteen shapes thinner for it." He folded a second finger. "Two. Those fifteen are the best of you. They turn back at first light below the village, human and bare, with a half-day climb ahead of them and the morning hunger on top. They'll be no use on a wall until dusk." A third. "Three. There are seventy horses in those lines and a hundred men by the torches. I'd put it at one chance in three that we all climb back whole. Someone pays in blood, and it may not be a life."

"Lower," said Vellan.

He sat by the embers with a half-carved bird in his hands. He did not look up.

"Lower, then," Devan said.

"I'd go anyway," said Vellan. "I'm good at lanes."

A dry sound went round the Company that was nearly a laugh.

"Not my order," Devan said. "Yours. Hands. Sally, or hold."

Kandan counted, since nobody could accuse Kandan of favouring anyone. It took a long time. Hands came up slowly and some came up and went down again. Thulasi's went up high and stayed there, and she met no one's eye. Kamalakshi kept hers in her lap.

"Twenty," said Kandan. "Sixteen."

Four voices.

Kamalakshi looked at Devan across the embers. "I voted hold," she said. "I'll take the wall. If any of you come back, you can thank me for the dull part."

"I will," Devan said, and meant it.

He turned to Kandan's men. They had gone quiet in the way soldiers did when they knew they would be asked something.

"Corporal, you and your ten come with me by the path. We go in behind the shapes and take the people out. This is my order, under the Company's vote, and I'll answer for it." He said it to all of them. "If it goes wrong, the name that goes first on your tile is mine."

Kandan's scarred brow moved. "It goes on the tile either way, warden. Question is whose goes under it."

"Then keep the tile dry."

Fifteen odiyans went down the slope to a flat of rock out of the wind. Devan turned his back on them. He had a reason and a better one: what they were was theirs to show, and he had not been asked. Behind him he heard the cork, the small wet sound of resin on skin, a sharp hiss through teeth. Then the bone noises, which he did not watch.

When he turned round the rock was empty. Cold air smelled of musk and of scorched tamarind.

*

Something went past him in the dark on the goat path, low and quick and warm as a hearth. Then another. He felt them as weather on his face.

Kandan's men pressed against the cliff and said nothing, and the shapes went down and were gone.

Devan saw nothing of the horse lines. He heard them.

The first scream came from the ford, high and wrong, a horse that had met a thing it had no word for. Then the whole line took it up. Picket ropes cracked. A torch swung and fell and a second bloomed beside it, and in that jumping light he saw seventy horses come up the lane in one dark wave with their eyes rolled white. Behind them something huge and slow put a shoulder to a loaded wagon. It went over like a dropped plate. A raider's shout turned into something else.

Vellan's bear went through the picket like a man through a bead curtain. Where it passed there was a lane.

"Now," Devan said, and ran.

Spears slapped behind him. The lane stank of dung and crushed barley and fear. A raider rose in front of him with his sword half out and Kandan's spear took him under the arm. Devan did not stop. He struck once, a haft to a knee, because a knee on the ground was a man who stayed down. He kept his blade for when it was needed. It was not yet.

The village lay above the ford on a hump of red earth, a dozen roofs of thatch, a cattle shed, a well with a stone curb. Raiders already stood among the lower huts with torches. Two thatches were burning.

Grey had come into the east, thin as a knife. Behind him in the thorn the shapes had gone quiet, drawing off to wait out the light. He could not feel them go. He knew they had by the way the noise changed. In a little while there would be fifteen people down there in the brush, naked and shaking, and nothing he could do about it yet.

Kesu was sitting on the well curb with a billhook across his knees.

He was a small man with one eye gone to a seam. He looked at Devan with the other and said, "Late."

"Come down off that."

"I hold this well."

"It's held." Devan crouched in front of him, because shouting would not do it. "It'll hold if you're dead. It'll hold better if you aren't. You can't draw from it from the pyre."

The old man's mouth worked. Behind him, in a ring of women and grandfathers and a boy with a bad foot, the rest of the village watched the thatch burn. Ponni sat on the ground with a blanket over her head. She pushed it back.

"Told him," she said. "I told him the warden had a wife who ties knots, and she'd skin him for sitting on a well against an army." Her eyes went over Devan's face, hunting for someone else's. "Where is she?"

"Four days off."

"Hm." She got a hand on his sleeve and hauled herself up. "Then you'll do."

Kandan picked Kesu up bodily, billhook and all, and slung him over a shoulder like a bag of grain. The old man called him four kinds of fool. He did not struggle. Devan thought he had known all along that he would be carried.

The women pulled blankets off their own beds and left them in a heap at the thorn's edge for whoever came out of it. Then they went up the path in a long ragged line, Kesu and Ponni and thirty more, and eleven soldiers, the boy riding on a volunteer's back. Devan took the end. Halfway up the first bend he looked back.

The thatch went all at once. A roof caught and the fire ran along the ridge-poles and the whole village stood up in a column. Raiders were running between the huts with torches in both hands, not even needing to hurry. Beside him Kesu said nothing at all. Ponni took the old man's hand and kept it.

The well curb stood in the middle of it, grey stone, untouched.

*

They climbed all morning. The sun came up into a hard white sky and the path turned to oven. Women carried children and old men carried each other. Devan walked the rear, and every time he looked behind he

counted, because counting was what he did when he was afraid. Thirty-two. Thirty-two.

Near noon, in the lower narrows, the Thurai horse found them.

Not many. A dozen riders, the ones who had not bolted, with a grudge. They came up the cart road under the shelf where Raman had died, and the first Devan knew of them was the sound a rope makes in the air.

He turned. That was the mistake: he turned toward the sound and offered his side.

The hook was a boarding hook, iron, three-pronged, the kind a ship's crew throws at a rail. It took him across the ribs under the right arm and went on dragging. He felt cloth part, then skin, then something deeper that he decided not to name. The rope snapped taut and he went over on his face in the dust.

Everything went white and ordinary. The sun was straight overhead. His shadow lay under him no bigger than a hand.

He tried to push up and his arm would not hold.

Boots. Then a spear came over him, very close, and a man planted himself astride him with his feet wide. Kandan. The Corporal who had called Neela a witch at a barracks door. He did not look down. He said to the riders, in a voice with nothing in it, "Come on, then."

Devan lay with his cheek on the path and let him.

It was not a small thing. For six years he had held every back he stood behind and none had held his. He could have said *I've got it*. He had said it to Muthu a thousand times in a hundred ways. He lay under another man's spear and did not say it, and the silence was louder than the hook.

The riders had seen enough spears for one morning. They went down the road without any hurry.

"Up, warden," said Kandan, still facing the empty road.

"One breath."

"Take two. I'm not going anywhere."

*

The shelf at last. The wall, the ladders stacked and broken, Kamalakshi on the lip with her sleeves rolled, giving him the long look of a woman who has been right and is too polite to say it. She did not say it. She said something better.

"Fifteen went down," she said. "Fifteen came up the cut at midmorning, in what blankets they'd found. Human, bare, shaking so hard they could hardly hold the rock, climbing the back of the cut one behind the other. I counted every one in. They're in the cistern shed eating everything Janu's girls left us." She jerked her chin. "Thulasi took a hoof on the foreleg. It's cracked, not broken through. She walked, but she can't stand a spear human, not this week. And Vellan won't leave her side."

Devan did the sum before she could. Fifteen hollow and flat on their mats until dusk. One more with a leg, and one more to sit by it.

"That's sixteen hands off tomorrow's wall," Kamalakshi said. She did not say *I told you*. She did not need to.

Everyone alive, and the shelf thinner for it. He had said *whole*, and this was the part of the word he had meant. He found he had to look at the horizon for a moment.

"Thank you for the dull part," he said.

"Sit down before you fall down."

He sent the villagers to the cistern shed beside the fifteen and ate nothing. Then he sat on a fallen ladder rung with his shirt off and Kandan's curved needle in his teeth, a hank of waxed silk in his lap, and sewed himself shut.

It was not clean work. The hook had gone in at the side and out toward the back and left a ragged lip of skin that he had to pull with two fingers. He kept his eyes on the horizon so as not to look at it. Kandan stood a polite pace away holding a lamp he did not need, in broad daylight, because no one had told him what to hold.

"It'll scar," Kandan said.

"It'll join the others."

Third stitch. Fourth. He counted them. He counted everything.

He counted the hour, too. It was well past noon by the sun, and he had not pricked his thumb. Hers had come early, three small stings on the climb, a half hour short of noon, and he had not known what early meant.

Three small stings, every noon, from her or from him. It was the whole of their bargain across four days of road. If one of them could not send, the other waited, and if the waiting went long, the waiting itself told you nothing good. He had missed it. He had been on his face in the dust at the exact hour.

And Kodiyur had a gun.

He knew nothing of its stairs. He knew only that, the night before she left, she had told him she would go where the city was loudest, because in a loud place no one hears a quiet thing. In Kodiyur the loud thing was the noon gun.

*If she was on a stair at noon.* He pulled the fifth stitch through. *If it came while she was on a stair.*

The wound-share carried hurt, not words. It would not say *I'm hit across the ribs, it isn't deep, I'm well*. It would raise a welt along her ribs, hot and weeping, in exactly the place and at exactly the hour, and the pain would feel to her as if something had torn her open. She was a woman in a palace who had to stay silent. He had no way to reach her. He could not even say sorry.

Eight stitches. Nine. He bit the silk and knotted it.

His hands had begun to shake, so he did the last thing with care. He took the leopard tooth from the cord at his chest. It was yellow, old, curved like a hook of its own. He set the point against the pad of his left thumb and pressed.

One.

Two.

Three.

Blood came up in three small beads. He watched them and thought of a girl's thumb somewhere with three welts rising on it, late, a whole

hour late. *Alive.* It was the only word he had. It wasn't enough, and it was all there was to send.

"Warden?" Kandan was looking at the thumb.

"Nothing." Devan closed his hand over the beads. "Count the people in the shed again."

"I've counted."

"Count them again."

Kandan went. Devan sat in the white heat with a wet needle in his lap and his side stitched like a torn sail, and listened for a pain that was not his own.

The ribs throbbed. His thumb burned. Somewhere south, a woman who had walked into the palace with a throat full of lime had a welt rising hot along her ribs in the wrong place at the wrong hour, and had already decided whether to scream.

## Chapter 15

# The Sea Stair

By day there was no shape to hide in.

Neela had never minded that before. At night the other one hid her. At noon she was a tall woman in borrowed boots, hanging off a cliff by her hands.

The rope was stiff with salt and it burned through the rags she had wound round her palms. Forty feet of rock went up in front of her nose, black and weeded at the foot, dry and brown higher. Below, a mackerel skiff rode the swell under the overhang. Rukmini had lent it for a day and four panam and asked nothing. Pavi held it against the cliff with one oar. Her left hand, the old-broken one, lay curled on the gunwale like a sleeping crab.

"The slot's a body wide," Pavi had said. "Usha swears it."

"Usha put the odds at three in four."

"And you?"

"I think Usha is loyal to a building."

Pavi had laughed once, short, and then not again.

Neela had pricked her thumb before she started. Three lime thorns from the bush by the Kettamala kitchen well, a full half hour before the gun. She had sat in the skiff with her sleeve pushed back and watched three beads come up. It was not noon. It was not nothing. He would read it for what it was, a word said early, because she would have no hand

free at the hour. She had told Chathu the cost was Devan's to hear from her. This was the first instalment.

She climbed. Fifty-one breaths. The slot was a stone-framed gap in the stair roof where spray had eaten a beam, and she went through it on her stomach and came down on a wet step with her heart going.

The rope slithered up after her. Pavi hauled it off the face before the quay could see a washing line on a cliff. Then the skiff was gone from the edge of the slot, sculling for the point.

The sea stair took her.

It was roofed in dark stone and loud with water. She stood still and counted. Below her, down a long bend, two men talked at the landing. Usha's pair. They faced the water gate and had never once looked up. She went up on the outsides of her boots, step by step, and did not hear them stop.

*

At the top was a door of black wood, and it was not barred.

She didn't like that either, but she had a list of things she didn't like and a stair behind her. The passage beyond was screened in carved teak. Light fell through the fretwork in lozenges. She slid into the niche behind the last screen and held her breath with the count.

Voices. Women's, and a clink of keys. Then another, warm and unhurried, with a trace of laughter in it.

"No, leave the shutters. I like to hear it."

A courtesy to an attendant. No raised voice. Neela had spent a month learning to fear a woman she had never heard, and the voice was kind. That was the worst thing it could have been.

Skirts went along the passage, away from her. A door closed far off. Forty breaths. Fifty. She counted every one and the passage stayed empty.

*Noon sits audience from the gun,* Chathu had said. *Which means she leaves before it.*

She went along the screens to the third door and into the queen's room.

It was plain. She stood a moment and let the plainness settle. Whitewashed walls. A narrow bed with a grey cover. A table, a stool, a brass lamp, a shelf with eleven books and a gap for a twelfth. A window of shutters left open on the sea, and the sea, huge and flat and bright, filling it. She had expected silk. She had expected a room that told her what the woman was.

On the table lay a stack of petitions as high as her hand. She moved close, because she looked at everything, and read the top one.

*Cheru's widow, of Kalladi. Seed grain for the second sowing, and her husband's last pay.* Under it, in a quick slanting hand, wedged between the lines: *Seed goes tomorrow. Pay is slow; I have paid it from my own purse, and you are not to thank the roll. Hold the well. Nirmala.* The whole name, as if a widow deserved all of it.

She turned over the next. And the next. Every one was answered. Every answer was in that same hand, no clerk's copy, no stamp. Forty petitions, perhaps. Forty people who now believed someone had heard them.

*She signs death writs in the same ink,* Neela thought. The thought did not fit anywhere, so she set the paper back square on the stack.

Under the window, on the floor, stood a chest of red lacquer with a bird picked out in gold.

She knelt. She would wait for the gun. The lid would sing on its hinge and the gun would drown it. She laid her palm flat on the lacquer, which was warm from the sun, and heard the harbour tower take its breath.

*

The gun went off, and the room jumped.

Something took her under the right arm and dragged.

It came from nowhere. A line of fire from ribs to spine, ragged where a blade would be clean, catching and pulling as it went. She knew the shape of it the way she knew a rotten stair. Not a cut. A hook. Something with prongs had gone in and kept going.

She bit down. Her tongue split against her teeth and the copper taste filled her mouth. She did not make a sound. The gun was still rolling off the rock and would have covered a scream, and she kept it in anyway, because the guild had spent twenty years teaching her what to do with a scream.

*Dragging,* she thought. *If it's the start of the drag, I'll know in a minute.*

The welt burned. It did not widen. It did not pull her down. It was hot and weeping along her ribs, soaking the guard's coat, and it held.

*He's alive. He's alive, or he was.* The thought had no floor. She put it aside by force and lifted the lid.

The chest was not locked.

The farm lock hung from the hasp with its shackle up, as if someone had meant to come back and turn it. Her skin went cold. *Opened worse at fourteen,* Chathu had said. She had come with the picks in her cuff and the plan in her head, and the lock had not waited for either.

Inside, on a bed of folded blue cloth, lay a stack of pages.

She counted them with the tip of one finger. Thirty. Each was a stiff pale leaf with an entry in resin-ink black as a beetle's back and still tacky after years. Each had a thin strip of another paper looped to one corner by a twist of green thread. An intake roll. A name and a village, for every one of them. A person.

She did not read the top entry. Her eye caught a number in the corner, a date, and the third line, which was the one that named the shape, and she dropped her eyes before it could settle. A name read in a hurry was a name you carried.

But in the margin, beside the entry, was a small brown bird.

Wings folded. Head turned. Drawn in a fine thin line, like a tick in a ledger.

She had seen it before. She knew where, and the knowing came in pieces. A tally book in her wrap, with the same little bird inked beside the lines marked *by leave*. Thurai boats at Nellimala crossing a bar at

slack water. And the back half of a ledger, thirty cut stubs, a folded bird by each.

*By leave. Whose leave?*

The itch was enormous. She had no hand to scratch it with. Voices in the passage. Not near. A door, a laugh, somebody calling for water. She turned the leaves one by one. Every margin, the same bird. Thirty out of thirty.

She slid the stack into a sheet of oilcloth, folded it flat, and bound it under the guard's coat against her ribs with the long strip she had brought. It sat against the welt like a hand pressing on a bruise. She shut the lid. She left the lock exactly as she found it, shackle up.

At the door she looked back once. The sea filled the window. The petitions lay in their square stack.

She went down.

*

The stair was empty all the way to the landing, and at the landing the sixth bell began.

It was a thin bright sound off the harbour tower, and it was the sound Usha had promised. The pair at the post straightened, said something to each other, and walked off down the lower flight to be relieved, each with one shoulder a little higher than the other from a long standing. Neela pressed into the shadow of the bend and counted.

Sixty breaths for the change. The last twelve with the landing bare.

She reached ten in the dark and the post was empty. She reached twelve with her feet on the stones of the landing and the sea flat as a plate beyond the arch. No wind. If it had been blowing it would have been nine, Usha said.

She crossed in eleven. At the twelfth she was below the post, and the relief came up the stair behind her in a clatter of spears, and no one looked down.

It had fallen to the breath.

A palace guard of eleven years who had measured that landing till she dreamed it could do that. Neela told herself so down the last flight and out through the fish wicket, where porters in wet wraps hauled in the palace's afternoon catch and did not look at her. Nothing in a palace fell to the breath. She had been in houses for a living. She knew which locks were left open and by whom.

Pavi was at the sea steps with the skiff.

"Go round to the salt store," Neela said. "I'll walk."

"You're white."

"I climbed a cliff."

Pavi looked at the front of her coat and said nothing. Then she shoved off.

The cliff path went up from the steps between gull-white rocks and wind-bent thorn. Neela made twenty paces and sat on a stone. Her hands were shaking. She held them out in front of her and watched them do it. They had done everything she asked for an hour and they had saved the shaking for now.

The sun had gone an hour past noon when her left thumb stung.

One.

Two.

Three.

Three small welts, hot and neat, one beside another on the pad of her thumb. An hour late. Late, and not a word, and the oldest word they had.

She put the thumb against her mouth, where the split tongue was, and for a while she did nothing at all.

*Alive.* He had been on the ground, or something had been in him, and now he had a hand free and a tooth to prick with. The bargain had held. He had waited out the hour, and she had waited out the hour, and the not-knowing had cost them each the same. She had told Chathu it was Devan's to carry too. She would say so to his face.

The pages pressed her ribs. She sat on the cliff path in the white afternoon with thirty people against her skin and a thumb that said *I live,* and the success of it was as hollow as a dropped shell.

She stood. She went up to the lane.

*

By dusk the drying shed smelled of salt and old fish and the lamp-oil Usha had brought. Racks of split mackerel hung in rows like the washing of the dead. The side door was bolted. The front door was bolted. The door behind the nets was open a hand's width, and Thilak sat on a crate beside it with his boar's patience and a broken cup of tea.

They came in ones and twos, in plain cloth, with their sashes left in lockers. Neela had learned the names by the second lamp. Sajan, bitter about the queen. Lata, whose brother's wife had had a reply to a petition. Sanu, the youngest, who had carried notes for a year and never read one. Twenty-seven others whose hands she took one at a time, whose mothers' villages she would not know till morning.

Thirty. She counted twice.

She laid the oilcloth on a barrel and did not unfold it.

"I have your pages," she said. "All thirty, and the rolls that go with them. I haven't read them. I won't tonight."

No one moved. Somewhere in the racks a drop of brine fell and was loud.

"Tomorrow at dawn, in this shed, in daylight, I read each one aloud to the one it belongs to, and put it in her hand. After that she holds her own leash, and no one else can read it against her. That's the rule, and it works. I've done it eighty-two times."

"And the room hears our shapes," said Sajan.

"Everyone in it. You'd have new witnesses. I'll ask the room to be only people you chose." She made herself say the rest. "That's the cost. I won't dress it."

"What happens to us after?" said Lata. "When she finds the chest empty."

"She'll know it was me."

"She'll know it was one of us."

"She'll know it was me," Neela said again. "I'll be the one she hunts."

Lata looked at her a long time. Then she looked at her own hands and said, "I'll take my page from the queen's hand, or I'll not take it."

"That's yours to say."

"I'm saying it." She stood. She did not seem angry. She seemed a woman who had finished a sum. "I'm sorry. She's never hurt me."

"I know," Neela said. "That's the trouble."

Hands, then. Kandan wasn't there to count, so Neela asked and counted herself, slow. Usha's went up first and her face did not change at all. Sanu's followed, shaking. Sajan's last, hard, as if it hurt him. Twenty-two. She counted them twice.

Eight stayed down. Lata and seven who gave no reason. They went out one at a time by the net door, and Thilak held it for each, and did not look at their cuffs.

*

It was full dark when the shed emptied. Neela stood in the net door with the cool coming off the harbour and the oilcloth against her ribs, and she did not feel like a woman who had won.

*Too easy.* She had said it on the stair and she said it again. The chest left open. The landing bare to the breath. A voice that kept the shutters open to hear the sea.

"Neela," said Thilak, very quietly. "Look up."

The palace stood on its cliff above the roofs, a black shape cut out of a darker one, studded with a few late lamps. She had stood below it all her childhood and seen nothing but a wall. She knew its windows now by the count: the third door beyond the black one.

One lamp was moving along the outer gallery.

It came out of the long hall's end and went along the cliff wall at a walking pace, steady, held at the height of a shoulder. It passed one window and the next. It turned the corner where the passage began.

It was going toward the queen's room. Toward the red chest, and the lock hanging open with its shackle up.

It did not hurry.

## Chapter 16

# Safe, Unseen, and Mine

The first name Neela read aloud belonged to a boy who had stopped answering to it at seven.

"Intake," she said. She held the leaf nearer the shed's one grey window. Dawn came through the slats in stripes and lay across the mackerel racks. "Chandrika. A tailor's son. Of Pallikara, by the river. Sold at seven."

Sanu stood very still in front of her. He was the youngest of the twenty-two, and he had carried notes for a year without reading one.

"That's me," he said, as if someone else had said it.

"Yes."

"I thought it was a girl's name."

"It was your mother's mother's. It says so, two lines down."

She read the rest. The number. The date, six years back, in a witness's hand. Then the line that named the shape, which she said aloud in the shed's cold light because the rule said she must, in full, before the one it belonged to. Twenty-one people heard it. Sanu closed his eyes. When she folded the leaf into his palm his fingers shut on it like a trap.

"It's yours," she said. "Nobody else can read it against you. Burn it, keep it, eat it."

"Keep it," he said, thickly. "Can I keep it?"

"Anything but give it away."

That was the rule of the work. A page read and handed over, and the room left holding what it had heard. She had done it eighty-two times at the Resin House with the sun on her back. She had not known it would be this hard with a roof on.

She did them in ledger order. Each came forward. Each heard a village that had not been said aloud in fifteen years, a trade, a mother's name. A woman learned she had a sister. A man of thirty with a soldier's walk was a fisherman's son from a place that had since gone under the tide, and he laughed once and sat down on a crate.

Usha came nineteenth.

She came up with her hands open and her sleeves pulled to the knuckle, as she had come up the hill to the Company. Neela read the leaf. Birth name, a hill village, a potter's daughter. Usha's real name was Ushakumari and she had been called Usha the whole time. It was the only name that had survived being sold.

"That's it," Usha said, when Neela finished. Her voice gave nothing.

She took the page. She folded it twice, small, and put it inside her cuff against the pared-flat seam on her wrist. She offered not one word of thanks, and went back to the wall.

Neela noted it the way she noted everything. A woman who had asked no question. A woman who had stood nearest the door since first light.

Twenty-two. When the last had gone out into the lane, blinking, the shed was empty but for Thilak at the net door and the smell of brine.

*

Noon came up the harbour in a long white glare.

Neela sat on a crate with her back to the racks and ate cold rice, because Thilak had put it in her hands and not moved until she did. Pavi had gone to the salt store to sit on Madhavi. Kuttu and Meenu had the front. The pages were gone, every one, into twenty-two cuffs and sashes and hems. Against her ribs there was only the fading ache where a hook had not been.

*Alive.* She had said it to herself for a day. He would be at the cistern shed now, or on a wall. Noon was minutes away. She would prick three times with the thorns in her sash, the right hand this time, so he would feel it clean.

She had the first thorn in her fingers when Thilak lifted his head.

He made no sound. He only turned the broken cup in his hands, once, the way he did when he scented a thing before it came into view. The net door moved. Not a push. A hand, laid flat and patient, and the door swung back a handspan, and then wide.

A woman stood in it with a writing case.

She was not tall. She wore plain grey cotton, a plain wrap, and her hair was greying under a cloth. She was fifty-four. Neela knew the number as she knew the sum of a lock's pins. She knew the voice before the woman opened her mouth.

"May I come in? I would knock, but there is nothing to knock on."

Behind her, a step back, with her sleeves pulled down, stood Usha.

There were no soldiers. Neela looked past both of them, down the alley, to the roofs and the blank wall opposite. No green sash. No spear. Thilak's eyes found hers and asked a question with his whole boar's body. She gave him the smallest shake of her head, and he moved his bulk aside from the door.

The queen came in alone, and every door in the shed was open behind her.

*

"No," she said, when Neela stood. "Sit. I've been walking since first light and I would like to do the same."

She took the second crate. It was low, and she settled on it without fuss, her case across her knees. She looked at the racks of split fish and at the stripes of light. Her face was lined and kind, and tired in a way that had been earned a petition at a time.

"You climbed in by the spray slot," Nirmala said. "My grandfather's masons left it. I've been meaning to ask them to close it for thirty years. I'm glad I never did."

"You left the lock open."

"I did." She did not look away. "I wished to see what you'd take, and what you'd leave. You took the thirty and left the petitions square. That told me more than a good many reports." She unlatched the case. "Usha, would you shut the net door? Thank you."

Usha shut it. She did not look at Neela.

"You told her," Neela said.

"Last night," Usha said. "After the lamp."

"Why?"

"Because you'd run thirty of us into rogue lives before the week was out." Her flat voice cracked at one corner. "Half of us hunted by crown and guild. I wanted you to see the rest before you read the first. And she asked me. She asked, Neela. Nobody has asked me a thing in eleven years."

"That's what a leash does," Neela said. "It asks."

"Yes," said the queen. "And I would like to ask you something, too."

From the case she drew a leaf and laid it on the barrel between them.

It was a fresh page. The paper was still the pale, stiff kind. The ink was black and tacky, and a fly had landed on one corner and could not get free. The hand was a quick slanting hand Neela had read twenty times over in a petition stack.

*Ushakumari, called Usha. Ledger number Nineteen, crown leaf. Night-shape —*

The word was there. Neela did not read past it.

"I wrote it last night," Nirmala said. "In my own hand, after I had fed her tea and heard what she had done. It will never dry; resin-ink doesn't. It has taken, as you see." She laid a finger beside the line, not touching. "You carried away paper. You can't carry away what I saw."

Neela looked at it. The shed stopped being a shed.

*A master who saw you turn can always write you again.* She had been twelve or thirteen. She had stood at the door of Chathu's room and watched him bend over a gnawed page, one that rats had been into, resin-ink blooming wet under his reed. *Kirri's,* he had said, not looking up. He had written it whole inside a quarter hour. Neela had walked away believing she had seen a kindness.

And at the shelter, Kamalakshi had asked it straight, with Vellan's bird in her fingers: *Can anyone else ever hold me?* Neela had given her the rule word for word and heard it ring hollow. She had not liked how fast she said it.

Burn a page and the witness remained. A page was only the memory of a witness, set down in a form that could be read. Anyone who had stood and seen could write it out afresh.

"The pages in the chest were only leaves," she said. Her mouth had gone dry. "You are the page."

"I am the witness." Nirmala said it gently. "I saw every one of the thirty turn, the first time, in a room of mine. I held each hand. That cannot be stolen." She looked at the fly on the corner of the leaf. "I did not tell you in order to frighten you. I told you so that you would not walk out of here believing something that wasn't true."

From the case, once more, she took a sheaf of leaves and set it on the barrel beside Usha's.

They were forty. Neela knew them by their thickness. Black ink, a master's hand.

"Chathu's," the queen said. "I had him write at my table, four evenings. Your forty, from memory. He has a very good memory. He wept for the ones who died. He said he'd never had cause to forget a girl." She did not smile. "These are true pages, and true pages hold. Your forty are mine too, whenever I choose."

Something snagged. Neela saw a cell under the palace rock, and a man's fingertips stained dry grey-brown from common ink. She saw a steward's list of forty names with blanks, and a man who had not answered it. The pictures would not lie flat against the black leaves in

front of her. She reached for the thought and the queen's calm voice went on over it, patient, and it slid away.

*

Neela did not move.

*Whenever I choose.* The words went into her like the hook, and caught, and she breathed through her nose.

"You'll say it at night," she said. "To cage them."

"I will not." The queen's mouth tightened, and for a moment she looked her age. "I have not caged a single one of my own in thirty years, and I will tell you what it cost me not to. But I would be lying if I said I could not. You'd know I was lying, and I don't wish to start that way."

"Why does it matter, what I think?"

"Because I want something from you." Nirmala sat back. "I'll say it plainly, and then you will want to know why I have sat in a fish shed to say it."

Neela waited. Her hands were cold.

"The folded bird," the queen said. "You've seen it. You have a tally book in your wrap. You've been trying for a month to learn whose leave."

"Yours."

"Mine." No shame in it, and no pride either. "Spread for what the realm sees. Folded for what it needn't." She raised one hand, wings flat. Folded it. "I keep a private hand. Everyone who rules does. You'd have found it sooner or later, and I would rather you heard it from me than from a clerk with a reason."

*Whose leave. By leave.* A boat crossing a bar at slack water without a pilot. A man in grey counting children. Neela waited for the rest to come, and the queen watched it not come, and did not offer it.

"Not all of it today," Nirmala said. "I'll not lie and not tell. I'll tell you what you need to answer me. Then you'll go and think."

She folded her hands on the case.

"I want the night-guard. All thirty, as one company, under your command. Not under mine. I will write no pages. Not one. They'll be vouched under the crown, so no hunter in Varanad can lay a finger on them, and you will answer to nobody but the throne, and not often to it." She paused. "And I give Devan back Kettamala. The seal, the warden's office, the garrison's grey. No one would call him harbourer again. Safe, unseen, and mine."

It was the way she said the last of it. *Mine.* It came out of a warm, tired mouth like a coin laid on a table.

"It's a good offer," Neela said.

"It's the best I have."

"Why would I take a leash from a hand that's kind?"

"You wouldn't have one. That's what I am offering." Nirmala did not look away. "I'd not even hold the pages. The thirty could burn theirs tonight and I'd stand over the fire. You'd have the knives, and I would have a night-guard that obeyed the woman who freed it, and Varanad would not go dark when the Thurai land."

"They've landed."

"They have." The queen's eyes did not change. "And I have kept a promise to my own people, which I may not break. You will want to ask about it. Not today."

Neela turned the words over, and one stuck.

"There's a better way," she said. "I know it. I've done it. An odiyan says her own shape, aloud, in her own voice, to one person she chooses, at the dusk turning. It voids every other witness. Every one. You. Chathu. The room. After that nobody can cage her without her. It's the only way to be free of all of you at once."

"I know." The queen's voice was very quiet. "I have known it for nine days. Usha told me what a ledger page does when it burns by itself."

"Then you know what it costs."

"Do you?"

It was not a taunt. It was a question put, patiently, to a woman who had been paying the cost since a night at the Resin House with a bleeding wrist.

"You'll have thirty pairs," Nirmala said. "Thirty odiyans each bound to a chosen person, and each pair feeling every wound the other takes. A spear in a night-guard's thigh is a spear in her husband's thigh, her sister's. They bleed for each other for life. And every one of them marked rogue, because the guild cannot vouch for a page that has burned. Your Company will be the freest knives in Varanad, and also the most precious, because every blade has a heart in the shape of a wound. You'll have made them precious, and precious knives don't win wars."

Neela didn't answer.

"I'm not saying it to wound you," Nirmala said. "I'm saying it because I've watched what a wall does to a man whose wife stands on the other side of it. I would not like to watch it thirty times."

*A thumb. Three welts, an hour late.* Neela had sat on a cliff path with her split tongue against the pad of it, and for some time she had not been a woman who needed anything.

She had told herself it was freedom. Freedom was belonging to no one. She had said it to Ammu at fourteen, and to Chathu in a locked room, and to a man on a rampart in the dusk with resin on her wrists. She had meant it as armour.

And the only time in twenty-seven years she had not been owned, she had been tied to a man by a wound that opened when he cut his chin shaving.

*The only freedom I have ever had,* she thought, *is the one that bleeds when he does.*

She would not know how to say it. She did not say it.

"You've not yet asked about him," Nirmala said, "and you have asked about nothing else with your eyes. So I will say it. A rider leaves the Salt Gate for Kettamala at dusk with the same offer in my hand. Three hundred crown spears for the pass, and the fort given back. If his wife takes command. If she does not, the rider turns round."

Neela's hands, in her lap, closed.

"He will have it before you do," the queen said. "I thought you would rather know."

"You've priced him."

"I've priced his old office. Which is not the same as pricing him, and you know it. But I'll own it's a lever, and I won't pretend otherwise." The queen's tired face was gentle. "It is a hard thing, to hold a lever on a person one respects. I would not have done it to a stranger."

*He'll get a letter that says his house for my answer. And I can't answer before the rider does.* She had no right to decide his life, and no right to let someone else decide it either. His fort. His father's seal on a nail. Raiu's pyre. A garrison who had saluted him fist by fist at the gate.

If she said yes, she bought it for him. If she said no, she kept it from him, and he would never have asked her to.

"I want time," she said.

"You'll have it. Until the pass." Nirmala stood, and the crate scraped, and she was a plain woman with a case in her hand. "You'll be going north to him, and I will be sending what I send. Answer me there. Not before, if you'd rather. I won't ask twice."

She took up the leaf with Usha's name on it, and blew once across the tacky ink. Then she laid it on top of the forty on the barrel and left them both there.

"Keep them," she said. "A witness who tells you what she holds is one you can bargain with. The other kind does not tell."

At the net door she stopped, one hand on the post.

"Thirty is a great many people to have against your ribs," she said. "I know the weight. Don't carry them alone."

She went out. Usha went after her without looking back.

*

Thilak shut the door.

Neela sat very still. The light on the barrel was white now, high, falling straight down through the slats. Two stacks of pages lay before her, and the fly in the corner of one leaf had stopped moving.

*Noon.*

Counting was the one habit that never left her. She went back over the last quarter hour and found where the count had broken: the gun had gone, a dull blow through the rock and the racks, and she had not felt it. Somewhere between *May I come in* and *a lever, and I won't pretend otherwise*, the harbour tower had fired and she had been sitting with a thorn in her fingers.

Her hand opened on it. The pad of her thumb was smooth.

The gun had come and gone without her.

A day behind, she had pricked early. Now late, the gun a quarter hour gone, and no word. And he would sit on a wall or a ladder rung with a stitched side and listen for a pain that was not his own, and hear nothing, and know what nothing could mean.

She took the thorns out of her sash. Three, in a row. She put the point to her thumb and pressed.

One. Two. Three.

Blood came up in three small beads. She watched them, and knew, as she knew a rotten stair, that she would carry the offer north to a man who would already have answered.

"Thilak," she said. "How far to the Hill Gate, on foot?"

"Eleven hundred paces." He studied her. "Neela. What did she want?"

"Everything," Neela said. "She offered it all."

She wiped the thumb on her coat. Then she took up the pages, Usha's on top, the fly still stuck to its corner, and began to count how many hours there were between this barrel and a pass she could not yet answer at.

## Chapter 17

# The Price of an Office

Noon came and went and nothing happened to his thumb.

Devan stood on the shelf with a sheaf of arrows in the crook of his arm, careful of the stitches at his ribs, and counted them for the third time. Forty. There was no gun here to mark the hour. There was the sun climbing over the east lip of the cut, and the shadow of the shelf wall shortening to nothing at his feet. He had watched it shorten with the whole of his attention while he told off arrows.

He held his left thumb in his right hand beneath the sheaf, where nobody could see him do it.

*She's on the road.* Two hands on the reins, a horse under her, a lime thorn in a sash she couldn't reach. That was one reason. There were two more and he had built all three with care. The fourth he had not built, and it stood outside them like a man at a door.

A welt meant a wound. No welt meant no wound. That was all the silence could tell him, and he made himself take only that and put the rest down.

"Thirty-nine," said Muthu.

"Forty."

"That's the third time you've counted that sheaf, and the second time you've got forty." Muthu sat on an upturned bucket by the handcart he had dragged down the cut at midmorning. Eleven sheaves, bound in wet cloth. He had brought a flask of the gate-house tea too, and his big

laugh, which the shelf had needed more than the arrows. "I've known you twenty years. You don't miscount. You hold the number and let it go."

"The sheaf's short."

"The sheaf's fine." Muthu grinned at him. Then the grin went out of his face, because down the cut, thin and clear, a horn had started. Two long notes. A short. A long.

The crown's riders. Bhaskaran's code, carried a mile down the stone.

Devan set the arrows in the cart and let go of his thumb.

*

The rider came up the cut leading a horse that had stopped being a horse some miles back and become a lather on four legs. He wore a green sash and the grey of the road. He had changed mounts at four posts, and he said so the way another man would show a warrant.

"For the Warden of Kettamala," he said, and stopped. His eyes went to the plain brown cloth Devan wore, and to the captain with the iron disc at his belt. "Captain. Sir. I was told—"

"Devan."

"Devan." The rider drew a case from his saddle. "Her own hand. I was to put it in yours and no one's."

Green wax. The sunbird, spread. Devan thumbed it up and read standing.

The body was in a clerk's round hand, tidy as a row of stitches. It offered what he had known it would offer, because he had been waiting for it since the day Rema left the fort. Kettamala restored. The seal, the office, the garrison's grey. The charge of harbouring struck off the roll. And three hundred crown spears sent up the cart road to hold the pass. They would climb on the day his wife took command of the night-guard, as one company under the throne's protection. *The same is put to her in Kodiyur.*

Below it, a few lines in a quick slanting hand.

*You will think it a lever. It is. I would sooner you thought so than that I pretended. N.*

He read it twice. Then he read the middle again, slowly, as if the words might be a different size the third time.

The trouble was not that it was clever. The trouble was that he wanted it.

He wanted it the way a man wants water. The iron seal on its nail in the hall. Janu's kitchen his again. The grey coats at the padippura, and the west stair, and the cistern chain that clanked the hours so that he slept through them. Raiu's pyre had been lit in that court. Every night for five years he had told himself he did not mind being warden, and he had not known until a sheet of paper laid it out in black ink how much he minded losing it.

And the arithmetic wasn't pride. He did it, because arithmetic was what he had. Fourteen hundred on the road. A shelf wall held by thirty-six odiyans, each one spending a night in shape and a day in shaking hunger, and by garrison men who had never been asked to be anyone's wall. The chalked tile in Kandan's hand already ran to four names, and it had been a week. Three hundred spears at the narrows would be a different war. They would be a different kind of morning for Kesu's people, and the hill villages. Too late for a boy from Kalladi who had carried a spear taller than himself, but not too late for the next one.

He knew the shape of the thing anyway. Vouched, unhunted, and a knife in a drawer. The old cage with a better roof.

"Well?" said Muthu, quietly.

"Read it."

Muthu read it. He read it with his lips still, the way he did when he was working a hard line. Halfway down he looked up and said nothing, and it was not the quiet of a man lying. It was the other quiet, the one Devan had learned to tell apart. A man holding his breath between two good things.

"Devan," he said at last. "That's three hundred spears."

"I can count."

"Seventy-odd of you against that host. There's Kesu's people behind the line. There's a goat-boy at the fort and a woman at the well with a baby. If it's a yes, they live." Muthu touched the iron disc at his belt. "And this is mine now, and a yes takes it off me. I'd hand you the disc tonight and be glad of it. So hear me as a man with nothing to win." His big hands opened. "Nobody's asking you to like what you'd say yes to. It's the pass."

"I know what it is."

"Then say yes and let her sort the rest."

"That's the part I can't do."

He said it flatly, because it was the only way he had of saying anything. The rider had gone very interested in his horse's girth.

*Let her sort the rest.* Her name in the queen's mouth, and thirty lives in the Company riding on how she answered it, and the first thing the queen had done was price his fort against her yes. If he wrote *yes* to buy the pass, the answer would be his before it was hers. If he waited for her to come up the cut with the fort lying on the table between them, she would answer with it on her back. Whichever way she went, she would carry what it cost him.

"I'll answer now," he said. "Here, in front of you, and the rider. Muthu, you'll witness it."

"As seal-holder?"

"As a man who watched."

*

He wrote it on the lid of the arrow cart, in plain ink, with the rider's pen. He read each line aloud as he made it. It was not for the rider's benefit. A thing said where others can hear it cannot later be made smaller.

*To Nirmala, queen of Varanad. I have your letter. It is not mine to answer. My wife's answer is hers. I will not buy the pass with it, nor sell her to buy back a fort. I will hold the pass with whoever chooses to stand. If three hundred spears come with no price on her, I will thank you for them. If*

*they come with one, I will hold without them. Devan, son of the warden of Kettamala.*

Muthu read it over his shoulder and said, "You've put a hole in your own wall."

"Yes."

"You could say *with conditions*. Take the spears and let her decide the command after."

"A condition is a yes with her name on the price."

Muthu breathed out through his nose. "She's two days up the road, if she rides as she climbs."

"The rider goes at first light."

"Then wait one night. Ask her."

"I would." Devan heard how it sounded and said it anyway. "We made a term, she and I. Say it before you do it. It was a good term. I'm doing it first."

The words hung over the cart lid between them. He had made that term in a tack room with rain coming through two roof leaks, and he had been proud of keeping it. It had held through a ledger, a raid, a hearing, a road. Now he would put his thumb to a letter she hadn't seen. She would hear it from the queen's mouth, or a clerk's, or his, and the order of it would matter more to her than the words.

*I owe her this.* He added it to the list he did not like.

He had no seal. The disc was Muthu's. He melted a bead of plain black wax over the rider's lamp and pressed his left thumb into it, the thumb she pricked. The print came up whorled and plain.

"Witnessed," Muthu said. He signed under it with the pen held like a tool. He didn't laugh when he gave it back.

Devan took a second leaf from the rider's case and wrote shorter.

*Justice Rema, Kodiyur. A roll is wanted at the Monkey Pass, north side, within the week. I am without office and the crown gives me no leave to call you. Come as recorder. Whatever is done here, held or lost, should be written by one who writes what is. Devan.*

"Rema?" said Muthu. "You'd call her here?"

"She entered Asha by name. She wrote down an execution she couldn't stop." He folded the leaf. "She records against the crown. That's the only kind of recorder I'd trust with this."

The rider took both, tucked them into his sash, and went down the cut leading his spent horse. He walked like a man who had just carried something heavy and did not know what.

*

The light went amber in the cut. Down the shelf, the wall pairs changed. The Company had its human night by rotation, and half were out of their shapes and hungry, hunched round a pot of rice that smelled of very little.

Vellan sat in the lee of the wall, on a flat stone near Thulasi's blanket. The big man had a knife and a block of pale wood, and the beginning of a bird in his hands. Thulasi slept with her cracked leg propped on a saddle. Vellan did not look up when Devan sat down.

"They're asking each other," Vellan said, after a while.

"Who?"

"The Company. Who they'd name, if they named. It's the sally. All that talk of shared wounds, and Neela's welts on your thumb, and who you'd trust to carry yours." The knife took a curl of wood. "Kuttu asked me."

"What did you say?"

"That I'll not bind to anyone." Another curl. "I've handed enough people my wounds."

It lay there between them. Devan knew the sum of that. Everyone on the shelf who had heard that sentence would hear it differently, and he, who had stood at the bottom of a stair at twenty-six with Janu holding a lamp, heard it the one way he could. He turned a pebble over in his pocket and found nothing to do with his hands.

He had not asked for Asha's last words. They would come when Vellan decided they were earned, and not a day before. He had let a man walk away from a reading with his back turned, and counted forty-one

steps. He had not forgiven him. He had never said so, and the man had never asked.

"Then I'll mind your back," Devan said.

Vellan's hands stopped.

Slowly he turned his head. His face did what Devan had not seen it do in all the weeks: it slackened, and then it broke. A low sound came out of him, rusty, like a gate that had not opened in years. It took a moment to know it for a laugh. Thulasi stirred in her blanket and muttered. Vellan put a hand over his mouth, and the sound went on in his chest.

"You," he said.

"Me."

"I know whose back you'd be minding."

"I know whose it is." Devan kept his voice level. "I'm not forgiving you. I'm standing behind you. Those are different."

Vellan considered that for the length of one slow breath. The laugh had gone out of his face and something steadier had come in.

"They're different," he said. "That's what I'll have."

He went back to the bird. Devan stayed on the stone while the light drained out of the cut and the first oil lamp was lit down the line.

*

At dusk the old watcher called him to the lip.

Koman lay on his belly on the rock above the shelf, his nose lifted into the wind, the way he had done in the pass village for eleven years. Devan lay down beside him. Below them the cut dropped to the river, and beyond the narrows the cart road climbed in a long grey switchback.

Something was coming up it, and the noise of it reached them before the sight. Oxen. A groaning of axles, and a rhythm of men on ropes, sixty at least, chanting low in a language he did not have.

It rounded the bend like a house climbing a hill.

Ship-timber, black with tar. Three men high on a cart bed, lashed hides hung wet from its flanks against fire, a roofed platform at the top and slits cut in its face. A tower. It rolled a hand's breadth at a time. Be-

hind it came a flat supply cart with a pale square on its tailboard, and painted there in fresh bright yellow, a small bird. Clean paint. He looked at it a moment longer than he needed to.

*Three men high.* He measured the shelf wall by eye. An archer on that platform would look down on every man behind it.

He opened his mouth to say so to Koman, and the old man's hand closed on his sleeve.

"There," Koman said. "In the river."

The river ran below the narrows, brown and quick, past the shingle where the cut met the road. Something broke its surface. A long dark back, low and slick, with no head to speak of. Then a tail, thick at the root, trailing like a rope. It crossed against the current with no hurry, the way a thing swims that has done it all its life. It was longer than an otter and heavier than any river-beast in the hills.

It came up on the near bank, our side, onto wet stones, and stood in the last light. The water streamed off it. Then it went into the thorn below the shelf, and the thorn closed.

"Is it ours?" Devan said.

"None of ours is that. None of ours would be out." Koman's nose was working. Eleven years he had walked the hill edge reading what the House's shapes left behind, a civet from a hare, a jackal from a fox, a bear's old musk three days cold. His voice had gone very small. "I've a name for every scent the Resin House ever made, warden. I've no name for that."

Devan let him have the word. He had given up the office that morning and the old man hadn't noticed.

Above them the tower groaned another hand's breadth up the road, and the sun went off the lip of the cut.

## Chapter 18

# Twenty-Two Riders

"Safety isn't a small thing," Lata said. "Say what you like about it."

She said it to the road ahead, not to anyone. The road was red dust, a day north of the last post, and twenty-eight horses were raising it in a long tail behind them. Neela rode at the front and heard every word.

"Nobody's saying small," said Sanu.

"You are. Every time you open your mouth." Lata rode with her back straight and her cuffs buttoned to the knuckle. She was Third Guard, the one who had refused her page in the fish shed and would take it only from the queen's hand. She had come anyway. She had been at the Salt Gate at dusk with a horse and no explanation. "A vouched name. A roof with a lamp in it. No hunter on the road who may lay a hand on you. Thirty years she hasn't caged one of us. Tell me what the hill has given you that matches that."

"It gave me a brother," Sanu said.

Nobody answered. The hooves went on. Neela knew the rest of it, because she had read it aloud at dawn four days back, in a shed that smelled of brine. Sajan's leaf had come ninth. *Pallikara, a tailor's son, sold at nine, one brother younger, sold at seven.* Sanu had been standing by the door. Both men had gone the colour of ash, and neither had spoken until the shed emptied.

"He hasn't said yes," Sanu said now, lower. "I know he hasn't. I only want to be asked what I'd do with the yes."

"Then ask him," said Lata.

"I've asked him. He says he'd bleed for me and he'd rather not." Sanu laughed, a short wrecked sound. "That's the nicest thing he's said to me in twenty years. I think he meant it kindly."

Sajan, riding twenty paces back, kept his eyes on his horse's ears. Neela did not turn her head.

Usha rode at the rear with her sleeves pulled down. At the Hill Gate the queen had put a strip of paper in her hand, folded small and sealed in green wax with the sunbird. She had not let Usha break it. She had said the line aloud, so that Neela heard it too, in that warm unhurried voice: *Ride with her. Press nothing.* Usha had carried it unbroken ever since. At the third post, when the stable-master saw twenty-eight riders and began to ask questions, she held the strip up whole, sunbird to the lamp. He fetched fresh horses and asked nothing more. She tucked it back in her sash, where it rode all day behind Neela's shoulder like a hand not quite laid on her.

*

The offer was honest. That was what made it hard.

Neela turned it over for the hundredth time while the road dropped into a dry riverbed and climbed out again. Thirty knives under her hand. No page on any of them, vouched under the crown, no hunter allowed within a day's ride. No one would need to name themselves to anyone, and so no one would need to bleed. A spear in a night-guard's thigh would be a spear in a night-guard's thigh. Nobody's husband. Nobody's sister.

She would be their protector. She'd be no one's master, and everyone's. And she would never have to stand in front of a living person and ask them to bleed for her.

That was the part she kept coming back to. Not the fort, not the lever. She had asked it of Ammu without knowing she was asking, and Ammu had paid. She would not ask it of thirty more.

*Safe, unseen, and mine.* Warm in the mouth. A coin laid on a table.

Against her saddle, under the flap, lay Chathu's tin. She had taken it from the cell because her hand did it before she thought. She had eaten one, in his cell, standing, and it had been perfect, and that was the worst of it. She had not touched another. It rode against her thigh all day, warm still from some fire she had not seen, and she did not open it.

*A gift is the start of a bill.* The queen had given her no sweets. She had given her a fly stuck on a page and a hand held out flat.

"Neela," said Thilak, riding at her stirrup. "You've stopped breathing again."

"I haven't."

"You hold it on the climbs." He didn't look at her. "It's all right. I only count."

*

They made camp in a dry grove off the road on the third night, under teak trees with the leaves gone leathery and brown. Nobody smeared. It had been Devan's last order before she left, and the Company had carried it out of the shelter on its back. The air went blue and the stars came on over the hill road. Twenty-eight odiyans and guards sat round a small fire in their own skins.

Neela walked to the stream with her cloth and her kit and a bar of the brown soap Pavi had bought from a tinker.

For five days she had worn a green starched cuff and a throat paste of lime and ochre. It had dried chalky and cracked when she swallowed. She knelt by the water and began to wash it off. The paste came away in grey ropes, and the water took it, and under it lay the scars.

She heard them come up behind her. She had known they would.

She did not turn. She scrubbed until the skin stung. She undid the cuffs and rolled them back, the green cotton, the wedding bangle under

the left one, and laid her wrists on her knees with the palms up. Throat. Wrists. The pale thick ridges, layered over each other like a tree's rings. Eleven years' worth.

Then she stood and walked back to the fire and sat down in the light with every inch of it showing.

Nobody spoke. The queen's guards were pared smooth at the wrist and painted at the neck. A surgeon had taken their scars once a season, and they'd learned to think of it as care. Sanu looked at his own cuff, and then at hers.

"Does it hurt?" he said. "The real kind. Still."

"The burn's the first night. After that it's the morning." She turned her wrist to the fire. "I don't hide mine. I'm not telling you not to. I just want you to see what it looks like when you leave it."

"A question for a question?" Kuttu said.

He had come up on the other side with a pot of rice. He was Kumaran, a ferryman's son, not yet thirty, and it had been his idea in the first place to call the forty a Company. He sat down hard and began to ladle.

"That's how they did it in the Resin House," he said. "Nobody told us. You get a question if you give one."

"We did it at the long table," Neela said. "I'd forgotten."

"I haven't," said Madhavi, and sat.

So it went, as the rice went round. Meenu asked Lata what the queen had given her that nobody could take back, and Lata said, after a long moment, "A name that was always mine. She called me by it before anyone else." Thilak asked Sajan why he'd served the queen so long, and Sajan said, "Because I thought if I was useful enough, she'd tell me where my brother was." That was a harder answer. The fire cracked. Sanu put his head down.

Lata turned to Neela. She did it the way she did everything, straight on. "What does it cost, then? The name. I want the cost, not the poem."

Neela told her. She gave the cut that opened on someone else, the fever that dragged another body toward the ground, the three welts on a

thumb an hour late. She said she'd had the ache, and the forced resin, and a man's wound opening across her side in the Resin House yard. Then she said the rest, because it was the question.

"I've never felt so tied in my life. And I've never been less owned."

"Both?" said Lata.

"Both." She held her wrist to the light. "It took me a month to learn those are different."

Lata looked at her a long time. "I don't know that I'd pay it," she said.

"No. You don't have to. That's why I won't take the offer by myself."

It was out before she had looked at it. She sat there while it went round the fire, face by face. Usha, beyond the light, had lifted her head.

*

Later, when the others slept, Kuttu sat with her on the stream bank. He didn't ask. He turned a stick in the coals and it threw sparks.

She did not know she was humming until he went quiet to listen.

It was the old tune. Ammu's, the fishing song she'd hummed at nine and twelve and twenty-four, when her hands were busy and her head was not. It had no tidy words. Neela had made up the half she didn't know.

"Pull and pull," she sang, under her breath. "The tide is coming in."

"I know that one," Kuttu said. "My father's ferry crew sang it. Different tune." He hummed his version, flat, slower. "Where'd you get it?"

"From someone who heard it at a net-mender's knee." She stopped. *A net-mender behind the sheds,* Ammu had always said, *taught us both the hitch.* There had been no net-mender behind the sheds. There had been Ammini, a net-mender of Nellimala, and her hands, which Neela's fingers had carried up the goat path without her. Maybe a girl of seven had tied it for a smaller girl, and Ammu had never had the heart to say whose knot it was.

She sat with that, and then with the other thing it knocked loose.

Three short yips. A pause. One long rising note. *Tomorrow, I will find you.* She had heard it a hundred times as a child, from a girl with a gap in her teeth. She had heard it a last time in the Resin House yard,

from a jackal's throat, the dusk Ammu drew Vellan and the hunters off. Neela had stood there in shape and could not answer.

She had always taken it for a goodbye. A promise Ammu had broken because she died.

But Ammu had given it on the nights Neela went off alone to settle something that was not hers alone. The stone empty, the cup bare, and that thin cry from the spur. It had never meant *I'll arrive.* It had meant *don't decide without me.*

"What?" said Kuttu.

"Nothing." Her throat hurt. "I only just heard what she was saying."

He didn't push. He threw the stick on the fire.

She lay awake after, on her back, with the stars. She tried the queen's offer one more way. If she took it, nobody would bleed for her. She would give the Company safety, and she would also hold the door shut on the choice she had made at a dusk turning, with a man looking at her. The only freedom she had ever had was the one she had been given, and had given back.

She could not decide that alone. Ammu had said so across a season and a grave. It wasn't hers to decide. It belonged to the forty-two with a page in a cuff, and a plank of names, and a man on a shelf who held the same offer in his own hands and would call it a lever, if he had any sense.

The Company voted on resin, on a sally, on a hill. It would vote on this.

And Devan would have a voice among theirs. He had said so himself, in the shelter, with no office: *If the hands say no, I sit by this fire and hate it.*

She was afraid of it.

She had watched him do it the morning the hands sent her south. He had put a river pebble in his cheek before the count, so that whatever he felt would stay behind his teeth until the last hand was up. Then he had said *yes* to the result. One flat word, level and careful, for the pass, for Kesu's people, for a boy in a red headcloth. He had said it the way a man

shuts a gate on his own fingers and keeps his face still. She had not been able to tell what it cost him. She had only seen that he could pay it.

That voice would say yes to the queen. Or a no said for her sake, so that she'd never know whether she had wanted him to say yes. Either way he would say it gently, and she would have to stand there and hear it.

She fell asleep counting the stars she could name, and she knew only four.

*

They climbed the last day without stopping. The road bent west, steepened, and went to stones. By afternoon the langurs had gone silent on the cliff faces, and she did not need Thilak to say what that meant. Strangers on the road. The Thurai, or the hunger of them.

Nobody sang. Even Lata rode without a word. They went up through thorn and scree, up past the lightning-split boulder where the goat path left the cart road, and Neela knew the place without a map, and for once did not wonder why. She did not slow.

The sun was a hand off the west rim when they crested the shoulder above the pass.

Below them, past a long fall of rock, the cut lay in its own blue shadow. A thread of river. A shelf of stone beneath the cliff, small as a hearth-ledge at this height. There was smoke over it. Not the cooking smoke of a camp. A thick black column leaning with the wind.

She gathered the reins.

The first sting came in her left palm. It was like a bee, small and bright. She ignored it. Then the right went, and the ones that followed were not stings. Heat rose under her skin, across the pad of each hand, along the base of each finger, slow and then fast. She looked down. The leather of the reins had not changed. The skin under it was lifting, white, in two bubbles the size of a thumbprint, and then in four.

She did not cry out. She made a sound in her throat and her horse tossed its head.

"Neela?" That was Thilak.

She held both hands up. The blisters shone in the low light. She turned them over, back and front, the way a woman looks for a splinter. The skin wasn't broken. It was only burned.

*Fire.* Not hers. She had touched nothing hot. Somewhere below, under that column of smoke, a man had taken hold of something that was alight, with his bare hands, and had not let go.

"Ride," she said. "All of you. Now."

And she put her heels in, blistered palms on the reins, and went down toward the smoke.

## Chapter 19

# Fire on the Shelf

The tower was burning against the shelf wall, and Devan was at the lip with a ladder on fire in his hands.

Neela saw it from the last bend of the cut, over her horse's ears. Black timber, three men high, wearing flame like a coat. The wet hides on its flanks had gone to hissing rags. A Thurai ladder hung from the platform to the wall, its iron hooks bitten into the stone, and it was alight from the rungs to the lashings. A man stood at its foot with his bare hands on the burning wood. He heaved. The ladder swung out, hung, and fell away into the dark with its climbers screaming.

Her palms screamed with him.

"Down," she said. "Walk them. Don't gallop on the scree."

Nobody argued. Twenty-eight horses came down the cut in a line, and the Company's wall pairs turned to stare. Someone shouted *Riders!* in a cracked voice. She did not stop to learn whose. She counted the steps from the stirrup to the stone, fourteen, and Thilak was beside her at nine, holding out his hand.

"The pot," he said. "Noon trees. Even pinches, the way we voted."

He had a clay bowl on a flat rock behind the wall, black and shining. She tipped her banana-leaf fold into it, all six pinches she had carried to Kodiyur and back. Then she took one from the bowl with a fingertip, the same as anyone. Behind her, Usha cracked the green wax off a flat tin she had carried from the palace store, and the queen's guards crowded

round it. Crown resin. It smelled the same. The hands that took it were pared smooth at the wrist.

The sun went off the rim. The cut turned blue.

She ran along the wall with the pinch in her fist. Devan was on his knees by the lip, his back to her, his hands held out from his body like a man carrying hot bowls. The skin of both palms was gone to a raw red shine. He was breathing through his teeth.

"Don't touch anything," she said.

He turned his head. His face was black with smoke, and he looked at her as though she were a sentence in a language he was relearning.

"You're early," he said.

"I'm late."

"You're here." He glanced at her hands, which she was holding exactly as he held his. "It's the same."

"It's the same."

There was no time for more. Over his shoulder a second ladder was swinging up out of the dark, and the tower groaned as its platform leaned. She crouched where she was and rubbed the resin hard across her throat and wrists. It burned as it always did, like a hot coal pressed to the old ridges. She kept her eyes on him.

Devan kept his on her. But he lifted his voice down the wall, hoarse and flat. "Pairs! Face the road. Backs to the shelf. Count sixty and don't turn round."

Nobody asked why. They had heard that voice in the dark before. Thirty heads swung outward, and thirty backs went square to her.

He had no pebble in his cheek. He had no time to find one. He watched her hands, and then her face, for the whole minute.

A minute is a long time. It was long enough for the hook of a ladder to bite the stone beside his knee. He planted one boot on the shank and kicked it loose without looking away, and the ladder went down the wall behind him. Her spine bent. Her hands went. The cut turned from blue to the bright, hard grey of the other one's eyes, and every smell on the

shelf stood up and spoke at once: tar, scorched hide, wet iron, sweat, a man's blood.

His blood. Under the smoke, close, a thin line of it.

*Behind you,* she thought, and could not say it, and went past him to the lip.

*

The other one did not think about sides.

She thought about edges. The wall had one, the platform had one, and between them was a gap of air a man could cross in a leap. Six Thurai came over it with bronze caps and short swords, half-blind in their own smoke. She met the first before his feet touched stone.

Behind her the shelf was changing.

She felt it more than saw it. The queen's riders were turning along the wall: Usha, Sanu, Sajan, Lata, and the eighteen who had come with them. Gold eyes in the dusk, and low long backs, and the sound a body makes when it comes out of itself. A fox. A heron, struck on one leg and coming down like a dropped knife. A dark creature with a snout and a thick, patient gait. She had never seen them in shape. They had been palace knives for years, kept in cuffs and paste, and they had never fought for a thing they chose.

They fought as if they had been waiting.

No page. No hand on a lead. Nobody at their backs tonight who could say a word and cage them. But the queen had watched every one of them turn, and she was alive, and the road behind them led straight to her. It was not far enough. The guards fought as though they knew it, and as though it made the night worth more. They went along that wall in a loose line and nobody told them where. She watched the fox take a man at the hamstring and be gone before the sword turned. She watched the heron strike a hook-rope and cut it with her beak.

*Unbound,* she thought, and was glad past all reasoning.

Then the second wave came over the gap, and she stopped watching.

Her left flank was open. She knew it as she knew a bad stair. A Thurai spear came at her ribs, low, and she twisted from it, and a weight she knew landed at her back.

Devan.

Spear in his scorched hands. He should not have been able to hold it. She smelled the blood from his palms as he gripped the shaft. He stood with his shoulders against her hip, not touching, then touching, then pressing the way a man leans on a wall he trusts.

"Left," he said, over her head. "Four. The big one."

She went left.

He did not call her name, or the other word, or any word that mattered to the dark. He called targets. They had learned that from the sally. She went where he told her, and where he did not, and each time she moved he moved with her so that her back was never open for longer than a breath. The spear came round once and took a man's blade on its haft just as her jaws closed on another's arm.

A sword caught his forearm. She felt it before he did. A bright line of heat ran down her own foreleg, shallow, a welt and no more. She did not miss her step. He grunted, and the grunt told her it was nothing, and he drove the butt of the spear into the swordsman's face.

Across the shelf a heavy shape had stopped. Kandan had turned round at last, sixty counts gone, with a sword in one hand and a chalk tile stuck in his belt. He was staring. Not at the Thurai. At the two of them.

Beyond him, the fox.

Usha had a man by the wrist and had forgotten to bite. She looked at the pair with her pale muzzle lifted, one breath, two. Then she let the man go to the wall's edge, where he fell on his own, and trotted along the stones to where Sajan stood bleeding at the foot of a ladder. She turned and set her back against his. He flinched. Then he shifted his weight to take her, and neither of them looked round.

The tower gave way at the middle watch.

It went all at once, with a long cracking groan, as the burned beam under the platform let go. The top of it folded outward and came down across the gap in a rain of sparks. Men fell with it. A roar went up from the shelf, and under it, from the river road, a ragged horn called the Thurai back.

She stood on the wall with her ribs heaving, and Devan stood at her back, and neither moved for a long time.

*

The first grey came up the cut like water into a footprint.

Neela crouched behind the wall, back in her own skin, teeth chattering. Hunger hit her as it always did, hollow and shaking, as if her bones had been scraped. She reached for the cloth. It was already in front of her, held out behind a man's back, warm.

She wrapped it round her. It had been inside his coat. The warmth was his.

"How many dawns?" she said. Her voice came out cracked. "Since I left."

"I lost count after nine," said Devan, to the wall. "I've warmed that cloth every one."

"You couldn't have known I'd be here."

"No." He turned, then, and offered her a leaf packet of cold rice and curd and a cup. The water in the cup steamed. "I did it anyway. You said cold water hurts your teeth."

She had said that in the dark, a long time ago, on a night when neither of them had meant it to matter. She took the cup in both hands, and the blisters cried out against the clay, and she drank anyway.

They sat with their backs against the wall and watched the tower. It was ash. A tall black stump of beam stood in the middle of a wide grey scar, smoke feathering off the top. Garrison men were poking through it with spears. The Thurai had left a ladder-hook in the stone, still bright. Someone had chalked a tile, and Kandan was standing over it, not writing.

"How many?" she said.

"Two of ours. Chami's cousin, and a woman from Kalladi I didn't know." He said the names carefully. "Seven hurt. The wall held. That's all I can count to."

"The guards?"

"All twenty-two. Three limping." His mouth moved. "Lata took a man off the wall by the belt. In shape. I saw her. She'll tell you she didn't."

She almost laughed. She held out her hands instead.

Her palms were white and puffy, the skin lifted over the heel of each hand. His lay beside them, on his knees, and they matched down to the line across the base of the thumb. He saw her looking. He turned his over, and she turned hers, and for a moment neither of them could tell which of them had been burned.

"Yours were first," she said.

"Yours came while I was holding it."

"Both, then."

"Both." He found a pot in his coat, Pavi's green salve, smelling of crushed leaf and smoke, and began, with his teeth, to unstop it. She took it out of his hand and did it herself. She laid the salve on his palms with the flat of her fingers, light, and the answering coolness came in her own, a half-breath behind. He shut his eyes.

"The noon signal," she said. "I know you waited."

His eyes opened. "I'd have waited longer."

"I couldn't. The queen was at my elbow." She kept her voice flat, because it was the only way to say it. "Noon, the day after the gun. She walked into the drying shed, and she sat beside me the whole hour. She's gentle. She doesn't need to be anything else. I had three thorns in my sash and I couldn't put my hand to them in front of her. If I'd flinched, she'd have wanted to know what I was reaching for."

"You did right."

"I know. I hated it." She wiped the salve from her fingers on the cloth. "I pricked a quarter hour late, once she'd gone. Two noons on, I

was on a post-horse at a gallop and couldn't loose a hand from the rein. You'd have stood on the shelf with a sheaf of arrows and a thumb that did nothing. I knew that, and I rode on."

"It did nothing," Devan said, "and I counted the arrows three times." His mouth twitched. "Muthu says I'm the worst liar he's ever known when I'm worried."

"You don't lie."

"I do arithmetic."

It was the closest to a joke he'd made in days, and it was bad, and she took it like bread. She leaned her shoulder against his. He did not move away. The sun was a thin line on the east lip, and the wall beside them was warm already where the stone had held the night's fire.

"Neela," he said. "I have to say something before the others come. I should have said it first, and I've been working out how."

"Is it about the queen's offer?"

"Three hundred spears, and Kettamala. The same she's put to you." He swallowed. "The queen sent me a letter. I answered it before I—"

A horn went off behind them.

It was not Bhaskaran's code. It was the great ram's horn the Company kept at the cairn fire, one long bellow that rolled down the cut and came back off the cliff. Every head on the shelf came up.

It blew again. Then Thilak was running along the wall, a hooked tapping knife in one hand and his grey wrap flying, and he shouted before he reached them.

"Council! Everyone to the fire!"

"Why now?" Devan said. He was already on his feet.

"The vote. The queen's offer." Thilak stopped short, hauling air. His eyes went from one blistered pair of hands to the other, and he looked away. "Koman read the road from the lip at grey. A column behind Usha's riders. Crown banners, and Usha says they're the queen's own. A day and a half back, no more. If we're going to say yes or no, we'll say it before it's at the gate."

Neela got up slowly. Her legs shook with the hunger, and her palms had not stopped burning, and the rest of the sentence was still in Devan's mouth.

*The queen sent me a letter. I answered it before I.*

Before he what?

He looked at her. Whatever it was, it was written plainly across his scorched face, and he did not say it. The horn blew a third time, and she took the hand he held out to her and went to the fire, with half a sentence in her ear and forty-two voices ahead of her.

## Chapter 20

# One Name Each

Devan had a mile of cart road to say it in, and he spent all of it not saying it.

Neela walked beside him with her hands bound to the wrist in strips of her own hem. Behind them the Company came up the cut in a long dusty line, the queen's riders mixed among them, two wounded to a horse. The ram's horn had called a council. Muthu had the gate open before the third blast died. He met them under the padippura with his hands open and the iron disc swinging at his belt.

"The lower court's yours," he said. "As long as it takes. The crown's order says no rogues inside my walls. It says nothing about drovers who held the shelf for me."

Kandan, at the back, made a noise through his nose. Muthu did not look at Devan. He looked at the ground, and he was quiet. It was not his lying quiet. Devan had learned the difference late and was glad of it now.

So they sat in the lower court of Kettamala at midmorning, under the tamarind, on the stones where he had learned to ride. The garrison stood along the steps. Janu sent a pail of rice water across the court with a kitchen girl, and a ladle, and no scolding at all, which frightened him more than scolding would. Chellam hushed her baby by the well.

Neela stood in the middle with an upturned grain measure in front of her. She laid things on it one at a time, like a woman paying a debt.

First, a single stiff leaf in a slanting hand. “Usha’s page. The queen wrote it fresh the night before I left, and gave it to me.” Then a thick sheaf in black ink, tied with green thread. “Forty pages. Chathu wrote them at the queen’s table. One for each of you.”

“Ours?” said Madhavi.

“Yours. I’ll read each one aloud at noon, in daylight, to its owner alone or with whoever they choose. After that it’s yours to burn or keep, and nobody can read it against you.” Neela’s voice was flat and careful. “But everyone in the room hears your shape when I read. That’s new mouths. And a master who saw you turn can write you again. Chathu told me that when I was twelve, over Kirri’s rat-eaten page. The queen saw every one of her guards turn. Chathu saw every one of you. Both of them are alive. A page is a leaf. A witness is a mouth.”

She gave them the offer next. Command of thirty knives with no pages on them, vouched under the crown, no hunter within a day’s ride. Three hundred spears for the pass. Kettamala given back to its warden. Safe, unseen, and the queen’s.

“It would work,” she said. “Nobody would bleed for anybody. I want you to hear that, because it’s true.”

Lata’s chin came up a fraction. She had braced for a lie and not been handed one.

“There is one thing that frees a person from every witness at once. Only one. It’s the only way to be rid of the new mouths as well as the old.” Neela set her bound hands flat on the measure. “You say your shape aloud, in your own human voice, in the minute you turn at dusk, to one person who is looking at you. Once in your life. It voids every other witness. The queen. Chathu. After that nobody can cage you without your voice joined to theirs.”

“And the price,” Sanu said.

“The witness page burns where it lies. You’re rogue, and the crown may hunt you. And you and that person feel each other’s wounds for life.” She did not look at Devan. “A mortal one pulls the other toward the ground.”

She stopped there. She did not say *so you should* or *so you shouldn't.* He watched her not say it, her jaw set, and thought it was harder than anything she had done on that shelf.

"I won't ask anyone to do it," she said. "I'm asking you to know what it is."

The court stayed quiet. Then Kuttu, from the stones: "She's told us her half. Somebody ought to tell us his."

Every head turned.

Devan's hand had gone to his belt pouch, for the pebble. He stopped it. A pebble kept words behind the teeth, and he needed these out.

"I've been on the other end of it since the night she named herself to me," he said. "I'll say what I have."

His voice came out rough from the smoke. He stood, because sitting felt like hiding.

"A hook opened my ribs in the narrows at noon. The same minute, it opened hers, in the queen's house, among people who would have used the sight of it. I sat on a broken ladder rung and put nine stitches in myself with Kandan's needle, and I could not tell which of us I was sewing." On the steps Kandan looked at his boots. "For four mornings I counted whether she lived by whether I woke to a welt. I couldn't ask a rider. I read my own thumb."

Nobody moved. He kept going, because stopping now would be worse.

"Mine go to her. Last night at dusk I took a burning ladder in my hands to keep it off your wall. She came down the cut with blisters to the wrist. She'd touched nothing. I did that, and I did not ask her, because there's no asking. When I swing a blade I send the blow to the one person I would never choose to hurt."

He made himself look at Neela. She was looking at the measure.

"There's the other side. I know she's breathing. It's the only reason I slept at all. I can't tell you it's worth it for you. I can tell you what I paid and what I got. Don't do it for the wall. Don't do it because I stood here

and said it was bearable. If you do it, do it because there's one person you would rather bleed with than be safe without."

"And if there isn't anyone?" Lata said.

"Then you stay vouched, with a roof and a lamp, and I would say that to the queen's face. It isn't nothing."

Lata studied him. "No," she said. "It isn't."

"So we vote on it," Madhavi said. "On who goes with who."

"No." Neela lifted her head. "No vote can choose whom you bind to. You ask one person. They have to be looking at you at dusk, in the minute. Nobody can look for you, and nobody can say yes for you."

For a time nobody did anything. A hen walked across the court.

Pavi stood first. She was small and quick, twenty-four, with a white scar on her chin and an old-broken wrist she held a little crooked. "Thilak," she said.

Thilak was turning a cup in his hands. "I'm forty-one," he said. "I bleed slow and mend slower."

"I know."

"You'll have my knees."

"And you'll have this." Pavi lifted the wrist. "You've been bringing me tea over it for a month."

He laughed once, an ugly, surprised sound. "Yes," he said, and set the cup down as if it might spill.

Kuttu didn't stand. He crossed the court to the gate arch, where Bhaskaran stood with his horn on his belt and his arms folded. "Sergeant," Kuttu said.

"I have four daughters," said Bhaskaran.

"I know."

"Their mother will have words." He looked at the horn for a while. "Twenty years I've carried this. Never carried anyone." He unfolded his arms. "Yes. Ask me when it's dusk."

Kamalakshi was on her feet before the murmur finished. She turned in a slow circle, taking in the whole court. "No," she said. "Not you, or you, or you. I've been looked at by enough people who could do some-

thing about it. I'll look at myself." She sat down, and from somewhere near the wall came a short, cracked laugh that might have been hers.

Vellan sat in the doorway with his knife and a scrap of pale wood. He did not lift his head. "No," he said. "I told the lad once."

Sanu was watching Sajan. Sajan put one hand on his brother's shoulder and said nothing, which was not a yes, and was not a no. Sanu looked at the hand as if it were a letter.

"That's all anyone has to say today," Neela said. "The vote on the queen's offer is tonight, after we eat."

*

Gopan had been oiling the cistern wheel when they came up the east steps. He took one look at the two of them and found somewhere else to be.

The housing was cool and smelled of wet iron. Neela stood with her back to him and her bandaged hands pressed to the stone, as though it were a fever she was trying to draw out. Somewhere below, a ladle rang in a pail.

"How will you vote?" she said. She asked it of the wall.

"I don't need to. I've answered."

"Answered who?"

There was no more road to put it off on. "The queen. Her letter came while you were still on the road. I wrote back within the hour. I refused Kettamala. I wrote that the spears weren't mine to take or leave, and that the Company would answer for itself. Muthu witnessed it. The rider was on the road by morning."

She did not move. He counted the chain through two links.

"You tried to say it at the wall," she said. "The horn cut you off."

"It would have cut me off. I was working up to it. That's not the same."

"No." She turned. Her voice dropped and slowed, each word set down apart from the next. "In the tack room, with the buckets going. *Say it before you do it.* You held the string while I tied that."

"Yes."

"Do you know what I carried down the road?" Her voice stayed low. "Your fort. Four days. If I said no to her, I was saying no to the roof you were born under. I decided I could pay it. I'd decided before Kodiyur was out of sight. I was going to pay it with my eyes open, in front of the Company, and you'd already paid it for me, with a pen." She drew a breath. "I carried a thing that was gone. And now I can't know what you'd have said if you'd waited. Or whether it was a no said for my sake."

He had meant to start with the excuse and put the apology after it. Hearing her, he saw there was no room for the order.

"I broke it," he said. "There's a reason. The rider was ready, you were four days off, the queen wanted an answer. It's true, and it makes the breaking no smaller. I could have held the rider a night. I could have sent him back with nothing. I didn't, and I should have. I'm sorry."

"Don't say it like a report."

He tried again. "I took the price out of your hands before you'd chosen to pay it. That was yours. I'm sorry." The words were not any better, but they were truer. "I said no because the fort isn't worth the Company's vote. That's the whole reason. I won't dress it up as sparing you. You'll have to take that on trust. If I can't tell you first, I'll tell you that I can't, and why. Before."

She watched him. Her thumbnail dragged along her forefinger nail, the bandage leaving the tips bare.

"Hear the rest," she said. "I'm still angry."

"I'm listening."

"Tonight, when the Company votes, I'll say what I think of the offer. If I think you're wrong, I'll say that too, in front of all of them. I'll speak against you if I must." She kept her palms on the stone. "And tomorrow at the gate, you don't answer for me. Not a word. Not to spare me, and not to spare the fort."

It cost him something to hear it, and she watched it land. "Yes," he said.

"You said that fast."

"Then I'll say it slower. I will not answer for you at the gate." He made himself go on. "Here's what I mean to say to her tomorrow, so you have it before I do. That I refused Kettamala in writing, and that was my act alone. That the Company hasn't answered, because the Company hasn't voted. And that I'll say nothing of what you are unless you say it first."

She was silent a while. "Good," she said. "Stand a step behind me when you say it."

"A step."

She turned back to the wall and set her palms on the stone again, and he set his on it a hand's width from hers. The cold of it went into both of them together. He felt the answering ease in his skin half a breath behind her own, and knew she felt his.

"It's mending," she said, after a while. "It isn't mended. It isn't forgotten."

"I'd think less of you if it were."

She nearly smiled. It went out of her face again at once, because someone was coughing at the foot of the steps.

Koman came up with his hands clasped before him, like a man at a naming. He was old, thin, and sunburned to the colour of a roof tile. Nobody had hired him to climb a mile of road, and he had done it anyway. "Warden," he said. Devan had given up correcting him.

"Say it, Koman."

"The long shape is in the river again." He kept his eyes on the floor. "Same bank as before, below the shingle. It came in after the tower fell, at the middle watch, and lay in the shallows with only the eyes above until the stump stopped smoking. It took nothing. It didn't touch the dead on the bank, or a horse. It watched the shelf. When the smoke thinned, it went under." He shook his head. "Eleven years I've read that water. Nothing the Resin House ever made smells like that."

Neela's eyes found Devan's. Neither of them said anything. Whatever lay in that river wanted nothing from the dead. A thing that watched and did not take had been sent, or had come to count.

"Thank you," Devan said. "Go and eat."

Koman bowed, badly, and went down. At the landing he stood aside for a woman coming up with her sleeves dragged to her knuckles.

Usha stopped inside the door and did not come further. She looked at the two of them, and at the hand's width between their hands, and took the news into the room like a stone she meant to set down gently.

"The column reaches Kettamala tomorrow at noon," she said.

"Koman said a day and a half."

"Koman read the dust at grey. I went up the lip with him at midday and read the outriders." Her voice was level. "When she rides with her people, the outriders go in pairs, always, on both flanks. The banners say her household. The pairs say her."

Neela's bound hands closed on the stone.

"She's with them," Usha said. "The queen is riding in her own column. She'll be at your gate by noon."

The chain clanked the hour. A queen who sent a letter and a lever did not climb a hill road to hear no. She came up it to answer. Devan found he had already counted the steps from the gate to the pass, and did not like the number.

## Chapter 21

# The Third Slat

Muthu was waiting at the foot of the north stair with a lamp in one hand and his other arm full of bedding.

"I've been told I snore," he said. "So I'm sleeping in the gate chamber tonight. Which is a kindness to everybody."

Neela looked at the bedding, then at him. He went quiet when he lied and loud when he joked, and he was neither now. He was just a big man holding a pillow like a shield.

"The warden's chamber," she said.

"It was always his. I only kept the bed warm." He held out the lamp. Sesame oil, full to the lip. "One night. Janu's changed the sheets and sworn at me while she did it. There's rice and curd on the sill and water in the kindi, spout toward the pillow." He stopped. "I didn't do that last part. She says that's how it's done."

Devan had come up behind her. She felt him there, a step back, as she'd asked.

"Muthu," he said.

"Don't." Muthu raised the pillow an inch. "The slat still creaks. I didn't fix it either."

He went down the stair, whistling something that wandered off the tune, and did not look back.

*

The room had not changed. The teak shutters faced west, closed and latched. The long bar hung on its hooks. The bed stood where it had always stood, and on the floor beside it lay a sword in its scabbard, hilt toward her side, because Muthu had been told once and had never asked why.

She counted the doors. Two. The little one by the hearth made three.

The council had run until the lamps burned low. Nobody would answer the queen until the queen had spoken in the open, at the gate, with the Company standing where she could see them. No vote on her offer had been taken. It was a delay. It was also a door held ajar. Dusk had come with the old pull at her throat, ten counts of burn in the scars, and gone. She was human. The ache would count the night against her. She let it.

Devan set the lamp on the table. Then he went to the pack hanging on the peg and took out an oilcloth bundle tied with red thread.

"I carried it up a hill and down again," he said. "It can sleep one night where we hid it."

He knelt at the third shutter and pressed the housing of the slat. A piece of the frame swung in on a hidden pin, no wider than a hand. He laid the bundle in the hollow and closed it, and the slat gave its small dry creak under his thumb.

"Sit," she said. "Please. I'd like to say a thing before I lose it."

He sat on the edge of the bed. She stayed standing, because the telling wanted her on her feet.

"You asked me at the fire what I thought of the queen's offer. I gave the Company the reasons. I didn't give them the rest." Her bandaged hands were clasped before her. "I wanted it."

He said nothing. He watched her and waited, and the waiting let her go on.

"In the fish shed. She sat on a crate among the racks and asked if she might come in, because there was nothing to knock on. She was kind about it. She offered me thirty knives with no pages on them and a roof with no number on it, and I stood there and wanted it the way I want

water after a turning." She heard her voice go flat and let it. "Command, Devan. Nobody over me. And nobody looking. That's the part I'm ashamed of. I could have been unseen again. No one with power over me who'd chosen not to use it, only a quiet house where no one could. Twenty-one years I answered to a number. It was safe. I missed it for an hour, and I hated that I missed it, and I came home and put my hand to the thorns and I still missed it."

"Is it gone?"

"No." She made herself look at him. "It's smaller. It's not gone."

He did not tell her it was nothing. He reached out and turned one of her bound hands over in his, palm up, and set his thumb on the strip of hem where the blister was. Not pressing. Just there.

"Thank you for telling me," he said. "I won't make it smaller than it is."

It was what she had needed, and nobody had ever said it to her.

"Now you," she said. "I know the answer you gave the queen. I don't know the one you gave yourself."

His jaw worked. He looked at the lamp.

"Muthu asked me on the shelf if it hurt," he said. "To refuse her. I said no. That was a lie, and he knew, and he let me have it." He drew breath. "It hurt more than I let him see. Her letter said *Kettamala restored,* and I stood on the shelf and smelled the pepper coming down the cut and I wanted it back. All of it. My father's chair. Asha's door. The shutters open for the air, the way he kept them. I wrote my refusal on the lid of an arrow cart, and my hand didn't shake, and then I went and hit a post for an hour."

"You didn't tell me."

"I told you I wouldn't dress it up as sparing you. I left out that it cost me." His thumb moved on her palm. "I wanted the fort. I still do. I would trade it again for what I got. Both are true."

She sat down beside him, close enough that the bed gave under them. "That one's easier to carry than the other."

"Which other?"

"The one where you're only noble."

He laughed. It came out short and cracked, and it startled him. She leaned into his shoulder and felt it in her own ribs.

"I won't take the command," she said. "That's settled. But I won't refuse it in a corner either, the way I'd refuse a tin of sweets. She hears my reasons in the open, with the Company standing there. If she's wrong, she can be wrong where people hear."

"And if she's right?"

"Then I'll say that too."

He nodded slowly. It was a smaller thing than a vow, and it settled in her like one.

*

She did not remember who moved first. She remembered undoing the strips of hem from her own hands, one wrap at a time, and his hands taking over when her fingers fumbled. The raw skin of her palms shone in the lamp. His matched it. He turned them side by side and studied the pair for a long moment.

"I'm twenty-seven," she said, because she liked to say it plainly, and because it felt like part of the asking. "You're thirty-two. We're both grown, and nobody here is paying for either of us."

"No one." His voice had gone low. "Neela, if you want to stop, you say. Any time. No reason."

"I know." She laid her cheek against his scarred knuckles. "Leave the lamp."

He went still.

"Keep it lit," she said. "I don't want the dark tonight. I want you to look at me. All of it. The whole time." She swallowed. "I've been seen in a hundred rooms by people who owned the seeing. I want to choose this one."

He took a breath that shook. "I'll look."

"Then do."

His hands came to her face first, careful of the blisters, and he kissed her like a man learning a path. She pulled at his shirt. He lifted his arms so she could drag it over his head, and the lamp showed her what the shelf had cost him. The long ladder-hook cut across his back, dressed and still pulling. On his right ribs, nine stitches of waxed silk, black and fresh, the skin round them angry. Beside them ran the old white seam from the ford.

She put her mouth to the old seam first. Then, slowly, past the stitches, as lightly as she could manage. The ache came anyway, a dull hot line under her own right arm, where the same hook had torn her in a room in Kodiyur. It lay along her ribs like a held note. He made a sound she felt in her chest.

"Does it hurt?" he said.

"Both of us. Don't stop."

"I won't." His voice was rough. "Tell me if it's too much."

When he bared her throat, he stopped. The scars lay there, pale ridges under the lamplight. He looked at them the way he looked at the pass from the wall, and then he put his lips to each in turn. She had once let a man see them as a lie. She let him see them now as a fact, and she did not look away.

"Look at me," she said again.

"I am."

He was. His eyes did not leave her face as he laid her back on the bed that had held the worst night of her life and the best. His hand went under her mundu, slow, a question, and she answered it with her whole body. She reached for him, blistered palms and all, and the burn of her own hands bloomed across his skin at the same moment, and he gasped. Then warmth came through it. The wound-share carried that too, she had learned: a heat in her that she felt twice, once in herself and once in his shoulders, bright and shared.

"You feel that," he said, roughly.

"Both ways."

"Both ways."

It slowed after that. He moved above her, and the lamp showed her his face, the grey in his hair, the line between his brows, which eased and came back and eased. She watched him watch her. She did not close her eyes. When the pleasure rose in her it rose in her face, open, helpless, undefended, and he saw it. She felt him see it.

She said his name. He said hers. Not the number. Not the cover. Her own, the one she had chosen, with the other one folded behind it and still unsaid.

The bed creaked under them. The slat did not.

*

Afterwards she lay with her head on his good side and the lamp burning down. Her palms ached, pleasantly now. His breathing slowed, and she counted it, as she had counted it for forty nights without telling anyone why.

One, two. The hitch came a third of the way through the long count, soft and sure. She counted again to be sure, and it came again.

"You're counting," he said, into her hair.

"You're awake."

"I'm lying very still so you can." His arm tightened a little. "Is it right?"

"It's always right."

On the sill by the shutters sat a grey river pebble in the dust, exactly where he had left it. Muthu had not moved it. Janu had cleaned the sill around it. She looked at it a long time in the thin, steady light.

She slept.

*

She woke before the first clank of the chain. The lamp had burned out. Grey light lay under the shutters. Devan was asleep on his back, one hand open on the sheet between them, and she watched him for a while without counting anything.

Then she got up, wrapped a cloth around her, and went to the third shutter on bare feet.

The housing gave under her thumb with its dry creak. He did not stir. The hollow opened.

Inside, the oilcloth bundle lay where he had put it. She untied the red thread with fingers that no longer shook. The hide strip of the contract chit, with the warden's chamber and *death by beast* in a hand she knew. The payment writ, folded small, dated seven weeks before her wedding. And the gift seal, cut from the sandalwood box, green wax with a sunbird and a small chip at the left wing.

She laid the three side by side on the sill, next to the pebble. In the grey they looked small. A hide strip. A folded paper. A piece of wax. Raiu had died of the first. Ammu had died of what came after. She did not think the queen knew what they weighed. She thought she knew exactly.

"It's all there," Devan said behind her.

She had not heard him wake. He was propped on one elbow, hair on end, his eyes already clear.

"You can't leave a bundle in a wall and expect me not to count it."

"I'd have been disappointed." He sat up, and she saw him catch his breath at the stitches. "She comes at noon."

"With three hundred spears." She did not turn from the sill. "What do they do, Devan, when their queen is named a murderer at her own gate?"

He did not reach for comfort. He was quiet, and then he gave her the answer as he gave her everything, flat and whole.

"I don't know. Here's what I do know. Three hundred, under captains of her household who have never met me. On our side, ninety-eight. Forty-two odiyans, now the six are back from Kodiyur. Twenty-two of her own riders, who may not hold when she's named. Forty garrison volunteers. That's a hundred and four, less six in the ground: Biju, Sankaran, Chami, Rajan and two more. Fourteen hundred Thurai wait on the far side of the cut. If one captain lifts a spear when I finish read-

ing, we fight at our own gate with the host at our backs, and we lose the pass. If none lifts, I've still named her a murderer in front of the only men who can hold the cut beside us. Some of them will not forgive me. Some will go home."

"So it might cost us the spears."

"It might cost us the spears and the pass with them. I think that's likely. I'm telling you so you don't find out at noon."

It was no comfort at all. She found, oddly, that she could stand on it.

"Then read it," she said.

"I'll read the writ aloud before her. In daylight, at the gate, with the Company and the garrison and the village standing there. The whole of it, her wording, her wax. Not hidden. Not whispered in a stair." He swung his legs over the bed's edge. "And I'll tell her first, to her face, that I'm going to."

"Why first?"

"Because the last man to keep a thing in his sleeve against me was Chathu." He met her eyes. "I said I'd say it before I do it. I mean to keep that."

She looked at the green chipped wax on the sill. For weeks that seal had ridden in his own sleeve, and he had told nobody. He saw where her eyes went.

"I know," he said. "I kept one too. I put the seal in the bundle on the hill, so it's there for you to see. I'm telling you before, and not after."

She almost laughed. It stopped short of her mouth.

"Then here's the term," she said. "You read. I refuse. My refusal, my reasons, in my own voice, to her face. You don't carry any of it."

"I'll stand a step behind you. I won't speak for you."

"Is reading the writ not answering for me?"

He took the question seriously, as he took all of hers. "The writ is my account of what she did to me and mine. That's mine to read. The Company's answer is yours."

She folded the bundle back together. Her hands knew the knot. She still wanted to ask whether he would use the writ as a rope or only as a

light, and she found he had not promised her which. Neither did she know.

"Then I'll have my own words ready," she said. "Hold the pebble."

"Why?"

"Because I want to see you hold it," she said, "and not put it in your mouth."

He took the stone from the sill. It was cold, and it sat in his scarred palm like something small and honest, and he closed his hand around it and did not lift it. Down in the court the cistern chain clanked again, and the first cocks answered.

## Chapter 22

# The Queen at Kettamala

Neela counted the spears from the padippura roof and got to three hundred and four before the first of them reached the shingle bank.

They came up the cart road in a double file, green pennants limp in the noon heat. Grey dust rose behind them. At the head rode a woman on a grey horse, one hand loose on the rein. No woman who knew she was going to be refused rode like that. Usha walked at her stirrup, bare-headed, sleeves pulled to her knuckles. Behind them, in a tight knot, rode seven guards in green sashes. Neela knew every one of their names from the drying shed in Kodiyur. They had been offered their pages and had said no. The eighth who had said no, Lata, was not with them. She had ridden north with Usha's riders and was already up on the shelf, and she had not looked at the road once.

"Three hundred and four," Neela said.

"Three hundred and three," said Devan, behind her. "One's a boy with a drum."

The garrison lined the court in grey. Bhaskaran's horn stayed at his belt. Nobody had told the Company to hide, so the Company did not. They stood at the back of the lower court, forty-one of them, in their own mud-coloured cloth, and let the queen look.

She looked. The gate took her through under the tamarind, and she slid from the saddle without help. She was fifty-four, small, her hair gone

iron-grey under a plain white cloth. She wore no crown. Her hands were ink-stained at the second finger, like a clerk's.

The garrison began to kneel. It went along the steps in a ripple, spears grounding.

"Stand," Nirmala said, in the warm unhurried voice Neela had heard through the screens outside the sea room. "This is a warden's court, and I'm his guest. Neela. I'd rather see your face than the top of your head."

Neela stayed on her feet. She had planned no speech for it. She stood where she was, hands bound in clean strips, and said, "Majesty. Kettamala is glad you've come. It was not told you were coming."

"It wasn't. I hoped to be forgiven." The queen's eyes went past her to Devan and rested there with what looked like real warmth. "Warden."

"Majesty." Devan did not bow lower than a warden bows. His voice was level and carried to the back steps. "I hold a paper with your wax on it. I'll read it when my wife has answered you. Not before."

Spear butts shifted on the stone along the steps, then went still. Neela kept her eyes on the queen's face and did not turn, because they had agreed he would say it and she would hear it, and she heard it.

The queen's brows lifted a little. "Then I'll wait on your wife," she said. "I'm told it's the only way to get anything done in this house."

Muthu came down from the gate chamber stair with the iron disc swinging at his belt and his big hands empty. He did not bow. He touched two fingers to his brow, as a captain does to a guest, and stood straight. The queen studied the disc, and then him.

"You hold my seal, Captain."

It was a test, laid so lightly that half the court would not have felt it.

"I hold the border's, Majesty." Muthu's voice was quiet and steady. He was not lying. "It was given into my hand by the man who wore it five years, and I hold it for the villages. If the border wants it back on a different neck, the border will say so."

Somewhere behind him a spear butt scraped a step. Neela watched the queen weigh the answer, as she had watched men weigh a blade at a throat. Then Nirmala smiled, and let it stand.

"A good answer. I need a man who holds the pass more than I need one who holds my seal." She turned. "Is there a table in this house? I have a petition waiting."

*

The hall had eight pillars. Neela had counted them on her first morning as a bride, and counted them again now, because it kept her mind steady. Janu had put out rice and curd and plain water, no better than for any guest, and stood against the wall with a tray in both hands.

The queen sat in the warden's chair. Devan did not take the seat beside it. He came and stood behind Neela's bench, near enough that she could hear him breathe. He had said he would stand at her back and not be her wall, and he stood a step back, as she'd asked.

"Before anything else," the queen said, "I'll hear who is waiting."

Neela had expected a ceremony of speeches. Instead a thin woman in a washed grey wrap was brought up from the court, coughing into her sleeve, and held out a tally stick as if it might burn her.

"Parukutty," said Neela, before she could stop herself.

The woman flinched at her own name. The queen looked from one to the other and said nothing of it.

"Soldier's widow, lower village," Parukutty said. "My husband was Raman. Spearman. I've a girl of six and a boy of nine." Her voice shook and straightened. "Majesty, the Justice paid mine early, and I thank you. But there are three more on the wall rolls, and the lower village will burn when the Thurai come through. Their death-gifts are due at harvest. There won't be a harvest. Could they be paid now, so they can buy bread on the road? And Chandu wants to carry arrows on the wall. He's nine. I'd rather he carried rice."

"Raman," Nirmala said. She said it as one says the name of someone one has met. "Killed in the spring, in single file under the shelf. The patrol of eleven." She did not look at a clerk, because there was none. "Minnu and Chandu. Is the girl's cough better?"

Parukutty stared. "It's mine, Majesty. The girl's well."

"Then you should have a physician's willow bark, and not wait for a harvest." The queen drew a sheet of paper toward her, took the reed Janu had brought, and wrote in a quick slanting hand. She signed it *Nirmala* in full. No stamp, no seal. "Three widows on the wall rolls, paid now, from my own purse. And Chandu does not carry arrows. He carries rice to the arrow-bearers, and eats first." She blew on the ink and held it out. "If anyone tells you otherwise, show them this."

Parukutty took the paper in both hands. She did not kneel. She seemed to have forgotten how.

Neela watched the queen's ink-stained finger tap the table once, then rest. This was real, the whole of it. It was the same hand that had kept a dead spearman's name and his children's names since spring, and had reached for a cough the moment it heard one. It was also the hand that had sealed a writ in green wax and sent Vellan up the west stair, where Raiu had died.

Both are hers, Neela thought. She could not make them into one woman, though she had been trying since Kodiyur. Behind her, Devan's breath stopped for a moment, and started again.

*

When the widows were gone the queen turned to the rest of the hall. "Now to the thing I came for."

A guard set a red lacquer case on the table. Neela knew it by its gold bird and its farm lock. The queen lifted the lid. Thirty stiff pale leaves lay on blue cloth, each with a clerk's copy of its intake roll looped on in green thread.

"The crown leaf," Nirmala said. "Fresh pages, in my own hand, written the night before your wife left Kodiyur. Usha's I wrote twice; your wife carries the first. I mean to burn them in front of you all, once you've heard my terms."

Neela reached into her wrap. She laid Chathu's sheaf beside the case, tied with its green thread, forty pages in black ink. "Mine," she said. "Chathu wrote these at your table. They're not burned. I told you why."

"You did." The queen did not seem hurt by it. "Look at them together, if you like. I'd be a poor queen if I minded being read."

Neela bent over the two piles. She did it for the Company and for the garrison, and because it kept her face busy. The queen's leaves gave off a bitter smell, scorched and sharp, like resin gone too long on a flame. Chathu's smelled like a lamp-black cake, dry, the smell of a clerk's ink pot.

She frowned. The two should have smelled alike. They were both pages in the same resin-ink, written by true witnesses. She turned the thought over but could not make it come out. When she straightened, it slid off like water off a leaf.

"Well?" said the queen gently.

"Nothing," said Neela. "I wanted to know them again."

"Then know them." Nirmala's gaze moved over Neela's shoulder. "Warden. I'll be plain, in your own hall, before your own people. The offer I sent still stands. Kettamala is yours. The disc, the pass, the garrison, your father's chair. Muthu may give back what he's held, with my thanks and a captaincy for it."

Every head in the hall turned. Neela kept her eyes on the pages and listened to the quiet behind her. This was the moment where a man could reach past his wife for what was his by blood, and the whole house knew it.

Devan said nothing.

Sandals stopped shifting on the stone. Janu's tray rattled once against her wrist. Devan did not step forward to take the chair or to refuse it. He did not so much as look at the disc on Muthu's belt.

The queen waited. Then she nodded, slowly, as if he had said a great deal. "Think on it," she said. "You'll have your answer when your wife has given hers."

The hall let go. It was a small noise, sandals scuffing, a cough, a spear butt set down hard in the passage. Without turning, Neela moved her bound right hand back along the bench, and Devan's fingers closed over

the strip at her wrist, warm and dry. His thumb found the blister under the cloth and stayed there. Neither of them looked down.

"That was a great deal of nothing," she said, low.

"You told me not to speak for you," Devan said, just as low. "I took it as wide advice."

Her mouth twitched. His thumb pressed once on the strip, then he let go, and she faced the room with her hand in her lap and the print of his fingers still on it.

"Janu," she said.

The steward jumped. "Lady?"

"Sit down."

"I'll not sit while the queen—"

"It's your hall," Neela said. "You fed her. You've kept it standing all these years, and you stood against the wall while she wrote a widow's bread on your table." She pulled out the bench beside her. "Sit."

Janu looked at the queen. The queen inclined her head a finger's breadth, a small permission, her mouth dry with watching amusement. Janu put the tray down on the stone with a clatter that rang off the pillars. She sat. Her hands went flat on her knees. Around the hall, a dozen kitchen women found sudden business with their sleeves and their sandals.

Neela kept her face still. She had never in her life been so sure that she had taken something and given it away in the same moment.

*

The west stair had forty-four steps. Neela went up them at dusk, because the queen asked it.

"Would you walk with me," Nirmala had said, after the meal, after the spears had been settled on the terraces and Usha had gone to see to the seven in green. "The warden's wife may choose the stair."

Neela had chosen this one. She had gone wide of the parrot newel from her first week, without knowing why. She knew why now. She had

stood at its foot with a shuttered lamp, six years ago, and counted. She laid a hand on its broken beak and felt it smooth as a river stone.

They climbed together. Nirmala's breath was short at the tenth step. She stopped on the eleventh, and it rang under her sandal with a hollow note.

"Here," she said.

Neela's hand tightened on the rail. Pala wood, worn.

"Rema's roll took down the physician's account: the postern, the eleventh step. I came up knowing which one to stand on." The queen did not look at her. "She was Devan's sister. I met her once, at the Kolathur fair. She argued with me over the price of pepper-sacks, and was right."

Neela's fingers went white on the rail. Her mouth had gone dry, and for one breath she had the whole sentence ready: *I held the lamp.* The queen had Rema's roll. She would know it already, and it would be no gift to her to hear it. Neela shut her mouth on it. She would say it where it cost the speaker, in the open, and not on a dark stair to the one who had paid for it.

"Ittan paid for Asha," she said instead. Her voice came out very even. "Not you."

"Not I. That was Ittan's coin, and Chathu's knife, and a bear's. I'd have stopped it, had I known. I will not pretend I never would have signed a thing like it." The queen turned from the stair and faced her. In the grey dusk her face was tired and honest. "I sealed the payment writ. Usha saw the bundle in your husband's pack on the hill, and she has told me what such a bundle holds. He carries it up and down my hills. He was loyal, Neela. He was also a week from opening a box in Ittan's keeping, and what was in that box held a price I had paid for twenty years. Ships off this coast. Boats that stayed on the sea. That price is not paid now. It failed this season, when the fleet crossed the bar, and the Thurai are at the cut."

Neela heard it land, and heard what it took with it. Devan meant to read that writ at the gate and watch the crown's own spears hear it for the first time. The queen had just said it herself, in a half-lit stair, as

calmly as a price at market. There would be no gasp now. Anyone who heard of this talk could say the queen had owned the thing already.

It would still have to be read. A confession made to one woman on a stair was a secret with a kind face. Said before three hundred spears, it was a fact.

"So you killed a loyal man to keep it paid."

"I tried to. I'd do it again, if the arithmetic stood the same." There was no cruelty in it, and that was worse than cruelty. "A realm is kept safe by what it never has to see. A widow in a village sleeps because she has never watched a knife go in. I've signed death writs for people who loved me and had done nothing but get in the way, and I have not slept well after any. But the villages slept. Until this season, they slept."

"Ammu is dead."

"Ammu. Twenty-five. Her name is in Rema's roll." Nirmala's voice did not change. "I'm sorry."

It was not an excuse. Neela had expected one, and could have fought an excuse. She stood on the eleventh step with a dead woman's name in her mouth and no place to put her hands.

"You'd have kept me unseen," she said. "Thirty knives, no pages. You said it kindly."

"I meant it kindly." The queen almost smiled. "It is the only gift I know how to give. I am sorry, too, that you don't want it. I think you're right not to."

A cistern chain clanked in the dark. Down in the court somebody laughed, and it was Kamalakshi, and the sound of it carried up the stair like a thrown pebble.

"My spies tell me two nights," Nirmala said, her voice shifting into a quieter, harder register. "The main assault, not the scouts. Fourteen hundred, with a new tower and ladders, up through the cut. Two nights from tonight. I'll have my captain give the order and mean it, whatever else stands between us." She drew a slow breath. "I'd have chosen a private room. He's chosen the court. I'll allow it."

"I'll answer at the dusk before the assault," Neela said. "In the open."

"In front of whom?"

"Everyone. Your captains. The garrison. The Company. Whoever else is left in this house." She heard her own voice, flat and slow. "You said the realm is kept safe by what it never sees. I'd like it to see. All of it, including what you've just told me."

The queen looked at her for a long time. Then, unexpectedly, she bowed her head, not as a queen to a subject but as one woman who had run a house to another who meant to.

"Then the realm will hear you choose," Nirmala said, "between what it never saw and what it cannot unsee. I would not envy you, if I were not fond of you." She turned and began to climb. At the landing she paused, one hand on the rail. "I did not lie to you in the fish shed, Neela. I have never needed to. It is the cruelest thing about me."

She went up into the dark passage.

Neela did not wait for her steps to fade. She went down the forty-four steps two at a time, past the newel without slowing, and across the lower court where the Company sat in knots around their cook-fires. The great ram's horn hung from the well post, where Kuttu had slung it after the council. She lifted it down. It was heavier than it looked, and the mouthpiece was cold against her lip.

She blew one long bellow. It rolled off the walls and up the terraces, and every head in the court came round.

They came to her in ones and twos, then all at once: Kuttu with his bowl still in his hand, Thilak wiping his knife, Vellan limping up from the gate arch. Bhaskaran's sentries leaned over the wall. At the edge of the firelight, Devan stopped a step behind her, and said nothing.

"The queen has given us two nights," Neela said. Her voice shook, and she let it. "I'll give her my answer at dusk, the day after tomorrow, at the gate. In the open, with all of you standing where she can see you." She looked from face to face. "Every one of you hears it before she does. Tonight, at the cairn fire, I'll tell you what I mean to say. Then you tell me if I'm wrong."

## Chapter 23

# What Vellan Carries

The queen's captain would not take an order from a man with no office, and he said so before Devan had finished unrolling the map.

"You gave back the disc in front of this whole hall," Captain Haran said. He was a broad, grey-moustached man who sat his chair as if it were a saddle. "I carry the queen's word to three hundred spears. I don't carry yours."

They sat at the long table in the hall, under the eight pillars: Haran, Muthu with the iron disc at his belt, Usha with her sleeves pulled down, Thilak with his big tapper's hands flat on the board, Neela at Devan's left. The queen sat at the head of the table in the warden's chair, with a cup of water she had not touched. She had said she would listen.

Devan had drawn the cut in chalk on a plank. Forty paces wide at the gorge. Narrower at the shelf, where Raman had died. Fourteen hundred on the far side of the river.

For five years, men had done what he said because the disc was on his belt. Nobody had ever answered him, and he had never had to hear whether he was right.

"Then don't take it from me," he said. "Put it to a vote."

Haran's moustache lifted. "A vote."

"Five of you hold something on that wall. You hold the crown spears. Muthu holds the garrison and the seal. Usha has the queen's riders, Thilak the Company's hands, and Neela the Company's voice. I hold noth-

ing." He laid the chalk down. "I'll say what I'd do, and each of you can say yes or no. If it's no, I sit down."

"Sutlers vote," Haran said. "Wardens command."

"Let him, Haran," Nirmala said from the chair. She turned the cup a quarter turn. "I'd like to see what happens."

Devan told it plain. Crown spears in three ranks on the shelf wall, behind the stakes Kandan's men had cut, because they were the only ones with the numbers to take the first ladders. Garrison archers behind them, with Muthu's eleven sheaves. The Company in the thorn below the lip and on the wall by turns, rotated by the hour so no one was spent before the tower came. Kandan's ten to the cart road, to cut the horse lines if the line bent.

"And where does my household stand when the line bends?" Haran said.

"Where it can retreat to the wall. I'd rather your men lived and ran than died and held." Devan heard how it sounded. "That's the part you'll like least."

Neela spoke for the first time. "Captain. Who is your second?"

Haran looked at her as if she had offered him a sweet. "Sethu."

"Then I'll want Sethu at the stakes with Kandan before dusk," she said. "They should know each other's faces before they have to know each other's backs."

Nobody laughed. Haran's mouth worked.

"Hands," Muthu said, in a voice that was almost his old loud one.

Muthu's went up. Usha's. Thilak's. Neela's. Devan raised his own last, and it felt strange, a hand held up like a boy's among people who could have sent him from the room.

Haran kept his on the table. "No."

"Five to one," said Muthu.

The captain studied the chalk plank for some time. "I'll hold the centre," he said. "Not under that man. Under the table." He glanced at the queen. She gave him nothing, only the dry watching look she had worn the day before.

"That will do," Devan said. To his surprise, it would.

*

At dusk he went down to the shelf.

The stakes stood in a double row, new-cut ash, the points still pale. Below the lip the river ran brown and loud. Beyond it, the Thurai fires made a low orange smear along the far bank. He counted a hundred and ten of them and stopped.

Vellan was at the lip, where the cut narrowed toward the top. The bear's limp showed in the man today, a drag and a step. He stood with his arms crossed, looking at the place where the walls drew in to eleven paces.

"There," he said. "I'll hold that."

Devan came and stood beside him. "The cut is the last narrow before the gate road. If they take it, nothing stands between them and the court."

"That's why."

"Alone?"

"Unbound." Vellan did not turn. "No one has named herself to me. If I'm cut there, no one else bleeds for it. I've handed enough people my wounds." He gave the cut a nod, as he might have to a bad neighbour. "Let the others bleed for the people they chose. I'll bleed for nobody."

"The Company voted the line. You'd be off it."

"The Company's voted me a hand. Mine's up." A small rough sound came out of him that might have been a laugh. "You'd have done the same."

Devan would have, once. He did not say it. The wind came down the cut, and with it, faintly, the smell of the far bank's smoke.

"She said—" Vellan began.

Devan went still.

The big man's jaw moved. His eyes were on the narrow place, not on Devan. "Asha. At the end. She said—" He stopped. "No."

"Vellan."

"After." Vellan uncrossed his arms. "If there is an after. Not on the night before a fight. You'd carry it up the cut instead of your spear."

Devan had waited six years. One more night he could do. What he felt was not forgiveness; he did not have that to give yet. It was nearer to what a man feels when a hard animal finally lets him within reach. He did not step closer.

"After, then," he said.

Footsteps scuffed the path behind them. Kamalakshi came up from the gate arch with a rag bundle held against her ribs, the way someone carries a thing she's afraid will be seen. She was perhaps nineteen, thin, with her hair cropped short, and the shelf stones rang under her sandals as if she were trying to make them.

She stopped three paces from Vellan.

"Here," she said, and held the bundle out at arm's length.

He unwrapped it. A bird, the length of his thumb, carved from pale wood. One wing was thicker than the other. The head sat too large for the body, and the beak, which should have been whole, was a blunt wedge that looked ready to bite.

"It's bad," Kamalakshi said.

"Yes."

"I haven't forgiven you."

"I know."

"Don't know it so loudly." She scrubbed her palm on her hip. "I did it with your knife. I wanted to see if it was hard."

"It's hard."

"Good." She turned on her heel and left, and did not run, which Devan thought must have cost her.

Vellan stood with the bird in his hand a long time. Then he put it inside his shirt, over the heart, and turned back to the cut.

Devan looked at the river. He gave the man the privacy of a view, as Neela had once given it to him, and the Thurai fires crawled on the far bank, thick and slow.

*

The pit below the east wall smelled of sesame oil and red earth. Lamps burned in their niches round the rim. Muthu was already down in it, barefoot, his shirt on the step.

"The seventh day," he said. "You owe me a round. I counted."

"I know I do."

"You've owed it since the Resin House. I'd like the interest in blood." Muthu grinned. It was his old grin, wide and a little foolish. "Don't worry. I'll be gentle with the stitches."

"Don't be."

Devan went down the north steps barefoot. The ribs pulled under the silk. He let them. Muthu knew where the old seam was and where the new stitches were, and Devan said so, and Muthu said he'd take it as a map.

They did not use marma. They went to touches. Muthu came in low and fast, as he always had, and Devan gave ground and took it back, and the packed earth slapped under their feet. It had been eight years, and then a few mornings, and the body remembered what it had been taught as a boy. His open hand stopped a hair from Muthu's ribs. He had practised that stop alone for years, in front of a post, and now there was a man at the end of it, laughing, who lifted his own hand to answer.

On the fifth pass, Muthu's palm landed on Devan's left side below the ribs. It was light. It would have been a rib broken, and a lung after, if either of them had meant it.

"There," Muthu said, breathing hard. "It drops. When you're tired. It always did."

"I know."

"You've always known. You've never done anything about it." He stepped back, rubbing his chest. "Who found it, then?"

Devan looked up. Neela sat on the north steps with her bound hands around her knees. She had not made a sound. Her lips were moving in a small count, steps or breaths, he could not tell.

"My wife," he said.

"She told you."

"She came down those steps on the eleventh day, put her fingers at the back of my neck, counted three, and told me my left dropped. I didn't turn. I held my breath." He wiped his face with his forearm. "I never did anything about it."

"Then do something," Muthu said. He went up the steps for his shirt, passed Neela, and put two fingers to his brow. It was a captain's salute, given to no one in the garrison, and she returned it with her chin.

Devan climbed out. The lamps burned steady. He stood in front of her with the sweat cooling on him, and for a breath he did not know how to ask.

"On the wall," he said. "In the line. Wherever I'm standing when the ladders come. Will you take my left side?"

She did not answer at once. She looked at the pit, at the packed earth, the marks of their feet.

"I'll be a cat by then," she said.

"Then the cat." He held her eyes. "My left drops. You know it, you found it. I'd rather it were yours to cover than anyone's. It's the weak side. I'm putting it in your hands."

"Whether it's hurt or not, I'll feel it."

"I know. That's why you."

Her mouth moved, and she did not smile. It was not that kind of thing. She reached out and put two fingers, light as a clerk's, on the cloth over his left ribs, where Muthu's palm had landed.

"Yes," she said.

He let out a breath that had nothing hidden in it.

On the way up the steps he saw that Muthu had watched the whole of it, and so had the lamps and the men on the wall, who had come to look at a warden fighting. He had used his strength in the open. Men would vote on what he said and count how badly he had stood. He had thought it would feel like having his skin off. It felt like being seen. He found he could bear it.

*

A hand on his shoulder in the middle watch.

He was awake before the voice. The lamp in the passage showed him Koman, the old pass-village watcher, with Unni behind him holding a torch. Koman's breath came in short pulls, and his eye had the stillness of a man who had run up a hill.

"Warden," he said, and Devan did not correct him. "I was on the lip. The far bank is moving."

Neela had sat up beside him without a sound. Her hand had found his wrist, as if it knew.

"Moving how?"

"The spies said after dark, the second night. They'll come at dusk, while the light's still in our eyes." Koman wet his lips. "They've brought the tower up in the dark to the shingle. They're not waiting for full night. I counted ladders until I couldn't." He spread his hands. "Dusk tomorrow."

Devan swung his legs to the floor. The stitches pulled. He felt Neela's other hand close on the sheet.

"The queen's spies were wrong," he said.

"The queen's spies," Koman said, with a flat old man's patience, "were not on the lip."

Unni's torch spat. Down in the court the cistern chain clanked the hour, three, and was answered by nothing.

Neela was already out of the bed and reaching for her cloth. Her face in the torchlight had the shut calm of someone doing sums she did not like.

"I set my answer for dusk tomorrow," she said. "At the gate. With the Company and the queen."

"Yes."

"That's the hour they come." She tied the cloth at her waist with a hard small pull. "My answer and the first ladder, in the same dusk. She'll want it sooner. She'll have to. They all will."

"You don't have to give it by first light."

"No." She looked at him. "But I won't be given the time to be afraid of it either. I'll go and wake the queen."

## Chapter 24

# The Naming Dusk

The queen said yes to the afternoon before Neela had finished asking.

"I thought you might," Nirmala said, sitting up in the dark of the guest room off the north range, her hair in a plain white plait. "A woman who has to be brave will want it done before she can be talked out of it."

"I won't be talked out of it."

"No. But you'd like the option to be tired of the idea. I'm sorry I can't give it to you." She reached for her cloth. "The lower court. When the sun is over the well post."

So it was the lower court, in the long heat after noon, with the dust lying still on the stones and the ram's horn hanging silent on its post.

Neela stood in the middle of the court with her bound hands at her sides. At the cairn fire last night she had told the Company what she meant to say. Kuttu had tried to argue her out of half of it, and Madhavi had made him stop. Now they stood along the north wall in their mud-coloured cloth, forty-one of them, with Vellan at the end, apart, arms crossed. Opposite them stood the queen's thirty. They had come down from the terraces in their green sashes with their sleeves pulled to the knuckle. Usha was at their head. Lata was at the back, looking at the ground.

The queen sat on a plain bench under the tamarind. Haran stood at her right, Sethu at his shoulder. Muthu had the iron disc at his belt. Janu

had come out with her tray and stood by the kitchen door with her chin up, not sitting this time.

Devan stood a step behind Neela's left shoulder. She knew it without looking. She could hear the small hitch in his breath.

"Majesty," she said. "You offered me thirty knives with no pages. Safe, unseen, and yours. The offer was kind. I'm going to refuse it."

No sound came from the garrison. Somewhere on the wall a sandal scraped.

"You asked me to be their master," Neela said. She did not look at the thirty. "I'll say what that means, since nobody here has ever said it plainly. A page owns a woman. You'd burn the pages, so you'd say you'd freed them. But the queen would still be the one who saw them turn. They'd be unseen to everyone but you. Unseen is owned. It is the same cage with the bars painted out."

She counted her breaths. Four. She went on.

"I was Seventeen for twenty-one years. I know what it is to be safe because no one can see you. It was never safety. It was waiting to be sold." She turned her head, then, to the green sashes. "I will not be your master. I won't hold your pages or your names. Nobody in this court will hold a leash over another person while I live. The Company fights by vote. It is bound by what its hands choose, and by nothing else. If the hands say no to me, I sit down."

"That's a lot of sitting down," Kuttu said, from the wall, not quite under his breath. A few of the Company laughed, a short, startled sound.

Neela's mouth twitched. It helped. It always helped, and she hated that.

"One more thing." Her voice went quieter, and she let it. "Before you all. When I came to Kettamala I came to kill the warden. I was paid for it. I had the night, the window and the knife." She breathed in. "I told him my name instead."

She took a step to the side. Not toward him. Only out of his way, so that the court could see.

"This is Devan. I chose him. Nobody gave me to him, and nobody paid for it. I said the one word that could have caged me to the one man who could have used it, and he never did. That is how I know what free is. It is not belonging to no one. It is choosing who you're tied to, and being able to walk away, and staying." Her hands had gone cold. "I'd like the realm to know whose wife I am, and why."

Behind her, Devan was silent. She had asked him to be. But his breath left him, slow and ragged, and a moment later his fingers touched the back of her bound hand. He did not take it. He only let her know he was there. In front of three hundred spears, that was louder than a speech.

The queen sat very still. Then she nodded, once, slowly, as she had nodded in the hall.

"Warden," she said. "You had a paper."

Devan's hand went to his coat. The whole court turned to him.

"I said I'd read it once my wife had answered," he said. "She has. Majesty, do you want it read before the ladders, or after?"

It was how he asked everything, flat and exact, with the choice left in the other person's hands. Neela did not look round.

"After," Nirmala said. Her mouth had a dry, tired line in it. "I know what it says. Read now, in front of Haran's three hundred, it would break the line tonight. Men do not hold a shelf for a queen they have just heard named. Read it once the ladders come down."

"Then after." Devan took his hand from his coat. "I won't read it unasked."

"Thank you. Now I answer the warden's wife."

She stood, and the whole court shifted.

"I could say I'd keep my pages and my guard," she said. "I could say it, and Captain Haran would be glad. But she is right about the cage, and I am too old to make a show of not seeing it." She looked past Neela, to the green sashes. "So. The night-guard stays mine until each of you frees herself. That is the price, and it is a hard one, and I won't hide it. Every guard who names herself will carry her partner's wounds, and her partner hers. Each wound counts twice, once as blood and once as a welt. A

death can pull a second one after it. I'll have a night-guard that cannot be cut without hurting someone she loves. I have weighed that. I think it is worth the weight."

The garrison stood very quiet.

"I will read no page tonight. I say it in front of my captains. Every leaf I hold stays quiet, and no one will be caged by my voice. I need you whole." Her gaze rested on Usha, and then moved along the row, face by face. "Each of you chooses. At this dusk, with the Company, on the shelf, you may name yourselves to someone you've chosen and fight carefully, knowing it. Or you may stay unbound and fight as mine. I won't think the worse of either. I will think the worse of any who choose without looking at the cost."

She sat. It was done.

Neela stood where she was while the court came to pieces around her. Voices rose, boots shuffled, somebody started to weep without noise. Janu was crossing the stones toward her with the tray. The queen had named the price, Neela thought, but not one person who would pay it. She would do that herself, by name, tonight.

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After the sun went under the ridge, the shelf was the colour of old brass. The stakes stood in their rows, pale at the points. Below the lip the river ran loud, and on the far bank the Thurai fires were thick and low, with something big and square moving among them.

Neela counted what she could see. Sixty breaths between the last light and the first drum. Eleven sheaves behind the wall. The tower on the shingle, three men high.

She did not count what she could not. Thirty of the queen's, forty-one of her own. Every one of them would be a cost.

They came out onto the shelf in the going light. The queen's chair had been carried down, and Nirmala sat in it with the red lacquer case open on her lap, the thirty crown leaves laid on blue cloth. Neela sat on a flat stone at her side with Chathu's forty fresh leaves across her knees, the

Company's pages written at the queen's table, held under a board against the wind. On top of them lay the members' own Resin House pages, handed to her for the dusk. Between them they would see every naming burn. Haran's spears stood behind them with their backs turned to the shelf, as Devan had ordered, the garrison facing the road, counting sixty.

"No one smears who isn't naming," Neela said. "No one turns who isn't ready. If you want to wait for the next dusk, there will be one."

"There might not," said Pavi, flatly.

"There might not," Neela agreed.

The first to go was Pavi. She walked across the shelf to Thilak and smeared her throat and wrists without a hand to steady her. Her old-broken forepaw was still a bent wrist for one more minute. Thilak stood where she had put him, with his big tapper's hands open at his sides. When the burn took her, she looked at his face and said something low and quick, in her own voice, and the otter finished on the stones in front of him.

Neela did not hear the word. It was not hers to hear.

On her knee, Pavi's own Resin House page caught where it lay on Chathu's sheaf. A thin line of flame ran along the witness entry and ate it. The intake roll fastened beneath it stayed whole, the green thread unscorched. Neela slid it free and pressed it flat under the board. A name and a village were not the guild's to burn.

Kuttu went to Bhaskaran. The sergeant of the padippura stood with his helm under his arm. At the cairn fire an hour ago he had told his wife, by name, what he meant to do, before he said yes to anyone, so that she would hear it first. Kuttu was shaking too hard to smear the resin. Bhaskaran took the pot from him and did it with his bare fingers, very slowly, because a man with four daughters could do a thing slowly. The resin bit. His fingertips went red and then raw, and he hissed through his teeth and kept going until the last wrist was done. Then he wiped his hand on his thigh and stood and held still. A second leaf curled on Neela's knee, and she saved the roll beneath it.

Sanu went to Kandan. The corporal had a scar through one brow, and a lame mother in Mathoor, and Neela had once said his name and been answered. Sanu had wanted his brother. His brother stood at the back with hands shut, Sajan, not ready, not refusing. Sanu looked once toward him and said, "I'll ask you again after." Then he turned to Kandan, who was white around the mouth and standing as if braced for a blow, and held out his hands.

"Not you," Kandan said. "I'm nobody's—"

"You're the one who said my name when you knew it," Sanu said. "That's enough."

It was true. On the cart road, when Sanu's horse went lame at the boulder, Kandan had asked his name once, from the saddle, and had used it every time since: *Left, Sanu. Water, Sanu.* No one in the green sashes had been called anything in years but a number. Kandan closed his mouth. He nodded. In the queen's lap, a leaf of the thirty caught. Nirmala watched it burn. She made no move to put it out.

They went on. Thulasi started toward Vellan's side of the shelf, remembered he would take no one, and walked to Madhavi instead. A heavy-set guard from the queen's thirty, who had said no in Kodiyur, crossed to a man in Haran's rank, a stranger, a spear-captain with a grey moustache. He took his helm off. Neela knew neither name. Company leaves curled on her knee, guards' leaves in the queen's lap. By the time the red had gone off the ridge, the lacquer case had half emptied itself into ash, and the wind off the river carried the smell of it, scorched and bitter.

Neela kept the ledger in her head, because it was easier than watching faces. Each of them rogue now, in the eyes of the crown. Each of them leaving a page that had burned where it lay. Each wound counted twice, once as blood and once as a welt, and each death able to pull a second after it. A line made of pairs, and a Company that could not afford to be hurt in two places at once.

Devan stood beside her and said nothing. He had ordered the wall. He was holding the shelf. Whatever came up the cut would find the line bent round these people, who had chosen to be bled.

Usha went last.

The light had thinned to the colour of weak tea. The Thurai drums had started, one and then three, as if tuning. Usha crossed the shelf with her sleeves still pulled down, and the paste on her throat cracked a little as she swallowed. She went to no one on the wall. She went to the queen's chair, and stopped three paces in front of it.

"Majesty," she said. "Look at me."

Nirmala's hand stayed on the case. The topmost leaf lay under it, the one with Usha's number, Nineteen, in a quick slanting hand.

Neela saw the old woman's face. She saw the queen weigh it as she had weighed everything, a realm's worth of arithmetic folded into one pause. Nirmala could have looked away. Anyone could have looked at the river, or the case, or Haran. Looking would cost her. It would give the girl she had once sealed into a green sash a share of her wounds, and a woman who had never in fifty-four years shared a cut with anyone would share them with a guard.

The queen looked.

She raised her eyes and held Usha's, steady, and did not blink. Usha smeared the resin on her own throat with two fingers and then on her wrists, and pulled back her cuffs. The flat pared seam showed. The burn took her. Her breath caught.

"I choose you," Usha said. It was not the shape. It was the word before the word. Then she said the other, very low, to Nirmala alone, and Neela turned her face away.

The last leaf of the twenty-six went up with a small dry sound. The ash rose white in the dusk. Four leaves lay on in the case, untouched, for the four who were not ready.

The queen's mouth shook once. Then she put her hand over it, and took it down.

"It stings," Nirmala said, to nobody. "It does sting."

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Four of the thirty held back from the naming line and did not come forward. Lata was one. She stood by the stakes with her arms crossed over her sash and her face closed. She had refused her page in Kodiyur, and she was refusing this too, and nobody went to her. Sajan stood near her, two others behind him. The queen had said she would not think the worse. She did not turn her head.

Kamalakshi did not name. She had said in the cairn firelight that she had no one to give it to, and she would not give it to a person who didn't want it. She stood at the back with her arms folded, a thin cropped girl who had laughed once at the shelter. Her leaf lay unburned on Neela's knee. Vellan stood a long way from her, at the narrow place, a man alone against a wall. Unbound, he had said. He had a bad wooden bird inside his shirt, and he looked at no one.

Neela turned that over, too. Four unready, two unbound, and the rest tied to a person by a cord of blood. It was the most exact accounting she had ever done, and it would not balance.

"Now the dark," Devan said, low. He was looking at the far bank.

The last light went off the water. The fires on the far side blinked as something big crossed in front of them. The drums quickened.

Neela went to the thorn below the lip, where the Company by rotation was to smear and turn, and found the new pairs already learning each other. Kuttu, in shape, set a forepaw on a stake point, and Bhaskaran, ten paces off at the wall, swore and shook his hand. Pavi clipped her paw on a rock and Thilak staggered like a man pushed. Thulasi's foreleg scraped a thorn, and Madhavi hopped three steps and caught herself on the wall. Sanu put a pad down on a flint edge and Kandan gave a startled laugh and then stopped laughing.

"That's how it feels," Neela said to them all, over the drums. She was not shouting. "It's a small thing. It's meant to be small. Learn it now, with thorns. By midnight you'll be learning it with iron."

Bhaskaran had crossed the stakes. He crouched by the animal at his feet, still rubbing his raw fingertips, and looked down into its eyes. "Does it get easier?" he asked it.

The animal looked up at him and could not answer. Neela did.

"No," she said. "You get better at it."

Devan's hand closed on her shoulder, brief and dry. She did not turn. She smelled the resin on her own wrists, and the first burn began at her throat.

"Left side," he said.

"I know where it is."

She put her eyes on his face for the span of one long breath. She did not say the word. She had no need. She stepped down into the thorn, and the world went to scent.

A drum stopped.

The silence was entire. On the far bank, the great square shape on the shingle began to move, very slowly, on its cart. Torches ran ahead of it. Along the lip the garrison's backs straightened, and Haran's voice rolled down the line, flat and carrying, calling the ranks.

Then the first ladder came out of the dark, iron-hooked and slick with river water, and struck the lip of the shelf with a crack of timber on stone.

## Chapter 25

# The Spear

The third ladder came over the lip while the second was still burning, and Devan put his spear through the first man who showed above the rung.

He did it without thinking. Since the scouts on the shelf, his body no longer asked leave. The man had a bronze cap and a mouth open to shout, and the point went in under the jaw and the shout never came. Devan wrenched the shaft free, braced his boot on the dead man's shoulder and shoved. Ladder, man and hooks went backward into the dark. Somewhere below, wood broke.

"Left, Sanu!" Kandan yelled from three paces down the wall. "Water, damn you, water!"

Devan did not look. He had one rule for tonight: look only at the next hand that came over.

The shelf burned in pieces. Torches on the stakes, a pitch pot someone had kicked over, the orange glow of the tower where it squatted on the shingle with its ram arm half raised. Beyond the stakes the river was loud and black. Between the stakes and the lip, the Thurai kept climbing out of it with bronze on their heads and iron hooks on their ladders, and the line held them and bent and held.

It was the first watch. The drums had been going since dusk. Devan had counted six ladders, then eleven, then stopped counting.

Neela was at his left.

He knew it by sound, not sight. A scrape of pads on stone, a low cough of breath, a warm bulk that moved when he moved. When he stepped, she stepped. When his left side dropped, as it always did when he was tired, a spotted shape was there to fill it, and a raider's thrust that should have opened his ribs found teeth instead.

He kept his eyes front. He was learning how to be guarded.

A sting lit his left forearm, sharp, then a second on the calf. Hers. A bar of fire along one flank, a scored line he could feel but not see. He gritted his teeth and kept the spear moving. Each welt was a count in a ledger he had agreed to keep. Every blow she took, he wore. Every blow he took, she wore. They had bought that at dusk in the Resin House yard, and tonight was the first time anyone would pay in full.

The Company paid beside them. He could see it, between ladders, by torchlight. An otter slid along the foot of the wall and a tall tapper in grey fought a pace behind her, spear held crosswise to shield her flank. When a raider's hook dragged across the otter's back, the tapper flinched, stumbled and kept his feet. A boar the size of a calf stood at the wall's end with Bhaskaran at its shoulder, the sergeant's raw fingers wrapped on his shaft. Sanu's long shape went flat to the stones, and Kandan, who had sworn he was nobody's, stood over it with a shield from a dead man's arm and took the hook meant for its neck.

They were fighting carefully. That was the word for it. Every animal looked for its partner before it struck, and every partner looked for the animal. They were slower than they would have been alone, and none of them was dying.

Not yet.

"Warden!" Muthu's voice, from behind, thick with smoke. The captain stood on the firing step with his garrison archers in a row, working their bows as fast as hands could draw. "Sheaf six is empty!"

"Take from the dead."

"They're on the wrong side of the stakes!"

"Then take from ours." Devan heard how it sounded, and did not take it back. "Muthu. Keep the arrows on the tower. Not the ladders. The tower."

"If the tower comes—"

"It's why I want you on it."

A crack of bows answered, ragged and then even.

Devan cleared a gap with the spear's butt, took a breath that tasted of pitch, and saw the thing he had been afraid of.

It happened where the line bent. A slight guard from Usha's riders had gone into the front rank beside a Kettamala spearman. Devan did not know her name. She had been paired with the man at dusk, and he had seen it from Neela's side on the shelf. The man was Vasu, who kept a mother with ducks at Kalladi. Their cords were new. Not two hours old.

She was fighting in her own shape. Devan could not make out what it was. It was low and quick and dark, and the only thing he could see was that it was too quick, going forward as if no one stood behind her. She took a hooked blade across the shoulder. A shallow cut, nothing, a line.

Vasu screamed.

Not from the cut. From the share. Devan watched it travel up the man's arm as if a hand had closed there. Vasu's spear slipped, and he went down on one knee in the line with his mouth open. The animal turned her head, and in the half breath that she looked back for him, a Thurai captain stepped through the place where she had stood.

Raiders poured into the gap.

There were no more than eight of them, then twelve. There was the red horsehair crest of the captain, a long blade, two others with hooks. The guard-beast snapped at an ankle and was struck back. Vasu had his hands on the wall, trying to rise. Behind them stood three pairs, new ones, Pavi and Thilak's neighbours, animals half turned to see why the line had broken, and the men beside them with their spears pointed at the wrong dark.

If the gap stayed open for ten heartbeats, the line would fold from the middle and every pair on the wall would be behind the Thurai instead of before them.

Devan did not decide. He had decided already, a long time ago, in a tack room, over a bad bow.

He knew what the step would cost the spotted shape at his flank. He took it anyway, and felt her come with him, pace for pace, as if she had been asked.

"Left," he said, to nobody, to her. And stepped into the hole.

The captain saw him come. He was a lean man with a thin beard and a cap of beaten bronze, and he had the wide-footed stance of a man who had killed in rooms like this one before. His blade came up. Devan's spear was in his right hand, point low, and the captain's eyes went to the spear.

Devan dropped it.

He heard it ring on the stones. He had not used the other weapon since the bank of the lower ford at twenty-four, and then it had been on a man already on his knees. Eight years he had kept his hand for answering, hidden, a thing held back against the day it was forced. Now he used it openly, with the torches and the garrison and the Company behind him, and with a man's mother's ducks hanging on the line. The fear that had sat on his chest all these years went still.

The two fingers of his right hand went out and found the notch below the captain's ear.

It was no more than a tap. He felt the small hard place give. The captain's eyes widened, then emptied, and he went down in front of Devan with the sword still in his grip, like a man lying down to rest. Nobody had struck him. He had fallen.

Devan felt the quiet it left, a clean cold space where noise had been, and then the next man was there, and the next. He scooped up Vasu's fallen spear with his left hand. His left dropped, as it always did, and a spotted body slammed into the space and the hook meant for his ribs

closed on fur instead. He felt it. A long burning drag along his own side, as though someone had pulled a rake through it. He did not stop.

"Back!" he shouted at the three pairs. "Close up, turn, face me! Left of me, now!"

They moved. An animal and a man, an animal and a man, and the gap had a wall in it. Devan stood in the middle of it with a borrowed spear, three newly bound pairs at his back and a leopard at his left flank. For three breaths, four, five, the line held.

Then he turned to take the next ladder man, and a different man came over the lip behind it.

Devan never saw where from. He caught only the shape of it at the edge of his eye: a raider with no cap, a short heavy spear, the haft sliding through two hands in the torchlight. Too close. Devan swung his borrowed shaft across, a beat late. The spear point came in under his right collarbone.

There was no pain at first. It felt like being struck with a fist and then with a cold finger. The point went through, he felt it go, felt the iron come out through the meat at the back and stop against his own shoulder blade. His breath left him in a hard push. The borrowed spear dropped. He looked down and saw the haft standing out of him, a polished ash shaft with a thumb-worn grip, ridiculous, like a post stuck in a field.

The fingers of his right hand would not close on it. They did not move.

Then something went out from behind him, the way a lamp goes out in a room you thought was empty.

He felt it before he heard it. A great drag pulled at the world on his left. Not a sound. A drop. A leopard's bulk sagged against his hip and went down, as if the share had put a hand on her neck and pushed. He felt the same spear in a different body. He felt, at the same moment, her cold: a chill climbing from the soles of her feet, a pull at the collarbone exactly where the spear had gone. It was the cost, and neither of them had understood how it would feel.

"Neela," he said. It came out of him in a rasp.

She did not answer. She could not. He felt her paws scrabble on the stones and fail.

The raider put his boot against Devan's chest to pull the spear free. Devan, with one working hand, caught the man's wrist and held it. It was a bad grip. It was the grip of a man who had run out of everything but refusal. The raider laughed, or began to, and then the sound changed.

A roar rolled up from the cut.

It was not like any sound the Thurai had made all night. It came from the narrow place at the top, where the walls drew in, and it was so large that the ladders shook with it. Devan smelled musk and old tamarind, scorched sap and wet fur. A huge black shape crossed the stones at a drag and a step, faster than it had any right to be.

Vellan's bear took the raider off Devan's chest as a man takes a toy from a child. It threw him a spear's length. Then it stood over the gap with its forelegs spread and its great head swinging, and the Thurai who had been pouring through stopped pouring. A hook rang against its shoulder. The bear took it in its teeth and broke it. Then it roared again, and the roar went down the line like a wind, and the three pairs at Devan's back found their feet.

The bear had left the narrow place. It had abandoned the one spot it had asked to hold, alone and unbound, so that no one would bleed for it. Devan thought, with a clear far-off wonder, that the cut was open behind him now.

He thought: someone should tell him.

His knees went. He did not fall so much as sit, and then lie back, and the stones were cold and rough under his shoulders. The spear shaft had been broken off short by someone's hand; he did not see whose. It lay across his chest like a lever. The sky above the shelf was black and torn with sparks. He could not tell if the stars were stars or embers.

He lifted his right hand. It lay where he put it and did nothing, open, as though it had never held a thing in its life. Two of its fingers had

found a man's neck a little while ago. They would not find anything now.

*Eight years,* he thought. *I kept it to answer with. And I used it first.*

Something moved close at his left side.

He turned his head, and it cost him. A leopard lay on the stones beside him, so near that her flank was against his arm. Her eyes caught the torchlight and gave it back gold. A raw wet line ran along her ribs, and another across her shoulder, matching the burn he now felt on his own. Her breath came short and quick, and each breath pulled against the place in him where the iron had been.

He knew that breath. He had listened to it across a bed since their wedding night. He had counted its catch and its hitch in the dark and never told her what it did to him.

She could not speak. The shape did not allow it. She could not take his hand, because she had no hand, only a heavy paw that she laid on his wrist with great care, claws sheathed, as if his wrist might break. It did not close on anything. It did not hold. It only lay there, warm.

"Don't," he said. His mouth tasted of iron. "Don't try to stand. You'll tear it."

She turned her head and pressed her forehead against his jaw.

That was all she could do, and it was not nothing. Somewhere above them the bear was roaring, and a woman's voice was shouting for the stretcher bearers, and a horn he did not know the code for was going on and on. The Thurai drums had changed their beat. The ground shook with something big. He could feel the tower coming, and he could not rise to meet it.

He did not know whether he would see the dawn. He did not know whether she would. The share ran both ways, and what had gone into him had gone into her, and he could feel the cold coming up from her legs like water in a well.

Her breath was against his throat. It hitched, and caught, and went on.

His thoughts were thin now, and slow, and one at a time. The wall. The bear. The stakes. Muthu's arrows. Janu, asleep, somewhere in a court that still stood. All of it was far off, and getting farther, and what stayed was small and plain.

Since Asha, there had been a wall behind him and nothing on the other side of it.

He felt the leopard's bulk on his left, and her breath on his neck, and the bear above the gap, and the line holding.

His back was not empty.

## Chapter 26

# Until First Light

They dragged him by the shoulders, and Neela went with him.

She could not stand. Her hind legs had stopped answering somewhere on the stones, and the cold climbed them like water filling a jar. So she crawled. She dragged her belly over the rock beside his boots, and her claws left white lines behind her. Kandan had Devan under the arms. Muthu had his legs. Neither man looked at her. They looked at the broken shaft standing out of Devan's chest and said nothing.

Under her own collarbone, a welt burned. It was deep and hot, and it sat exactly where the iron had gone into him. Every breath pulled at it. She was bleeding there, a little, in the thick fur at her throat. Only the shape of his wound, drawn on her. But the cold kept climbing, and she knew what the cold meant.

*Mortal wound drags the other.* Ammu had said it in the straw. Neither of them had understood it then.

She wanted to say his name. The leopard had no mouth for it. What came out of her was a low, wet cough.

"I know," Muthu said, hauling. His face was black with smoke and streaked clean under the eyes. "I know. Nearly there."

Nearly there was the rear of the shelf, where the cut narrowed and the wall made a pocket against the rock. Someone had hung a hooded lantern from a stake. Someone had spread a cart tarpaulin on the stones. Beyond it, the line was a noise: iron, bronze, shouting, the drums. The

bear's roar came from above, from the top of the cut, from the place that should have been empty.

Kandan let Devan down onto the tarpaulin as if he were glass. Neela did not wait to be asked. She climbed onto him.

She laid herself across his chest, below the wound, with her forelegs over his ribs and her weight on the wet cloth they had packed in the hole. He was a long man and she was a heavy cat. His heart beat under her, quick and faint, like a thing running a long way off.

"Good," said a voice above her. "Stay exactly there."

A woman knelt at his head. She was past fifty, broad in the shoulder, her grey hair tied up in a strip of green. She had a leather roll open on the tarpaulin, and the lantern gleamed on what was in it. A clamp. A curved needle. A hank of waxed silk. Neela knew her: the woman from the Kodiyur drying shed, who had laid the paring knife down. It did not matter now.

"Thankam," the woman said, to the leopard, as though the leopard might not remember. "The queen's surgeon. I am going to cut his coat off and then I am going to hurt him. Your weight is better than any hand I've got. If you shift, he bleeds. Do you understand?"

Neela lowered her chin onto his breastbone.

"Good," Thankam said again.

*

The knife went through the cloth with a sound like tearing paper. Devan's breath changed. It went short and then long, and a noise came out of him. It was not a word.

Neela counted.

She always counted. Exits, steps, doors. Now it was breaths, his breaths under her ribs. *One. Two.* A third of the way through a long count, there was a hitch. A small catch, like a hand missing a rung. She had learned it in the dark of the warden's chamber, lying awake beside a man who pretended to sleep. She waited for it now as she had waited then. It came. She let the count go on.

*One. Two. Hitch.*

"Clamp," Thankam muttered. She was talking to herself, or to Muthu, who was holding the lantern too low. "Higher, Captain. Higher. I need to see the back of it."

Muthu lifted the light. His hand shook. He steadied it with the other.

Devan's eyes had opened. Neela knew it by the tightening of the chest beneath her. She raised her head and looked into his face, grey as ash, with sweat standing on the lip. His eyes found her and slid away, and found her again.

"Cold," he said. It was a thread of a voice. "Your legs. Someone. Her legs."

Neela went still.

He was bleeding on a tarpaulin with iron in his back, and the thing he had noticed was her hind legs.

Muthu did not argue. He tore off his own coat and laid it over her haunches and tucked it under her flank, clumsily, the way a man covers a sleeping dog. It smelled of smoke and horse and sweat. The cold in her legs did not stop. But it dulled, as if a door had been put between her and it.

Devan's eyelids drooped. His mouth moved.

"Go up," he said.

She did not move.

"The line. Vellan. You're a better..." His breath caught on the hitch and he had to start again. "Go. I'll keep."

Up the cut, the bear roared. Neela's whole body answered it. Her claws pricked the tarpaulin. She could have been up the stones in three bounds, if her legs would carry her. She could have put herself between the Thurai and the narrow place, and been useful, and loud, and a leopard for some good purpose.

And his blood would have come up through the cloth the moment she rose.

She knew it as one knows a step in the dark. The choice was not hard to see. It was only hard to do.

The other one's every instinct was for the fight. Hers was a small stubborn thing, learned in a room with a barred shutter. She laid her chin back on his chest, and pressed down.

He saw it. His lips moved again, not on words this time. His good hand, the left, came up off the tarpaulin and found the fur of her neck, and rested there.

"Stubborn," he whispered. "Good."

*

"The nerve is cut," Thankam said.

She said it in the flat voice of a woman who had said such things to soldiers all her life. She had the clamp in, and the bleeding had slowed to a seep, and she was working the silk through with a hand that did not shake. Devan was gone again, far under, his breath long and slow. Neela was grateful. She wished she could close her ears.

"Behind the collarbone, where the plexus runs. The spear went through it. The shoulder will mend, and the lung is whole, which is a mercy I'd not have bet on. But the nerve to the hand is cut clean." Thankam drew the thread. "I can close the wound. I can't close that. If it grows back, it will take a year, and the hand may never close hard again."

No one answered.

A light moved at the edge of the lantern's reach. Neela's ears turned, and a figure came around the rock with a second lamp in her fist. A small woman in a plain dark wrap, her hair coming out of its plait.

The queen did not look at her guard or at her captain. She came to the tarpaulin and knelt on the stones, in the blood, with no cloth under her knees. She held her left arm a little away from her body.

On the forearm, below the pushed-up sleeve, a welt had risen. It was a red slanting line, raised and angry, the length of a hand. A fresh cut. Not hers. Usha's, from somewhere in the line.

Nirmala saw Neela looking.

"It does sting," she said, very dry. "I was told it would. I find I can't stop attending to it." She set her lamp on a rock where Thankam could use it. "You'll want light on the shoulder. Give me his."

She took the lantern out of Muthu's hand. Muthu let her.

She held it steady. Neela watched her do it. The old woman knelt there with her wrist bleeding a little through its own cloth and the light never wavered, though the line was close and the ground shook with the tower's ram. She held it exactly where the surgeon needed it, as if she had done nothing else.

"I held lamps once," Nirmala said, to nobody. Her eyes were on Devan's face. "For each of them, at the first turning. A room, one flame, a child with resin on her wrists, and a woman who must not look afraid." She breathed. "I told myself the light was so that they could see a face. It was so that I could."

Thankam's needle went in. The queen's hand did not move. But Neela, who had spent twenty years learning what people did with their hands when they were afraid, saw the knuckles go white on the lantern's bail.

"I did not count the cost," the queen said. "I counted everything else."

Neela could not answer. She did not think an answer was wanted. She only lay across a man's chest and let a queen hold the light, and saw how small the old woman was in it.

*

Time went by in breaths.

She counted them past a hundred and past a thousand, and lost the number, and began again. *One. Two. Hitch.* Each time the catch came, something gave in her own ribs. The cold in her legs held at the knees. It went no higher. She did not know if that was Thankam's silk, or her own body's weight, or the plain stubbornness of a man who had decided to be there in the morning.

She learned the sounds of the night. The ram stopped. The drums changed beat, then thinned, then began again from farther off. Garrison archers cursed and sang and cursed. Somewhere a man cried a name over and over. She did not know whose.

The bear roared. Each time, she counted the gap before the next. It was short at first. By the middle watch, it was long.

She lifted her head once, when the pain in her collarbone went quiet. Between two stakes, past the lip, the river lay black and moving, and something was in it.

It was long and low, and it rode very flat in the water. It was nothing she knew. Koman had called it a shape the Resin House had never made. It moved along the shingle bank where the Thurai dead lay half in the current, and it took a man by the harness in its jaws and drew him up out of the river, and left him above the water line. Then it went back for another. Raiders were calling from the far bank. A torch swung, and the creature slid under it and was gone. It did not fight. It did not look at the shelf. It pulled the wounded out and let them breathe.

She did not understand it. She was too tired to try. She put her head down on Devan's chest.

*One. Two.*

*Hitch.*

*

The sky greyed from the east. First the stakes grew edges, and the stones showed their colour, and the faces around the tarpaulin turned from black to bone. Then the cold went out of her hind legs all at once.

She knew what was coming. She had always known. It came the way it had come every morning of her life, unasked.

The turning back was pain.

It began in her spine and ran out along her limbs. The leopard's muscle drew in and the woman's came up through it, and her bones remembered a shorter shape and fought to keep a longer one. Her claws were nails. Her paws were hands. The coat on her haunches grew heavy,

and Muthu's shirt-sleeves were suddenly there in her fingers. Her skin was bare and wet to the dawn. She retched. She had no breath for a sound.

Someone had turned their back. Kandan, standing at the rock with his shoulders square and his face to the cliff. Muthu, too, with a blanket held out behind him at arm's length. The queen did not turn. She had seen it before, and Neela had already said her word to one man. A witness's silence was a favour now, not a need. It still counted.

She took the blanket. She did not remember doing it.

Her voice was a scrape. "Don't. Move. Him."

"We won't," said Thankam.

Neela got her hands under her. They worked. Her fingers were stiff and white and shaking, and they were hers. She crawled the last arm's length on her knees, to where his head lay, and bent over him.

His eyes were shut. His lips were blue. The seep at the pad over his wound had come back, red and slow, and she could feel it in her own chest like a thumb pressed on the bone.

She knew where the point was. Her mother's people could not have taught it, and the Resin House had. A hand's breadth under the jaw, at the hollow of the throat, where the pulse beat close to the skin. Heal or kill; it depended on the hand and the heart behind it.

She set two fingers on it.

*Breathe,* she thought, and did not say it. He had no need of an order. She leaned her weight into the touch, very light, then a little less. She counted three. She counted his hitch.

Under her fingers, the blood eased.

It was nothing a stranger would have seen. The red on the pad thinned from a seep to a bead and from a bead to a stain. Thankam's head came up. In Neela's own breastbone, the hot stabbing line she had carried all night settled, like a lamp turned low.

Above them, at the top of the cut, the roaring stopped.

It did not trail off. It stopped between one breath and the next, and the quiet that took its place was larger than any noise. Neela's fingers did

not leave Devan's throat. She did not lift her head. She knew that silence. It was the silence of a house with the door left open.

The queen lowered the lantern. In the grey light it looked like a small, ordinary thing, a clay lamp with its flame gone pale.

"Who will go up?" Nirmala asked.

No one answered.

Devan's chest rose under Neela's hand, and fell, and caught on its small familiar hitch. She stayed where she was, bare and shaking, and counted it, and did not let go.

## Chapter 27

# Keep the Light There

Devan woke to a hand he could not feel.

It lay on the tarpaulin beside him, palm up, and it looked like something a stranger had left there. He told the fingers to close. Nothing happened. The silence at the top of the cut was the second thing he noticed. The bear had stopped.

Grey light. Smoke and wet stone. Neela sat against his left side in Muthu's coat with a blanket over her shoulders and her bare feet drawn up. Her two fingers were still against the hollow of his throat, as if she had forgotten them there.

"Vellan," he said.

Her eyes came up. They told him she had been listening to that silence all night. "Muthu says he's sitting."

"Sitting where?"

"At the top. Against the rock. Nobody's gone near him." She swallowed. "Nobody knows what the bear left."

He tried to rise. The shoulder said no in a voice like a cleaver, and the dead arm dragged at his side. Thankam, asleep on her knees over her roll, jerked awake.

"Lie still, Warden, or I stitch you twice."

"I need to go up the cut."

"You need to lie flat for a week."

"A man is dying up there who held the narrow place for me." He heard how that sounded. "And he has something that's mine."

Thankam looked at him a long moment. Then at Neela, who said nothing and did not need to. The surgeon cursed in a coast dialect and called for the captain.

Muthu and Kandan did it with a door. It had come off a guard shed in the night, and it still had its iron strap hinge. They laid it by the tarpaulin and slid Devan onto it, and Thankam bound his arm to his chest with a green sash so the dead hand could not swing. Neela walked beside him, barefoot on the stones, holding the corner of the blanket with one fist. Every few steps her hand came up and touched his shoulder, then went away, as though checking a latch.

The cut climbed between walls of red rock. He saw it from his back, one ledge at a time. A bronze cap in the shingle. A ladder hook still sunk in a stake. Thurai dead lay in rows where the line had held them, and others lay singly where they had come over and not gone back. Past the stakes the river ran brown and quiet. Far down the road, toward the strand, a thin dust rose where the host was pulling away. The drums were still going, but slowly, like a heart that has finished running.

"They've drawn back," Kandan said, to nobody. "To the beach. They'll count us."

"Let them," said Muthu.

Devan said nothing. He was counting something else. At the narrow place the cut drew in until two carts could not pass, and there the dead lay thickest. They lay in a half circle, bronze and torn leather, and some of them bore no mark he could name.

The bear had made a wall of them. Vellan sat against the rock behind it.

*

He was a man again, as the dawn had made him. He sat with his legs out and his big hands in his lap, in the grey wool of a Company tapper, and the wool was dark to the knees. Someone's hook had opened him from

hip to ribs. He held his belly shut with one arm, and the other lay across his chest. The bad leg lay straight at last, with no drag left in it. A bird sat in his palm.

It was a bad bird. Devan saw that from the door, and so did the whole cut, probably. One wing was thicker than the other and the beak had split. Someone had cut it with a dull knife and no patience.

"Warden," Vellan said. His voice was a grumble with the bottom taken out. "You brought a door."

"Muthu did."

"Good man." His eyes went past Devan, to Neela, and stayed. "Seventeen. Sit. You're swaying."

Neela knelt in the blood. She did not argue. Kandan and Muthu lowered the door and stepped back, and Muthu pulled Kandan's sleeve until the two of them walked away down the cut, out of hearing. Devan was grateful. Nobody ought to see this.

"I can't do anything for it," Vellan said. "Thankam would say so. I'd not trouble her." He looked down at the arm across his belly. "Unbound. That was the point. Nobody bleeds for me. I'd have hated to hear that I'd cut anyone."

"You left the narrow place," Devan said.

"I did." A dry breath that was almost a laugh. "The line gapped. Somebody ought to fill a gap. It's an old habit."

"You told me you'd say it once you'd earned it."

"I haven't." The big hand tightened on the bird. "I've no way left to earn it. So I'll say it anyway and you can do what you like with the words. Is that fair?"

Devan found that he could not speak. Neela's fingers had come to rest on his left wrist. He turned the hand over and held on.

"Sit nearer," said Vellan.

They did.

"She came down the west stair in the dark," Vellan said. "Late. Past the second watch. She had no lamp. I was low on the stair, in shape, by

the grate under the eleventh step, back against the wall where the dark was thickest. I heard her before I saw her. She was counting."

Devan's mouth went dry.

"Out loud, under her breath. Forty-four, forty-three, forty-two. Slow. One hand on the rail. I thought, this one's afraid of the dark. It's no business of mine, but I marked it." Vellan's eyes had gone far back. "She came down a long way before she saw anything. Then, far below, at the foot, a little glimmer. A shuttered lamp, opened a thumb's width."

Neela made a sound. It was very small.

"Yours," Vellan said. He did not look at her. "You'd been told to open it twice if anyone came into the court. She wasn't in the court. She was on the stair. You opened it once, I think. Just the once, out of fright. A thumb of light."

"I don't remember," Neela whispered. "I remember counting. I remember the dark."

"You opened it. She saw it." Vellan breathed, carefully, around his wound. "And she called down. Not loud. 'Who's there?'"

Devan shut his eyes.

"You didn't answer. You were twenty-one and you'd been blindfolded and told to be a post. Quite right. And she waited. And then she smiled." The big man's voice changed. It wasn't an imitation. It was only as careful as a man handing over something that might break. "I saw it. I was close enough. She smiled at the light, and she said, 'Dev? Keep the light there. I can see the steps.'"

The cut was so quiet Devan could hear the river.

"She thought it was you, Warden. At the foot of the stair, with a lamp, for her. She thought her brother had waited up." Vellan swallowed. "She came on down, counting, her palm sliding on the rail. Easy. She wasn't afraid. She only saw me at the last, when she was nearly on me, and I'll tell you, she looked at the bear and then she looked back down at the light. As if to check it was still there. She never took her eyes off it."

Neela had made herself small beside him. Her hand had gone to her mouth.

"That's the whole of it," Vellan said. "I've carried it six years and I thought it would be heavier to put down. It isn't."

*

For a long moment Devan felt nothing. That was how he knew it was coming.

Then it came all at once, from under his right collarbone, where the spear had passed. Six years. Six years of a wall at his back. He had slept with it, eaten with it, and never let a living soul stand behind him on a stair.

Asha had come down forty-odd steps in the dark, afraid of it all her life, and she had looked at a thumb of lamplight and thought: *Dev's there.*

And someone had been. Not him. A lamp, and a woman behind it.

He did not choose to weep. The sound came up through his chest like water from a well, and the shoulder tore and the dead arm shook against the sash, and he could not stop. He wept as he had not at the pyre, or at the writ, or in the grey before dawn with Janu's lamp. It was loud and ugly. He did not turn his face.

Neela's arms came round him.

Both of them. She did not ask. She got her arms under his good shoulder and across his chest, below the wound, and pulled him against her, and held on with both hands as if he might go over an edge. He felt her cheek on his hair. Through her he felt the shape of her own grief, which was not his grief and was the same. Her breath shook. A tear fell on his scalp.

"I opened it once," she said into his hair. "Once. I didn't know."

"You couldn't have."

"I know."

"Don't ask me to forgive you." He wasn't certain it was his voice. "There's nothing there to forgive. You gave her a light."

She was quiet so long he thought she would say nothing. Then her voice came, very low, against his hair.

"Three hundred and ten," she said. "That's how long I stood at the foot of that stair, after. They'd unwrapped my eyes and told me to count, and I counted. I've never told anyone the number. I thought if I said it out loud it would be something I'd done."

"It was something you did," Devan said. "You stood where you were put, in the dark, and you counted. So did she. Two of you, counting, on the same stair." He turned his good hand over on her wrist. "I'll keep the three hundred and ten with you. Half of it's mine now."

She said no word. She only held him tighter, and the two of them rocked together on the red stone, a man with a dead hand and a woman in a borrowed coat, over a thing neither would put down and neither would carry alone.

*

When he could look up, Vellan's eyes were on them.

"I'd have liked to hear what you'd have said," the big man murmured. "Well. It's said." The bird shifted in his palm. He closed his fingers over it with great care. "The girl's bird. Kamalakshi. Terrible, isn't it? She cut it with my own knife. I told her the beak was wrong. She said it was supposed to be." The grumble was fading. "Keep it where it is. I'd not like it taken."

"It stays," said Devan.

"Good. I've done what I could." The breath went in and out. "There's a Thurai boy at my feet. Fifteen. Someone ought to see that he's buried."

"I'll see it," said Neela.

"Aye. You would. You've the names." His head tipped back against the rock. His gaze went up, past them, to the top of the cut and the grey sky above it. "It's light," he said, a little surprised. "I can see the steps."

Devan did not move. Neela's arms had not loosened. After a long time, when the breath had not come again, she put two fingers to the big

man's throat, where the pulse lay close. She held them there a good while.

Then she took her hand away and shook her head.

*

They carried him up the last of the cut on the door. Devan walked.

He had not asked leave. He had stood, with Muthu's arm under his good shoulder, and said, "Put Vellan on it." Nobody had argued. Four men lifted the big man between them, and his hand stayed shut on the bird, and the blanket over his face moved a little in the wind.

The cut climbed on in the new light, red and wet. Garrison men stood along it with their spears grounded. They did not salute. Some looked at the door, and some at Devan's sash, and Kuttu, the ferryman's son, stood with both hands over his mouth. Pavi had her arm round Thilak, who was not weeping but breathing like a man who had been under water. The Company had come out of the night thirty-odd strong where there had been forty-two. Nobody counted aloud.

The lower court of Kettamala had been turned into a camp. Cook-fires, a row of cots, a well with a line already at it. Janu stood by the kitchen door with a pot in each fist. When she saw the door and the blanket and the sash on Devan's arm, she set the pots down very slowly and did not come forward. He gave her a nod. She pressed her apron to her mouth.

Queen Nirmala was waiting by the well.

She sat on an overturned bucket, with her left arm in a bandage and Usha at her shoulder. In her lap lay a flat case of green-lacquered leather, scorched along one edge, brought up from the red chest in the night. She had it open. The leaves inside were thin and pale and mostly not leaves at all. They were black curls, ash, a drift of it on the blue cloth. A few remained whole.

She looked up as the door passed. She did not stand. She looked at the blanket, and her mouth moved a little, and she said, "The bear."

"Vellan," Neela said.

"I know his name. I paid for his kind for twenty years and never once asked it." The queen's voice was quite level. "I ask it now. It is a poor time to learn what a name weighs."

No one answered. Muthu set his end of the door in the shade of the wall, and the others laid it down with care.

Nirmala turned the case so that Devan could see.

"Twenty-six leaves have burned of themselves since the dusk," she said. "Each at its naming, as the witness entry went. Four are left, for the four who were not ready." She ran one finger along the cloth, and the ash came away grey on her skin. "Those are the four pages I can still be made to read. Mine is the voice that would cage them, if I were pressed, and every guard of the four knows it."

"Will you keep them?" said Devan.

"I have not decided. That is the worst thing I own." She closed the lid over the black. "You have your hand, Warden? No. Thankam told me. Then I will say it to the one who still has two." She looked at Neela. "You cannot hold what is left with a promise. A company needs a roll. It needs a first name on it, written by daylight where every witness can see, and someone to write it who is not afraid of the ink."

Neela stood very still in Muthu's coat, bare-footed on the court stones, with Vellan's blood to her knees.

"I will tell you what it costs, because no one told me what mine cost," Nirmala said. "The first name written binds that person to the Company's vote, whatever the hands decide. And it makes her the crown's first name to answer. Whatever the Company does, I will lay at that name. I would not ask it of anyone I did not mean to hear from."

She rose from the bucket, slowly, using Usha's arm, and the cold light caught the sunbird on the scorched case.

"Who signs first," she said, "I leave to you."

Devan looked at his own right hand hanging in its sash and thought of a pen. Then of a lamp on a stair.

Somewhere above the court, the first cistern chain clanked the hour.

## Chapter 28

# First Name on the Roll

By midmorning the sun had reached the lower court, and Neela could not stop looking at the ink.

It sat in a cracked clay pot on the well curb, plain black, the kind a clerk buys by the measure. She had bent over it twice already, the way a woman checks a sleeping child. Both times it smelled of nothing at all.

"It won't take," Thilak said beside her. "I tried it on my thumb. Not a mark that stays."

"Good."

He had brought a sheet from the queen's green case, a clean crown leaf, ivory and heavy. He had flattened it on a board across two buckets and weighted the corners with pebbles. His big tapper's hands kept straightening it, though it was already straight. The lamp-black plank leaned against the well. Forty names ran down it in her own hand, and nine blanks had been filled since the Resin House.

Behind her the court was filling. She did not turn to count. She listened: boots on stone, a cough, Kuttu telling someone to move his feet. Garrison men in grey stood three deep along the kitchen wall, and the queen's riders in green along the other. The Company had no colour. They stood where they had slept, in tapper's wool and borrowed coats, thirty-odd where there had been forty-two. She knew every face. She had said every name.

Vellan lay in the shade of the barracks wall under a blanket. Someone had put a smear of lamp-black on the board's edge for him, near the top, so he would be on the plank.

She washed her hands at the well and dried them on Muthu's coat. They were steady. All night they had shaken.

Janu stood at the kitchen door with a pot in each fist, though no one had asked for food. At dawn Neela had told her the one thing Vellan said about the lamp, and Janu had said nothing at all. She had gone back to her pots and had not looked up since. Muthu stood near the gate arch with his hands behind him. The queen sat on her bucket with Usha at her shoulder and the scorched case on her knee, her bandaged arm across it. She did not look at Neela. She had the grace to look at the sky.

And Devan sat on the mounting block with his dead arm in its green sash, and watched her.

He had refused the cot. Thankam had said what she thought of that, at length, and then brought him a stool. He was grey. He did not smile. He held her eyes, and she heard the old click of a latch closing, the one she had learned in a warded room. This time it was a door she had chosen to stand in.

*Say it before you do it,* they had agreed once, in a tack room, with rain on the thatch.

"I'm going to write my name," she said across the court, loud enough for anyone. "First. Then I'm going to ask you to write yours."

"I heard," he said.

"You didn't hear the rest." She turned, so the court could hear her. She had not planned the next part. "The queen says the first name binds me to the Company's vote, whatever the hands decide. If they vote against me, I go with it. And it makes me the first name the crown comes to when the Company does something it dislikes. I'm telling you all now. By daylight. Not in a back room."

Nobody spoke.

"For twenty-one years I answered to a number," she said. "I wanted to be no one's. I wanted it so much I called it freedom." Her voice

scraped. She let it. "It was a very quiet cage. Nobody in it ever bled for me."

She picked up the reed.

It was a poor reed, chewed at the end. She dipped it and her hand hung over the sheet. She had killed with that hand. She had tied a double hitch with it, in her sleep, without knowing where it came from.

*Indu.*

The first stroke was thin. She pressed, and the second was a bold black bar.

*Indu, called Neela, of Nellimala and Kettamala.*

It took less time than a breath. The ink lay wet and shining and did not burn or flare or draw blood. Something went through her anyway, from the base of her skull down into her hands. She would have called it a weight leaving, but it was more like a weight set down on a table where someone else could see it.

"Read it," said Janu, from the kitchen door.

"Janu—"

"Aloud. I'm sixty-one and half deaf and I want to hear."

So Neela read it. Her voice cracked on the second name. In the grey ranks a man said her birth name over under his breath, as if testing it for heft. Pavi pressed a fist to her teeth.

The queen said nothing. But Neela saw her lips move on the word *Kettamala*, and a small, odd stillness cross her face.

*

Devan stood.

It took him a moment. Muthu moved forward and Devan lifted his good hand, and Muthu stopped. The mounting block was six paces from the well. He walked them one at a time. She watched his feet.

"Reed," he said.

Thilak handed it over. Devan took it in his left hand and bent over the board, wearing the face he wore at the kalari pit when a stance was wrong and he had not yet worked out why.

He tried the right hand first.

Nobody had asked him to. He lifted the dead arm out of the sash and set the reed between the fingers. They lay around it like cloth. He told them to close. She saw him tell them. The reed rolled out of his palm and clattered on the board, and spattered a dark star across the corner of the sheet.

Someone drew a breath and held it.

"I'll write it," Neela said, quietly, only to him. She was already reaching. "You say it and I'll put it down. It's no shame, Devan. Asha used to write your letters. You told me."

His good hand closed over the reed first.

"I did tell you," he said. "I'll write my own."

"You can't."

"I'll write it badly."

"Yes."

"Then they'll see me write it badly." His mouth moved, not quite a smile, dry and tired and entirely his. "I spent eight years hiding what I couldn't do, Neela. And what I could. I'm done with both."

It was a terrible hand. The first stroke slid sideways and the second doubled back on itself. He pressed too hard and the nib split. He paused, breathing through his teeth, and she felt the pull of his shoulder as an ache under her own collarbone. Then he went on. The letters crawled across the leaf, big and crooked, each one separate from the last.

*Devan.*

He straightened and let everyone look.

The name sat under hers like a child's first lesson. The *e* leaned drunk against the *v*. A drop of ink had fallen on the last stroke and spread. In front of sixty soldiers, the Warden of Kettamala had written his name worse than Kuttan could.

Nobody laughed.

Kandan came forward first. He was a hard man with a scar through his brow, and he had called her a witch at a barracks door. He took the reed from Devan's fingers without a word and signed in a square, careful

hand. Under it, in smaller letters, he wrote *Mathoor*, his village. Then he stepped back and looked at the sky.

"Bhaskaran," called a voice from the arch, and the sergeant came with his horn on his belt. Kuttu followed, then Pavi, then Thilak, then Thulasi, who limped and would not be helped.

Neela watched the names go down. *Madhavi. Meenu.* Meenu's was small and neat and shook. She had once lived in a cage the width of a hunter's arm, and she signed her whole name, birth and all.

Kamalakshi stood a long time with the reed in her fist, thin and cropped and furious at nothing. Then she bent, wrote, and straightened, and her eye fell on the smear of lamp-black beside Vellan's place.

She laughed. It came out short and rough, like a cough, and then again, with tears running. "He'd have said it was crooked," she said. "My name. He'd have said the *K* leans."

"It leans," Neela said.

"It does." Kamalakshi wiped her face with her sleeve. "Good."

The queen's riders came forward in their green sashes, two by two. Sajan signed with his chin up. Sanu signed after him and looked shyly at Kandan, who nodded. Lata took her turn without looking at anyone, and her hand did not shake.

Usha signed last. She wrote *Usha*, then paused. Neela saw her add a second stroke, slowly, and then more: *Ushakumari*. A potter's daughter, from a hill village. The ink dried on the whole of it in the sun.

Then Usha turned and looked at the queen.

There was no anger in the look. It was the look of a woman setting down something she had carried a very long way and checking whether the other person had noticed. Nirmala met it. Her hand rose a little from the lacquered case, stopped, and lay down again.

"I see it, Usha," the queen said.

That was all. It made Usha's shoulders drop.

*

"The hand won't come back," Thankam said.

She said it to Neela, not to him, because she had learned which of them listened. She had come to the well to wash and stood drying her fingers on a rag. Devan was back on the mounting block, his left hand ink-blue to the wrist.

"I've told you what I told you in the night. A year, if the nerve grows. But I've seen it in daylight, and I'll not lie. It won't close hard again. The two fingers he strikes with won't hold. He can lift a cup with it, in time. He can't kill with it."

Neela's mouth opened. She did not know what she meant to say.

"Then it won't," said Devan.

They both looked at him. He was studying the hand where it lay in the sash, turning it a little with his left. There was no grief in the movement, only attention.

"That strike's been waiting for me since I was twenty-four," he said. "A hair from the notch below an ear. Every time I raised my hand I knew where it would go. I thought it was what made me safe." He let the arm fall. "I used it once more at the cut, before the garrison, because there was no other way. It's gone now." He looked up at Neela, and his eyes were quite clear. "I find I don't mind the gap."

"Warden—" Thankam began.

"I'll learn to hold a pen with the other hand. It'll be a worse hand than the first. But a man who can't strike has to ask, Thankam. I think I'll be better at that."

Thankam made a noise like a cat sneezing and walked away. Neela saw her put the heel of her hand to her eye by the cistern.

Neela sat on the block beside him. Their shoulders touched on the left. His wound pulled at hers, a low hot thread, and she let it.

"You've ink on your collar," she said.

"So have you."

"We look like clerks."

"A shame. I'd hoped for something more dangerous."

She laughed, short, and he leaned the weight of his head toward hers without quite touching. A year ago she would not have let him see her do it.

*

At noon the harbour gun was too far to hear. But the cistern chain clanked twelve times from the wall, and the court went quiet for it.

Janu put down her pots.

She wiped her hands on her apron, twice, and walked across the court. She did not hurry. The soldiers parted for her as they would for a bier. She carried a clay lamp, the plain kind with a sesame-oil wick, and a stub of flint in her fist.

She went to the foot of the west stair.

Neela's breath stopped. Nobody had known Janu meant to go there. Once, for Neela's confession, the woman had crossed the ten paces she had kept from that stair for six years. She had not gone back since. Now she stood below the parrot newel with its broken beak, in the full noon sun, and for a moment her whole back was a question.

Then she crossed the last ten paces.

She stooped and set the lamp on the bottom step, beside the newel. She struck the flint twice, and the wick took. A small, pale flame stood in the bright day, hardly to be seen.

Janu laid her palm flat on the carved parrot's head, as one might touch a child's. She said something no one could hear. She left the lamp burning, turned, and at the edge of the well stopped in front of Neela.

Her eyes were red. Her hand was still wrapped in its cloth. She did not touch Neela with it. She looked at her bare head, the ink on her sleeve, the bangle on her wrist, and last at the man beside her.

"She wasn't alone, then," Janu said.

It was not quite a question. Neela's throat closed. She nodded.

"A light. At the foot." Janu's mouth worked. "I sat at the kitchen fire with her supper warm and I never came out. All these years I thought it

was dark down there." She drew a long breath. "I'll have it burning. At noon. Every noon I'm in this house."

"Janu," said Devan.

"Eat something. Both of you." She was already turning. "Look at the pair of you. Grey as ash."

She went back to her pots. Her shoulders were shaking, and nobody watched.

Across the court the little flame stood on the bottom step of the west stair, a thumb's width of light. Neela found she meant to pass it.

*

"A handsome morning's work," said the queen.

She had waited until the last name was down. Now she rose from her bucket on Usha's arm, and the court turned toward her like a field of grass. The roll lay on its board, sixty names deep, crooked and black and drying in the sun. Nirmala looked longest at the first line.

"You have made it real," she said. "I have been queen of this country thirty years, and I have not seen anyone do a braver thing with a reed."

"But," said Neela.

"But." The queen's voice was gentle. She never raised it. "A roll is not a charter. A charter binds the crown, and I will not be hurried into it by a morning's feeling, however fine." She laid her hand on the scorched case. "I will sign nothing that gives up the crown's right to the leaves I still hold."

Neela's skin went cold in the sun.

"Four guards," Nirmala said. "Sajan, Lata, and two more. They have not named, and I will not have them forced. Nor will I have their pages out of my hand until they are ready, and I will say when that is. And the pages Chathu wrote at my table, the forty. Eleven have no name beside them yet, because eleven have not chosen. They were written under my roof. You hold them on loan, Neela. They are the crown's."

"They're the Company's," said Kandan, hoarse.

"They are *paper*, Corporal," said the queen. "And paper is mine."

"Then so is this." Neela laid her palm flat on the board. "The roll is on your leaf, from your case. Sixty names, and Thilak carried the sheet from your own hand. Take it. Take it now, in front of all of them, and see who signs again."

Nobody moved. The queen looked at the sheet, and at the garrison men in grey, and at Usha, whose name was drying on it. Something in her face weighed the cost and found it high.

"Keep your roll," she said at last, and the courtesy in it was thin as wax. "I want the pages."

The little flame at the stair did not waver. Devan's good hand found Neela's wrist and closed there, not tight.

"You told me what the roll costs," Neela said. Her voice came out level, and she was proud of it. "You didn't say what it was worth."

"No." Nirmala met her eyes. "That is for you to find out. Quickly, I think. The Thurai will count us by dusk."

She sat down again on her bucket, folded her hands on the lacquered case, and was only a small old woman in the sun, waiting.

## Chapter 29

# Plain Ink

Kandan came into the hall with a white rag in his fist and mud to the thighs.

"A herald," he said. "Alone, on a grey horse, with this wound round his spear." He held up the rag as if it might still be hot. "He stopped at the stakes and wouldn't come a step nearer. He says the admiral wants a truce. Three days."

Neela counted the hall without meaning to. Eight pillars, two doors, one window with the shutter back. Twelve people stood in it, and not one of them had slept. The queen sat in the warden's chair, because Devan had put her there, with Usha at her shoulder. Devan stood beside the table with his dead arm in its green sash. Captain Haran, grey-moustached and sour, leaned against a pillar. Muthu stood by the door.

"Three days for what?" said Devan.

"To bury their dead. To wait for the sea lords' word." Kandan's scarred brow pulled down. "I'll tell you what I saw, Warden. Down in the cut there are bronze caps with red crests among the dead. Officers. I counted forty crests before I stopped. When the host pulled back to the beach this morning, it moved under sergeants."

"Captains die first in a narrow place," Devan said slowly. "They go up the ladders to show the men how. He's lost his hands, and he never got the shelf."

"He's lost his nerve," Haran said.

"He's lost some of both. It isn't the same as losing the war." Devan looked at the queen. "I'd take the three days. And I'd double every picket in them."

"As would I." Nirmala folded her hands. "It is a gift I would be a fool to refuse, and a fool to trust. Send the herald back with a yes, Corporal. Tell him the stakes stay where they are."

Kandan went. The hall let out its breath, and Neela felt the stool under her again. She sat by the wall with Chathu's sheaf in its oilcloth across her knees. She had carried it so long that her arms had stopped noticing.

"Then let us use the three," said the queen.

She did not rise. She never needed to. The court of Kettamala had learned that about her in a single morning.

"The Company may exist," she said. "I say it here, before the pickets and the captains and the clerk with the lamp. A body of free odiyans, owning its name, taking contracts by its own vote. I will put my hand to that." A small pause, as clean as a cut. "On two conditions. The crown keeps the pages of the four guards who have not named. And the crown keeps Chathu's pages for the forty, all of them, named and unnamed. They were written at my table. They were written for me."

"They were written *on* us," said Pavi, from the doorway.

"They were written *by a witness*," the queen said, "who saw each of you turn. I do not say it to wound. I say it because it is true, and a page is a page. Whoever holds those leaves can read them at night. A charter that lets the Company hold them lets eleven people who have not chosen walk about with a leash on their necks and no one's hand to keep it. Better in mine than in nobody's."

Neela listened and found, to her annoyance, that part of it was an argument. A good one. Better a known hand than none. She had thought it herself, once, about Chathu.

She lifted the sheaf out of its oilcloth because her hands wanted something to do.

She laid it against her face.

She hadn't meant to. She was tired in the way that makes people press a cheek to cold stone. Forty stiff pale leaves, and she bent her head to them and breathed. Something in her went still.

Nothing.

No scorched tamarind. No pine sap. No bitter bite at the back of the throat, the smell that had followed her through every yard and shed of her childhood and that she could have found blind in a burning house. She had stood beside this sheaf at the well, and in the hall, and on the road from Kodiyur, and she had called its smell lamp-black and thought nothing. Lamp-black. The smell of a clerk's pot.

She put her thumb to the first leaf, to the *Madhavi* in Chathu's tidy hand, and pressed hard.

The ink was dry. It did not tack. It did not take her thumbprint, or cling, or pull. Resin-ink never dried. She had seen a page of her own, fresh as the day it was written, ten years after.

*Grey-brown fingertips.* She had seen them in the cell, and noted them, and let the queen's calm talk her out of them. *A steward's list with the names left blank, and no answer.* She had stood in his cell with the tin warm in her hand and asked herself whether it fitted. It hadn't, and she had put the question down.

"Your Majesty," she said. Her voice came out smaller than she meant. "Did you ever read one?"

"I beg your pardon?"

"A page. One of his forty. At night, aloud, to the person it names. Did you ever try it?"

Nirmala looked at her. "No. I watched him write them, four evenings running. I did not wish to test a leaf on a stranger." Her eyes went to the sheaf. "Why?"

"Because it's plain ink." Neela held up her thumb. It was clean. "It's a clerk's ink, the same as Thilak's pot at the well. He wrote forty pages in it and never once used resin. They've no more power than a laundry list. They never did."

Nobody spoke. Haran took his shoulder off the pillar.

And she saw the namings again, the scorch rising at each dusk. It had come off each member's own handed-back Resin House page, the true one, which she had held beside the sheaf on her knee. Chathu's leaves beside it had only curled in the heat, like anything near a flame. She had watched the wrong paper burn and believed it.

Neela heard the thing she was saying as she said it, and it took her a moment to understand what she felt. It was not triumph, or not only. A man who held every one of their cages, who had sold her at nineteen and bound her at twenty-seven and told her the ledger was mercy, had been handed forty fresh cages and a reed, and he had written forty empty rooms.

Behind her, Devan said very quietly, "Neela."

She did not answer. She sat there with the sheaf against her chest and her eyes burning, and the hall went on being a hall around her.

"We will break for the hour," said the queen, and her voice had gone strangely careful. "I should like to look at those."

*

The tin came at the end of the hour.

Neela had gone out to the well because the hall had too many walls. Devan found her on the curb. He sat down without asking, a little to one side, so she had the whole of the curb to her left. He said nothing. That was what he did.

A steward in the queen's grey-green came across the court. He carried a small flat tin in both hands, wrapped in a cloth, the way you carry a thing that might spill. He bowed to her and not to Devan.

"From the palace post, mistress. Brought up with the column's last rider. It's for you by name. The rider says it was brought to the gate warm and he kept it warm as ordered."

She took it.

It was warm. She didn't need to open it. She knew its heft, and the faint oily smell through the cloth, jaggery and sesame. Eleven times it had come to her before a killing, once in the kennels, once on a gatepost,

and once she had carried it out of his cell. A folded scrap was tucked under the lid. The steward had done well not to read it, and had bowed himself away before she looked.

She read it.

*Written off. Paid in full. C.*

Common ink, grey-brown, in the neat hand she'd learned her letters from. She read it three times. Then she laughed, once, and it came out wrong.

"He knew," she said. "He sat in that cell and the queen put a reed in his hand and said *write them fresh.* And he wrote them in the wrong ink and said nothing and let her have forty empty pages." She held the scrap out flat in the sun. "He cheated a queen. For us. Devan, he cheated the *queen*."

"Yes," said Devan.

"It's the only thing he ever did that wasn't for himself. The only one." Her hands were doing something to the tin, turning it. "And he did it with a pot of ink and a straight face. He'd have loved that. He'd have liked to see her face."

Devan was silent.

"He taught me my letters," she said. "Did I tell you? Sitting at that long table with my feet not touching the floor. Pachan gave me his sweet and Chathu said, *Clever girl, you'll go far.* I was ten. Nobody had ever said I was clever. I thought it was the best day of my life." Her voice caught on something and she stood on it until it broke. "He held my wrist at the first resin and I screamed and he said *good girl, it's over.* He wept when Ammu died. I believe he did. And then he took the crown's money for me, and he put me in a cage, and he sent me a *tin.* Tin after tin. How can I—"

"You don't have to make it add up."

"I want it to add up."

"It doesn't." He said it gently, with the plain flatness she had learned to trust. "I won't tell you he was kind. He sold Asha. He sold you. He'd have sold me to the same bidder and sent a tin to my funeral. I won't say

a word for him." He turned his good hand palm up on his knee, not reaching for her, only leaving it there. "And I won't tell you not to grieve him. I haven't the right, and I haven't the grief. Say it. I'll sit here."

She stared at him.

She had expected an argument. Not a hard one. Devan would never have been hard. But she had braced herself for some careful sentence about what the man had done, and how little right she had to mourn him. She'd have deserved it. He didn't say it. He sat in the sun with a dead arm and a face grey from no sleep, beside the well where Ammu's blue cloth should have been, and let her miss the man who fed her and sold her. He did not mistake it for love, or call it weakness. He left it a space the size of a body.

"I'm not sorry he's in a cell," she said, with her eyes shut.

"No."

"I'm sorry he's not the man I thought he was when I was ten."

"Yes."

"He was never that man."

"No," said Devan. "But you were ten. You were right to want one."

She put the heel of her hand to her mouth and wept for a while, quietly, with the tin warm in her lap. He sat beside her and did not touch her until she turned her head. Then his left hand came up and settled on the back of her neck, steady and dry, and stayed.

When it was over she wiped her face on Muthu's coat and set the tin on the well curb, shut.

"I'm not going to eat them," she said.

"I didn't think you would."

"I might give them to Kannan's goat."

"Pepper would bite him for it," said Devan, and she laughed, a real one, and the grey ghost of a smile moved over his face and went.

She stood. Her legs held. She picked up the sheaf, and the scrap of paper, and Ittan's oilcloth tally book from where it rode against her ribs.

"Come on," she said. "I know what I'm going to say."

*

The queen had not moved from the warden's chair. Before her on the table lay three of Chathu's leaves, and she had her good hand flat on them as if to keep them from lifting. Usha stood very straight at her shoulder. Her face said she had already heard.

Neela put the scrap of paper on the table. Nirmala read it. A line cut deep between her brows and was gone.

"He wrote you forty cages in plain ink," Neela said, aware of the hall filling at her back. "I'm not saying it to shame you. You'd have been right to want something to hold, with thirty thousand Thurai on the beach."

"Fourteen hundred," said Haran.

"Fourteen hundred. It felt like more." She let it stand. "So the forty are free. They always were. The pages are ash with a name on, and the only living witness to those forty turnings is a man in your cell with ink on his fingers. You hold four real leaves, Majesty, and I'll come to them. But first I want to read you something."

"I am listening."

"I want everyone to listen. I want it said where the hall can hear." She opened the oilcloth tally book to the leaf with a bit of thread marking it. "This is Councillor Ittan's. Every extra pass he sold has a hook beside it. Down the other side there's another column, in the same hand, with no hook. A little bird, folded wings. You know what it means. The ledger key says it means *by leave.*"

The queen said nothing.

"Twenty-one years back, in brown ink copied from an older book." Neela read. "*Nellimala. Second harvest. Two boats of Thurai men, the coast road to the foot of the pass. By leave.*" She looked up. "That is my village. I was six."

"Neela," said Devan, behind her. Not to stop her. Only so that she'd know where he stood.

"Ponni is an old fishwife sleeping in Kesu's shed, and she was there. She says two boats crossed the bar at slack water with no pilot, as if expected. Men in grey waited at the top of the goat path with a flat cart. There was a small new yellow bird on the tailboard. One of them coun-

ted the youngest children as they were lifted on." Her voice did not shake. She had said it to herself on the road so often it had worn smooth. "I was in that count."

A low sound went through the hall. Kuttu, near the door, had put his hand over his mouth.

"Then the crown leaf." She laid it beside the tally book, the green-threaded intake rolls, the thin brown birds in every margin. "Thirty rolls. I've read them all. Usha, a potter's daughter from a hill village. Sanu, tailor's son, of Pallikara, which burned this season, and its name stands in the ledger as an intake village the year he was taken. Every village on these rolls was raided in the year its child was taken. Every one. I checked them against the raids Devan has on his border roll." She breathed. "And a Thurai scout died at the shelf with eleven new Varanad silver coins in his purse, with the lowest pepper leaf doubled on the die. That's the same die as the widow's coin you paid out of your own treasury. The same weight, to a grain."

She stopped. She had not known how loud a hall could be with nobody saying anything.

"The raids made your knives," Neela said. "That is all I have to say. I don't say it to bargain. I'm not holding it over you. I just don't think we can write a charter on top of it as if it weren't there."

Nirmala did not look away. She did not glance at Usha, or at Haran, or at the door. For a long moment she studied Neela's face, and the warm, unhurried expression she had worn through every hour since the Salt Gate stayed where it was and meant something different.

"Yes," she said.

It was not loud. It dropped into the hall like a stone into a well, and Neela, who had braced for a denial, a lawyerly sidestep or a gentle *you mistake me,* found she did not know what to do with her hands.

"Yes," the queen said again. "To all of it. I will not make you prove the rest." She drew her good hand off Chathu's leaves. Her bandaged arm lay in her lap, and Neela saw Usha's shoulder move as though the welt had stung them both. "I think I am being asked, today, to put down

several things I have carried a long time. I should like to say what I will sign. I would like the hall to hear it, and the Thurai to hear it, if there is a wind. I will sign a charter that—"

A horn sounded from the padippura.

One long note, then two short. Bhaskaran's code. Unarmed strangers at the gate, and not many.

Everyone turned. Behind her, Devan drew breath.

The note sounded again, and a third time, with something added at the end that she had never heard. Bhaskaran, who had a wife and four daughters and a soldier's discipline about horns, had let it run long.

Muthu was already at the door. He looked down the stair and back. His face was a man's who has read something in a clerk's round hand and hopes he's mistaken.

"Warden," he said. "It's Justice Rema. On your letter." A pause. "She's brought the high court's roll."

## Chapter 30

# Say It Anyway

Rema did not sit.

She came into the hall with the road still on her, mud to the knee and her case tied in oilcloth against her chest. Four bailiffs in borrowed green sashes stood behind her. Her old escort had gone over to the Company's side of the hall. She looked at the warden's chair, and at who was in it, and bowed to the queen exactly as far as the law asked.

"Majesty," she said.

"Justice," said Nirmala. "You have come a long way for a hall with no cushions."

"I have come with the high court's roll." Rema's voice was dry and quite steady. "It sat nine days ago. It entered Asha, daughter of the late warden of Kettamala, officer of the border, aged twenty-two, killed under contract. It entered the pass sales and the killing as one conspiracy, bought by the Keeper." She did not glance at the dead man's empty place. "The court cannot try whoever sealed the writ that paid the guild, because no one has laid it before the court. So it did the one thing left to it. It authorised me to record any charter the parties make. A true one, in daylight, with the witnesses present."

Devan stood by the table with his dead arm in its sash. His good hand was already at his coat.

Janu waited in the doorway, Muthu behind her. The Company had come in at Neela's back, thirty-odd of them, and stood along the pillars in tapper's wool. Captain Haran had stopped leaning on his pillar.

*Say it anyway,* Devan thought.

Asha had written it on a scrap he found under a camphor block. He had kept it from Neela for weeks, because it was the one thing of Asha's he could not share. She had meant it for whoever found the ugly truth. He had spent six years being a man who found it and kept it in a box.

"Justice," he said. "I have a paper to read. Then I will give it to you."

He took the oilcloth bundle from inside his coat. He had lifted it out of the hollow behind the third slat at dawn, and it had ridden against his ribs since. The red thread came away without a knot. He laid the contents on the table: a strip of hide, cracked and dark, a folded sheet with a green seal, and a lump of cut green wax.

The queen did not move. Usha, at her shoulder, did.

"This is a contract chit," he said. "It is the buyer's half. It names the warden's chamber at Kettamala, death by beast, before the pass closes. It is in Master Chathu's hand, and I know the hand from a letter shown at a border school." He turned the sheet and held it where the window light fell. "And this is a payment writ. It is dated seven weeks before my wedding. It is payable to the Resin House on the warden's account. It is sealed in green wax with a sunbird, and the sunbird has a chip at the left wing tip."

He set the cut wedding-gift seal beside the writ. The chip matched.

"I wrote to the council eight weeks before the wedding," Devan said. "I said the raiders' tallies carried true wax and asked to see the seal registers. Within days, this was sealed. The woman whose wax it is sits in the warden's chair."

The Company stood at his back like weather.

He knew what he was spending. Three hundred spears. The captains who had not yet decided to follow a man with one hand. The pass. He had told Neela the cost at dawn, plainly, because she asked for no softer word.

"I will not hold this over you, Majesty," he said, turning to the chair. "I have carried it on a hill for weeks and thought about how I might. I don't want a lever. I want it seen."

He walked the three paces to Rema and put the paper in her hand.

"For the court roll. In daylight. Enter it as read."

Rema took it as if it were hot. Her thumb found the chip in the wax. She looked at the queen, and for the first time her face did something other than record.

"Entered as read," she said.

*

Nirmala stood.

She did it without Usha's arm, which cost her something. The welt on her left forearm showed pale under the bandage where she had pushed back her cuff. It was Usha's, shared, and she did not try to hide it.

"May I answer?"

"The hall is yours," Devan said. It was the first thing he had given her that was not evidence.

"I permitted the raids," said the queen. Her voice was warm and unhurried. It did not rise. "Limited, through controlled passes, in exchange for no fleet on the coast. I made that treaty with sea lords I did not respect, and I called it keeping the peace. I bought thirty children's pages from a man I knew to be a seller of children, and I called it an economy. I sealed this writ." She did not look at it. "I paid for your death, Warden. You had asked a question that led to my councillor's door, and my councillor's door led to mine."

Devan had heard liars confess. He had heard frightened men do it. He had never heard it done like a ledger being read aloud, one line at a time, by the person who kept it.

"I believed a realm is kept safe by what it never has to see," she said. "The widows saw the sums paid. The villages saw the smoke. I saw only that the harbour was whole." She took a breath that Devan watched her

pay for. “The night the Thurai came up that cut with bronze caps and ladders, twenty-six of my own knives knelt in the wet, bleeding for strangers. A realm is not safe by what it has not seen. I held that it was. I find it isn’t so. It is only blind.”

She stopped. The hall let her.

“I have not finished being sorry,” she said. “I only found out this week I could do it standing.”

Devan looked at Neela. She stood at his shoulder, a step to the side, and she was not looking at the queen. She was looking at him, and her fingers had found his sleeve and closed on it hard.

*

“Before this goes to the crown,” Devan said, “it goes to the Company.”

The queen’s eyebrows rose a little. He didn’t blame her. A man with one hand and no office had just told a monarch that her charter would wait on a show of hands.

“The Company owns itself,” he said, to the pillars. “That is the first term. Nobody holds a page, a leash or a lease on any of you. You take contracts by vote, and you refuse them by vote. Second, the Blackbark groves go to the Company, under Pachan’s map. Resin is yours to ration and nobody’s to sell.”

Kuttu made a sound halfway to a laugh.

“Third. The crown never holds a page again. Not the four it keeps, not the eleven it claims. They come to the people they name, or they burn.” He looked at Nirmala. “Fourth. The crown recognises the Company in law. Every named member is under the charter, so none is rogue, and none may be hunted. Fifth. The Company holds the Monkey Pass for Varanad by contract. For pay, for a term, by vote, and with the right to say no.”

He lowered his hand. “That’s all of it. These are not mine to sign. Hands, if you want them. Nay, if you don’t. If you’d cut a clause, say it.”

“The groves,” said Pavi. “You’ll not ask the Company to guard them for the crown?”

"No. They are yours. Guard them or don't."

Thulasi asked whether *the pass by contract* meant they could be ordered back to the cut against their wishes. Devan said, "No. The contract says what you agree to. Anything past it comes back to a vote." She nodded and said nothing more.

Kuttu counted. He counted twice, because he did not trust his own thumb. When he was done he looked at Neela.

"All of them," Kuttu said. "All five. No one wanted a clause cut." He swallowed. "Kamalakshi's hand was the last one up, and the highest."

Devan found his own throat unreliable. He had asked, and they had answered. It was the whole of the thing.

"Then I've a last matter," he said. "It isn't a term. It's mine, and I'd like it said in front of you."

Neela went still beside him.

Once he had stood in a hall and had a clerk write that he harboured his wife. That was a shield, and it had cost him a seal. This was a debt, and he meant to sign it.

"I am bound to Neela," he said, loudly, in the middle of the hall, to sixty people and a queen. "Behind her when she wants a back, beside her when she doesn't, and never in front of her like a wall. Justice Rema, I ask you to enter it on the court roll, and to enter me as a member of the Company. Not as anyone's warden. Devan, of the Company, bound to Neela, odiyan, by his own word and by hers if she gives it. Set it beside Asha's name, in the same ink."

Rema's pen stopped over the page. "That roll goes past the assize note, Devan. It goes to the high court. A member of the Company is party to every act the Company takes under its vote. Every contract it accepts, every blow it strikes. Your name will stand under all of it, and no one will be able to say you only watched."

"I know."

"You would have no office to shelter behind. The crown could answer any one of them on you."

"Then it's spent." He kept his eyes on her. "I want the Company's life. I do not want Kettamala. I will not go home to it if home means standing apart from her. Wherever the vote sends her, my name will be on the roll beside hers."

The silence went on a moment longer than he could bear.

Then Neela stepped out from his shoulder, so that everyone could see her do it.

"I chose him," she said. Her voice shook once, and she let it. "On a rampart, with resin on my wrists. In the Resin House yard with a bear coming. I chose him in a fever, and I chose him with a bar across a shutter. I'm saying it by daylight, so nobody tells it differently." She took his left hand, the good one, and held it where the hall could see. "Enter it, Justice. I chose him, and I choose him again."

Rema wrote. The scratch of the nib was the only sound in the room. Then she sanded the line and turned the roll so the whole hall could see it.

The Company did not cheer. They were not people who cheered. Kamalakshi said, loudly, "About time," and Madhavi hit her on the arm.

Janu, in the doorway, had both fists in her apron and her chin up. Muthu looked at the ceiling.

*

"Majesty," said Rema, when the hall had settled. "The Company has voted its terms. Will you answer them?"

Nirmala looked at the table. At the hide strip and the green wax and the roll with Asha's name.

"One night," she said.

"Majesty—" said Haran.

"One night, Captain. I have not asked for much in thirty years that I did not take." She looked at Devan. "I have something to do tonight. I would rather do it alone, and be seen to have done it. I will answer at noon, by daylight, wherever this Company chooses to hear me."

"The old watch-house," Neela said, "on the shoulder above the narrows." She spoke at once. "It's empty, and it's ours to ask for. We want it for a hall."

"Noon," said the queen, "at the watch-house." She sat down again, rather suddenly, and put her good hand over the green case. Usha's fingers went to her own forearm.

Devan didn't ask what she meant to do. He thought he knew where her eyes had gone. They had gone to the case.

*

At dusk the court was cleared.

It took some doing. The garrison faced the wall, every man, on Haran's grudging word and Kandan's loud one. Bhaskaran stood by the gate with his horn unlifted. Muthu held the stair. Devan stood at the padippura with his back to the court and his face to the road, and Neela stood next to him in a coat that wasn't hers, a smudge of Thilak's ink still on her wrist above the bangle.

She had turned her back too. He had not asked it.

"You can't hear faces," she said, very low. "I can hear feet. I'll tell you who's coming. Names only. You'll know it was done, and you'll have seen nothing."

He kept his eyes on the road. It was an odd thing to be given: a witness's knowledge with the witnessing taken out. "Names only."

"Names only."

Behind them, a flask clinked. Resin has a smell like scorched tamarind, and he had hated it for twelve years. It no longer made his skin crawl. It smelled like the start of her mornings.

"Lata," Neela murmured. Hard heels on the stones, a guard's boots, then a stop. "She's stopped at Usha."

"Usha," said a voice behind them.

"I'm here."

"I said no in the palace. I said it so the queen would know I meant it. I rode north anyway." A long breath. "I don't want it to be her hand. If it's anyone's, it's yours."

"You know what it is," Usha said. "I already bleed for her. This makes two. I'll bleed for you both, and you'll bleed for me."

A pause. Devan could not see it, but he could hear the small scrape of cloth being pushed back. He guessed Usha was looking at the dressed cut on her forearm, the one that had raised its twin on the queen.

"I'd rather it cost somebody," Lata said. "That's what it's for."

"Then I won't tell you it's light."

"Look at me. Don't look away when it starts."

"I won't," said Usha.

Then came the small sound of a woman changing, wet and fast, a catch of breath and the shuffle of a body going down. Above it rose Lata's voice, low and flat and perfectly clear. One word.

Usha let out a long, shaking exhale. It was the sound of a person taking a weight she had been afraid to take.

"I have it," Usha said. "Lata. I have it."

"Done," Neela breathed. "Both of them standing." Her shoulder was warm against his arm. She went on counting for him, a name at a time, as the last of the unbound came. "Sajan. He's stopped at the edge. Sanu's watching him go." A scuff. "Kandan, close behind Sanu. Fists under his arms by the sound of his coat." Devan didn't turn. Voices, one by one. A word. A breath answering. Madhavi crying. Kuttu telling someone, in a cracked voice, that it didn't hurt, it didn't, he swore it.

"Kamalakshi," Neela said last, and he heard her smile. "Straight line. She's walking it like a rope."

He heard Kamalakshi say, "Steward."

"What?"

"I want to do it to you."

A silence. Then Janu, in the voice she used for burned rice, "Me? I'm sixty-one."

"You sat up with a lamp for the lot of us and didn't ask for anything after."

Another pause, longer. Devan could picture the apron, the fists in it.

"I'll bleed when you bleed."

"Yes."

"I'll feel it if you fall off a wall."

"I don't intend to fall off a wall."

"You've a face like a wall already," said Janu. "Stand there. No, there, in the light. I'm not squinting at you in the dark." Her voice thickened and went on without a break. "Yes. Yes, child, all right. Do it. Do it before I think better of it."

The change came, and the word, and a long, wavering breath. After it Janu drew in her own, once.

"Well," she said, after a time, in quite another voice. "That's that. And I'll tell you now, since we're bound, I've eaten your cairn-fire rice. It's a crime. Grey as a drowned rat. If I'm to bleed for you I'll not do it on that."

Someone laughed, a high cracked sound that was nearly a sob. Kamalakshi, he thought, and then he was sure.

The court breathed out. In the west the light had gone from the stair, and the single small flame at the foot of it stood steady, as it had at noon.

Neela's hand found his, the good one, and stayed. "That's all of them," she said. "You can turn."

He turned. She was already looking at him, her eyes bright.

Across the court, the south range had one window lit. A thin thread of smoke rose from it, too pale for a cookfire and too steady for a lamp.

"That's the queen's," Neela said.

"Yes."

"She said she'd do it alone."

"She said she'd be seen," said Devan. "Come on. Janu will want to feed us."

"She's going to be unbearable."

"Yes," said Devan, and for the first time in a long time he did not mind at all.

## Chapter 31

# The Charter

By noon the queen had not come, and Neela had counted the road four times.

The old watch-house stood on the shoulder above the narrows, a squat laterite room with a slate roof, a door that had lost its hinges and a gate fire-basket rusted the colour of dried blood. It had one window facing the pass. Someone had swept the floor. Janu, probably, who had arrived at dawn with a broom and a list of complaints.

Rema's table stood in the middle, borrowed from the lower court. The Company stood along the walls, sixty names and more, with garrison men packed in at the back. Devan stood at Neela's shoulder, a step behind and a little to the side, as he had promised. His dead arm lay bound in Thankam's green sash. His good hand was in her sleeve, and he did not seem to know it.

"She'll come," he said.

"I know."

"You've counted the road."

"Four times."

"It hasn't moved."

"Neither has she," said Neela, and Kandan's voice came from the door, loud with relief.

"Riders. The queen's own."

Nirmala came up the last of the slope on foot. Usha walked at her side, and behind them came Captain Haran with a grim face and a flat green case under his arm. The queen's grey hair was freshly dressed, and her face carried a night with no sleep in it. She stopped in the doorless frame and looked at the sweepings and the rust and the people.

"I have been in many halls," she said. "None of them had its owners in the doorway."

"It isn't finished," said Neela.

"No. It is better for that." She walked in.

She did not take a chair. She stood at Rema's table, and Rema stood to one side with the roll open. The first copy of the charter was in a clerk's round hand. As Nirmala unfolded it, Neela saw that the last third was in the slanting hand she knew from the sea room, quick and uneven, with two lines struck through.

"I wrote this myself," said the queen. "I would like to read it myself. Justice, tell me if I leave a word out."

"I will."

She began.

"*We, Nirmala, queen of Varanad, in daylight and before witnesses, recognise the Night Company as a body of free persons, owning its name, its groves, its hall and its members' lives. No page, leaf or ledger of any member shall be held by the crown or by any hand but the member's own. No member shall be hunted, caged, sold or named rogue under this charter. The Company contracts by its own vote and refuses by its own vote.*"

Neela had heard her read a dozen petitions in the same warm, even voice. The voice had not changed, only what it carried.

"*The Company holds the Blackbark groves under the map of Pachan, hunter and tapper, and the resin is the Company's to ration and no one's to sell. The sums entered in the crown's book as 'Sold to the crown', for thirty pages over twenty years, were taken from the price of children. They are owed back to the members they name, with the years, from the crown's own treasury, in panam, on the first day of the dry season.*"

A sound went round the walls. It was not a cheer. Thulasi had shut her eyes.

"*And the crown sets down, so that none who comes after may say it did not know, what it permitted.*" The queen's voice did not drop. "*The crown permitted limited raids by Thurai through the controlled passes, in exchange for a fleet that did not land. The crown permitted the pass-tokens of its councillor. The crown permitted the taking of children from villages the raids had burned, and bought their pages, and told the children they were safe. The crown kept in office the councillor who bought the death of the warden's sister Asha, and sealed the writ for the warden's own death in its own wax.*"

She stopped, and breathed once.

"I have left no word out, Justice?"

"None," said Rema.

"Then I sign."

*Nirmala,* in full, quick and slanted, no stamp, no clerk's copy. She set the pen down gently, as if it weighed more than a pen should.

"Recorded," said Rema, writing. "In daylight, by the high court's leave, before the parties. Captain Muthu."

Muthu came forward with the iron warden's disc in his fist. He had carried it since the day Devan unhooked it in the hall, and it still hung on him like a borrowed coat. He pressed it into the black bead of wax beside the queen's name with his whole weight. "Witnessed," he said. His voice cracked. "For the border. And the villages."

"And not for the household," said Devan quietly.

"Not for anyone's household," Muthu said, and stepped back without looking at anybody.

Neela found she was holding Devan's hand hard. Under her thumb sat the rope blister he had raised on the shelf ropes, three days old and tender. A welt rose on her own palm, and she let it. He turned his hand and held hers back, blister and all.

*

The green case lay open on the table. Haran had unbuckled it without being told.

Inside lay the crown leaf, what was left of it: three stiff pale leaves, each with a green-threaded roll looped to it, scorched along one edge. Lata's had burned itself at dusk, when she named Usha. Beside them lay the sheet headed *Sold to the crown*, which Devan had taken from his pack and laid there at dawn, with thirty ledger numbers and the folded-wing birds. Under that, tied with plain tape, lay forty leaves in Chathu's tidy hand.

"The gate basket, I think," said the queen. "Is it lit?"

It was. Kuttu had lit it at dawn, with a face that said he had a view on the matter. Nirmala took up the three leaves herself and carried them to the door and the small hungry flame in the rusted basket. The Company let her through. Neela went too, because she would not have missed it for a pardon, and she saw the queen's hand lift.

"Stop."

The queen stopped, the first leaf an inch from the fire.

"The rolls," said Neela. Her voice came out harder than she meant. "They're looped on. Birth names, birth villages. Burn the leaf and you burn those with it."

Nirmala looked at the green thread as though she had never seen it, and Neela believed she hadn't. The crown had read those leaves for twenty years and never once read the part that belonged to the children.

"I did not think," said the queen.

"No."

Usha held out her belt knife, hilt first. Neela cut the thread on the first roll, carefully, the way she cut a lock-spring. It came away whole. She did it three times. Then she held the rolls out on her palm and looked for the people they belonged to.

Two guards came forward and took theirs. Sajan came last. His brother Sanu stood beside him, close enough that their sleeves touched. Sajan closed his fist on the roll. It named a younger brother sold at seven,

and the brother was standing next to him, not quite looking at the paper.

"The leaf is only the leash," Neela said. "The roll is yours. What you do with the leaf is yours too."

"I'd like to do it myself," said Sajan.

The queen held the leaf out with both hands. He took it and fed it to the basket corner first. It caught, curled and blackened, and the ash rose and was gone on the pass wind. The other two folded theirs away and said nothing, and nobody asked them to. They had the rest of their lives to decide.

The queen put the sheet in next, once Rema nodded that every number was copied into the charter. The thirty numbers blackened in order. Then she loosened the tape on Chathu's forty and let them fall in a heap. They smoked, brown and ordinary, a clerk's list of rooms nobody lived in.

"Done," said the queen. She wiped her hands on her skirt like any woman at a hearth. "I keep my throne, Neela Seventeen, I believe. I do not keep my knives."

"You keep your name," said Neela. "That's a good deal."

"Is it?" The queen smiled slightly. "It is the one thing I may no longer hide behind."

Neela had braced all morning for the second thing, and it came up in her throat.

"I have a request. Chathu."

The queen waited. Behind Neela, Devan did not move.

"Don't kill him," said Neela. "Don't keep him in the rock. The kennels at the groves hold forty-one caged animals, and Pachan carries all the water, and he has two hands. Kirri's in the third from the end. Chathu kept them. He was the only one who knew which animal was whose. Send him there, under Pachan. He feeds them and waters them and cleans every cage with his own hands until he dies. He doesn't leave, he doesn't write, and he doesn't speak a shape aloud between dusk and dawn. Pachan can keep the gag cloth."

"For life. You think that is mercy?"

"No," said Neela. "I think it's the only job he's never done."

Nirmala was silent. Then she said, "Captain Haran, you will write that."

"Majesty—"

"At once, Captain."

Haran wrote.

*

One more thing remained, and Neela had been afraid of it all morning.

It was small. The Company's roll lay on a board across two buckets, a crown leaf in clerk's ink with sixty-odd names. Neela's own was first, in her hand. Under it sat Devan's, left-handed and crooked, where he had signed it in front of everyone. Beside the two names, in the margin, there was room for one more line.

"Your hand," Devan said. "Mine looks as if a hen wrote it."

"It looks like yours."

She took the reed, and beside their names, in her own steadier letters, she wrote the line they had worked out on the walk up the shoulder at dawn, in whispers, with the whole Company asleep below.

She read it aloud for the walls, because the Company had a right to hear.

"*Bound by choice.*"

"Bound by choice," Devan said after her, to the sixty, and he said it like a clause he had read ten times and agreed with.

"That is all?" said Rema, peering.

"That is all," said Neela. "We'll say the rest to each other."

Kamalakshi said "Finally," and nobody told her to hush.

*

The tent was Muthu's, lent and not asked for. It stood on the shoulder behind the watch-house with its back to the wind. It held a lamp, a rush

mat, two blankets and one pot of water. A leaf packet of cold rice and curd stood by the door, left by a hand that had not come in.

Neela undid the flap, and Devan ducked in after her.

He stood with his bad arm against his chest. In the lamplight his face looked tired and unguarded, the grey in his hair standing out. He was thirty-two and she was twenty-seven, and he had refused a throne's offer, and he looked at the floor of the tent like a field he had been told to cross.

"I can't do some of it," he said.

"I know."

"I can't hold you."

"You can hold me with the other one. Or I can hold you." She sat on the mat and looked up. "I've been thinking about it all day. In the middle of the queen's clauses, I confess."

"During the reading of the sums."

"Between sums."

The corner of his mouth gave. Then he said, low, "I'm afraid I'll do it wrong. I've only ever done this with two hands. With you."

"Come here."

He knelt on the mat. She found the knot of the green sash. Thankam had tied it with a surgeon's firmness, and Neela bent over it the way she bent over a lock. When it fell open she eased the arm out and laid it across her knee, the dead weight of it, the hand curled and still.

She kissed the palm. Nothing moved, but he drew a sharp breath through his teeth.

"Can you feel that?"

"A little. Like a lamp across a room." His voice had roughened. "More than I did."

So the hand was dead, and still it listened. She turned his fingers over and set his palm against her ribs, where the hook had torn them in Kodiyur, and held it there with her own.

"Then feel it there. Tell me if it's too much."

He told her it was not.

She undressed him slowly, with her eyes on the work, the way she had done every hard thing in her life. She eased the wool from the stitched shoulder and kissed round the place under the collarbone, then the nine silk stitches on his ribs. Under her mouth his breath went to pieces. When she was done she let him do the same for her, with his good hand, one finger at a time, learning a word in a language he'd stopped speaking.

"Ask me," she said, when he stopped.

"What?"

"You always do it without asking. You work it out from my back, my face. Do it aloud."

His breath caught. "May I—" The sentence did not come, and she waited. He closed his eyes. "Neela. May I put my hand here."

"Yes."

"And here."

"Yes."

"Will you stay close. I can't reach."

"I'm not going anywhere," she said, and moved over him.

She guided his hand where she wanted it. He learned fast, as he had learned everything she showed him. He asked, and she answered, and between the answers neither had much breath. Her fingers laced through the ones that would not close. She took his weight on her own thighs so his shoulder would not carry it. He said her name into the hollow of her throat, over the pale ridged scars he had kissed a dozen times without once mentioning them, and something she had held tight since she was six years old let go.

The share carried the rest. It ran as it always ran, her heat in his skin and his in hers, a doubled pulse, but tonight it ran louder, the dead side of him heard at last. Her pleasure reached him before she had finished having it. He made a sound she had never heard from him, low and astonished, and held on with his one good hand like a man who thought she might be taken.

When it was over, neither moved for a long time.

"I count the exits," she said into his collar. She hadn't meant to say it.

"I know."

"Door, flap, the seam by the pole. I always do." She was quiet. "I stopped. About the time you said my name. I didn't count anything."

He didn't say *good.* He didn't say *safe.* He put his mouth against her hair.

"Then it's the one place," he said. "The place where you can stop." He said it slowly, picking it out from the rest. "I'd like to be that. If you let me."

She lay on his good shoulder and looked at the lamp's moving ring on the roof. She had worn a leash once, a ledger, a number. She had spent years learning that a hand on the back of the neck means *wait.* His hand lay on hers now, and it meant nothing but *here.*

"And I'll be your right hand," she said. "The pen, the sword, the knots. Whatever you can't do, I do. Ask, and I do it. I'll say when I can't."

"You'll say it before you do it."

"Before," said Neela. "That's the bargain."

"It's a better one than the first."

"The first was a bad one," she said, and he laughed into her hair, the slow dry laugh she had waited half a year of mornings for.

*

She woke at first grey with her cheek on his collarbone and the lamp long out.

Cold came in under the flap. Out on the shoulder a langur barked once and stopped. She did not count the door. She counted what she had counted every morning since the wedding, and it was waiting where it always was: a small catch in a long slow breath, a third of the way through the count.

*One, two, and—*

There. Alive.

"Seven," said a voice by her ear, rough with sleep.

She went still. "What?"

"Seven breaths from the first of the grey. Yours catches at the ninth count. You hitch like a cart on a stone." His chest lifted under her cheek. "I've been awake a while. I wanted to be sure."

"You count mine."

"Every morning. Since the wedding. I thought you knew."

She hadn't. She lay with that and found her eyes were wet, and thought, quite calmly, that she'd been counting him for half a year and he'd been counting her as long, and neither had said.

"Then we've kept each other alive for half a year," she said, "on a bad habit."

"It's a good habit." In the thin light his face looked slack and easy, a man who had slept. "The Company will want its first vote today. As a chartered body, I mean. The crown can't order it now, and it can refuse the crown." He sounded almost amused. "Kuttu has been looking at the road since we came in."

She thought of Kamalakshi's raised hand and sixty ways of saying *no.* "What will he put to them?"

"I don't know. That's the point of it."

Outside, the horn spoke, one long bellow from the watch-house door. It was Kuttu's, and he was not a man who waited for the light.

Neela sat up. Through the flap she saw him on the shoulder, pointing down the pass road. A stranger was climbing it alone at grey, small as a thumb against the mist, in no hurry at all.

Devan reached for her with his good hand, and she took it, and for a breath neither moved.

Then she helped him find his sleeve.

## Chapter 32

# The Night Company

The lamp at the hall door had no shutter.

Neela checked it every dawn, the way she had once checked exits. It was a plain clay lamp on an iron hook, and it burned sesame oil day and night. Devan had taken the shutter off the first evening, prying the little tin door from its hinge with his left hand and a borrowed knife. He had set it on the sill without a word.

Once, at the foot of a stair, she had opened a lamp a thumb's width because a man told her to. She had counted to three hundred and ten in the dark afterward. Now the lamp stood open to the whole pass, and anyone climbing the shoulder could see it from a mile off. It said: *someone is here, and the door is not shut.*

She trimmed the wick and went in.

Weeks had gone by since the charter. The dry season had come early and hard, red dust where there had been mud, and the pass road had opened behind the last of the rains. The stranger who had climbed at grey after Kuttu's horn had turned out to be a boy, the pepper factors' runner, with wet sandals and a letter. Kuttu had been so embarrassed that he carried the boy's water up himself for a week.

The Thurai fleet had sailed. Sixty hulls had crept out of the bay on one tide, like a stain going out of cloth. The queen had read the truce aloud on the Kodiyur harbour steps with her own voice and her own name. Usha had stood at her shoulder, and Usha had told it to Neela

twice. Fishwives had come down to hear it. Rukmini had sold mackerel through the whole reading and shouted at the scale-boy for staring.

Open truce, the queen called it. Ships might return, under a cloth, to talk. Nobody in the hall believed it was peace. They believed it was a door left on the latch, and they had all learned to sleep beside one of those.

The hall was the old watch-house with its roof mended and its floor swept, and a long table that Thilak had built from the lower court's doors. Sixty-odd names hung on a board by the entrance in lamp-black. Sunlight lay across the table in a slab. Out on the packed earth behind, someone was swearing in a bright, cracked voice.

*

"Left," said Devan. "Not the right. Your right is the clever one. That's the problem."

He stood in the yard with his dead arm in its sash and his good hand held out flat. In front of him stood six of the youngest: Kuttu's cousin from the ferry, a pair of Kandan's recruits with the cuffs still too long for them, and Meenu, who still kept her back to a wall whenever she could. Each held a wooden practice staff in the wrong hand.

"Why?" asked Meenu.

"Because you're going to lose the other one someday." He said it flatly, as a fact about weather. "Everyone does, a little. A hook. A fever. A door shut on it. I had eight years of a drill that needed both hands, and it took a spear to teach me I'd only learned half of it." He turned the staff in the boy's fist, gently. "Again. Slowly. Slow is how you find where it hurts."

They went again. The staves clacked. The drill was a slow open-handed pattern he had made himself at twenty-five, the winter after the ford. She had watched him learn to run it backward with the wrong arm, a hundred times a day, swearing quietly. He did not look at her. He knew she was in the doorway. The first boy's staff swung wide and caught Devan across the good forearm with a crack. Devan said nothing, but his

ears went a little pink. On Neela's own left forearm a welt rose, hot and neat, and she rubbed it and did not look away.

Muthu rode up at midmorning, which meant it was the seventh day.

He tied his horse to the rusted gate basket and walked into the yard with his old grin and the iron disc swinging at his belt. He had grown thinner in a month. Holding a pass-seal did that, Neela thought. It was what happened to a man who chose a loyalty.

"Seventh day," Muthu announced. "I've been owed a whole round for a month."

"You were owed one a month ago," said Devan. "I paid it."

"You paid half. You'd your good arm up the whole time." Muthu pulled off his sword belt and dropped it on the dirt. Then, with ceremony, he tucked his right hand into his waistband and picked up a staff in his left. "There. Fair, now. I'll not have it said I beat a man with one hand and used two."

The youngsters had stopped. Even Meenu had come off her wall.

"This is a terrible idea," Devan said.

"Yes."

"You're going to hurt yourself."

"Warden," said Muthu, "I've been losing to you since we were boys. Let me lose my own way."

They squared up in the dust. It was not graceful. Muthu led with a stroke so wide that Devan simply stepped under it, and for a breath Neela thought it would end there. But Muthu spun on his heel, wrong-footed and furious, and cracked the end of his staff against Devan's ankle. Devan hopped. Then he stepped on his own sash and went down in the dust like a felled tree.

Muthu stood over him, panting.

"That's one," he said, delighted. "That's one in eight years. Admit it, you're beaten."

For a moment Devan lay looking at the sky. Then his shoulders began to shake, and the sound that came out of him was the slow dry one she knew, except that this time it came all the way up. He laughed at the sky.

He laughed until he had to put his good hand over his eyes. The six young ones watched him in awe.

"Beaten," Devan managed. "By a man holding his own wrist."

"Say it again," said Muthu. He was laughing too, with his head back, the big army laugh that had once drowned out a lie. "Say it for the roll."

Neela leaned on the doorpost and let her ribs ache. Far off in the dust a welt rose on her own ankle, a small bright joke in her bones.

She remembered the day he told her he had laughed only once before she made him do it. She had stopped counting how many times since.

*

The boat came in the afternoon, and it came as a basket.

It arrived on a cart with a fisherman's boy who had walked up from the coast, and it was the sort of woven basket that carried mackerel. The boy had a letter. The letter was from a boatwright at Pazhayangadi, who had raised a new shed on the burned shore. He wrote carefully that the vessel was sound and the keel true, and that he had painted the name as requested. *Kirri.* Twelve feet of coast fishing boat, bought with the Company's first earnings, the pay the crown had sent up in a sealed bag for a month of holding the pass.

The vote had been quick and strange. Kuttu had proposed it as a joke. Madhavi had stopped laughing before he finished. Thulasi had raised her hand first. Then it was hands all round the long table, even the four who never raised them for anything.

Neela turned the letter over and read it a second time.

Kirri had promised to send her anklet back in a fish-basket, a sign, once she had a boat of her own. She had been the guild's best liar, and nobody had believed her. Now there was a boat and a basket, and Kirri herself lay in a cage in the Resin House kennels with her mind nearly gone. The anklet was still on her.

Neela had a clean cloth folded. She had washed it three times in the well, with Janu's lye soap, and laid it in the sun. She put it in the basket

with a leaf of rice and a note, which she had written four times and torn three.

*Kirri. Your boat is built. She floats. I'll send the anklet down to her when you're ready to go out. Or you come out. I don't know which. Neela.*

She had not written *I'm sorry.* The word had no place in a cage. But she had signed with both names, in the bottom corner, small. *Indu.*

Pachan would carry it to the cage. He carried everything now, with Chathu behind him under a gag cloth at dusk and nothing but a mop and a bucket in his hands. Muthu had seen him on the cook-house step. Gaunt, grey, mopping.

Neela sent the basket down with the fisherman's boy and watched him go.

Ponni was waiting when she turned.

*

The old woman had come up the shoulder alone, which at her age was a kind of rebuke. She was small and weathered, with skin the colour of a walnut shell. She wore a faded cotton wrap and held a bone needle in one fist, as if it were a weapon she had not yet decided to use. She did not look at Neela's face first. She looked at her hands.

"Still tying it," said Ponni.

Neela looked down. Her fingers had been working a sash end all the while, pulling a double hitch tight. She had done it without thought. She did it in her sleep.

"Your mother tied it so," Ponni said. "Same hand. Same little flick of the thumb. She'd not have known she did it." She wiped her eyes briskly with the heel of her palm. "Don't fuss. I've seen the whole thing and I'm too old for you to fuss at."

"Come and sit."

"I'll see this door first."

So Neela took her to the board by the entrance. The roll hung there in lamp-black, sixty names on a plank, with Thilak's careful letters at the top. *Neela,* the first line read, and beside it, in a smaller hand she had ad-

ded herself, *Indu*. The two names stood together with a short bar between them, like two rivets in one plate.

Ponni could not read. She put a finger on each name and listened while Neela read them aloud. She went over the second one twice.

"That's her," the old woman said. "That's the girl I carried round the bend. She was heavy as a sack of rice and she never made a sound." Her mouth worked. "I thought I'd put her in the ground, you know. I thought it every day for twenty years."

"I know."

"You'll keep both?"

"I'll keep both," said Neela. "One of them is a number I answered to. The other I didn't know I had. I'd like to have them in the same place."

Ponni nodded, once, as if closing a ledger. Then she squinted into the hall and saw Janu's tiffin on the table. Kannan had brought it up that morning, in a covered brass tin, with a note in Janu's large furious hand. The note said the rice was overboiled because the cairn-fire wood had been wet, that the greens were the last the garden would give, that Neela was thinner than she had any right to be, and that she should send the tin back clean. A second line added, almost as an afterthought, *Eat the curd first.*

"Who sent that?" said Ponni.

"Janu. She keeps the house at Kettamala." Neela lifted the lid. "She's bound to one of ours, now. She says it's a crime."

"I like her already," said Ponni, and sat down to eat.

*

At dusk they voted.

It was the Company's first contract, and the Company took its time. Sixty-odd of them sat at Thilak's table or stood along the walls, with the lamp in the door burning behind them. Kuttu stood at the head with the great ram's horn on a thong round his neck. He had insisted. He had also insisted on speaking first, and had to be asked to stop.

The offer was in the letter the runner had carried up weeks ago, from the pepper factors of the lower village, in a plain hand with no wax. Forty carts of pepper were stacked at the pass foot, waiting since the rains. The raiders had never touched them. But the road beyond the shelf was long and lonely, and the factors had lost two drovers in the spring. They wanted the carts escorted over the pass and down to the coast road, in daylight, by the Company. They offered pay by the cart.

"Paired members only," Neela said. "That's my one clause."

Heads turned. She had said it quietly, as she said most things, but the room heard it.

"A pair can bleed for each other and know it," she said. "A lone member out on a road with a wound she didn't take is a woman in trouble nobody can trace. Pairs go together. If one is cut, the other knows where, and how bad, and which way to run." She looked down the table. "And nobody goes who isn't ready to bleed for the one beside them. If you've no partner yet, you stay."

There was a silence. Then Kamalakshi, from the bottom of the table, said, "Janu will want a place on the first cart."

"Janu," said Pavi, "is sixty-one."

"She says she isn't."

The laughter broke the room open. It was not the laughter of people at ease. It was the laughter of people who had bled for strangers a few weeks ago and were relearning how to do it for money. Neela let it run. Then Kuttu raised the horn and sounded one short note, the hall's sign for hands.

They voted. Forty-one for, nine against, the rest holding. Nobody had asked Devan to lead it. He sat at the table's end with his dead arm along the wood, and when the count was done he said only, "Pairs, then. We start at first light."

*

Mist still lay on the pass the next morning when the horn went.

It was not Kuttu's long bellow this time. It was Bhaskaran's code, blown from the gate far below and carried up the cut on the cold air. One long note, two short. Unarmed strangers at the gate, and not many.

Neela went to the door.

The lamp still burned in its hook. Devan came and stood beside her in the way he had learned, a step behind and a little to the side. They watched the road together.

Three came up the shoulder in the grey. The first was a tall man in a pale robe, grey at the temple, with a white cloth tied at his left wrist and another at the head of the staff he carried. A truce cloth. Behind him walked a servant with a flat box. And at the tail, a pace apart from the others, came a lean man with a long jaw and a coat too heavy for the weather.

The envoy stopped ten paces from the lamp. He looked at it for a time. It was the look of a man who had expected a guarded door.

"I am told," he said, in careful, accented Varanad, "that this is the house of the Night Company."

"It is," said Neela.

"I am sent by the lords of the sea. I come under cloth, as your queen has allowed." He bowed from the waist, exactly as deep as law demanded and no deeper. "They wish to hire it."

Nobody spoke. Down the shoulder, someone dropped a bucket.

"For what?" said Devan.

"That," said the envoy, "I am to say to the Company, and not to its door."

Neela hardly heard him. She was looking at the man behind.

He stood with his hands loosely folded, the cuffs of his coat pushed back a little, as if the wind had done it. The skin of both wrists showed bare and pale, and she knew those ridges. She had seen them every day of her life on her own arms. Thick, layered, a decade of burning. Under them, the wind brought her something else. Salt. Sweet, dry clove-bark, and under that the bitter scorch of resin, fresh as a week ago.

She had smelled it once before, on a sleeper by a half-built tower, among sixty-three tents on a slope where her mother's house had been.

The man's eyes came up and met hers. He did not look away. His long jaw moved as if he would speak, then closed. He wore a ring on the thumb of his left hand.

She had read every page the Resin House ever wrote. Eighty-two pages in a single day, and the ones in the ledger's back half, and the stubs. She knew every number and every shape the House had ever made. She had counted them twice.

He was in none of it.

"He's yours?" she said to the envoy, and kept her voice level.

"He is ours," said the envoy. "He asked to come. He says you will want to see him." A small, thin smile. "He says also that he is in no book you hold. I confess I did not understand what he meant."

Neela understood it perfectly. It rose in her like cold water. A rogue, with no master and no ledger, who smelled of a House that had been finished. Someone had been making odiyans in a place she had not found, and had been doing it with the sea lords' salt on them.

Who made you? she wanted to ask. And what do they want with free knives?

She did not ask. She had learned that much. You do not put the question that matters to a stranger at your door. You put it to your own people first.

She turned her head.

Devan was looking at the rogue too. His good hand had closed, once, at his side. Then he looked at her, and only at her, and his face had changed in a way she knew now. It was the face of a man who had spent eight years deciding everything alone, and had chosen, in front of the envoy and the whole yard, to wait for her.

"I'm asking aloud," Neela said, quietly, so the stranger would hear it and so Devan would. "Before the Company, and before them. How do you vote?"

Devan held her eyes. A breath. Two. In the mist, the lamp burned in its open frame.

"You first," he said.

She had not known how much she wanted it until it was given. She turned back to the envoy, and the stranger, and the box, and the long road down.

"Then I vote no," she said. "Thurai burned Nellimala. I was carried out of it in a fishwife's arm. I'd sooner go hungry a season than be paid in their silver, and if the table says yes against me, I'll carry that cost too." She lifted her chin. "But we'll hear you. All of us, at the table. And you'll leave your staff at the door. We vote at noon."

# Also by Anya Kalloor

**The Odiyan Contracts**

1. *Vow of Teeth*
2. *Oath of Claws*
3. *Crown of Night* (this book)

# Coming next

Varanad has a secret. In the black woods above the pepper coast, a guild trains orphans to become odiyans. At dusk, a smear of bitter resin on throat and wrists, and a woman becomes a leopard, a jackal, a bear. By dawn she is a woman again, and anyone who saw her change holds her life in their mouth. One word, her animal's name spoken in the dark, and she is caged in fur forever.

Neela has done eleven contracts. The twelfth will earn her release, her page burned and her birth name returned. The twelfth is a man.

Devan, warden of Kettamala, is the husband she was sold to. She has forty days before the monsoon closes the Monkey Pass. She has a window, a ledge broad enough for a crouching body, and a plan to make his death look like a leopard's work.

He has a secret too. He saw her turn on their wedding night, and he has said nothing.

Every shutter he closes at dusk is a mercy or a trap. Every night he sleeps beside her is a night she could end it, or he could. And somewhere above them both, a seal in green wax has paid for his death.

Three books. One couple. A guild that owns its killers, a queen who keeps knives nobody sees, and a love that costs blood to keep.

Start with *Vow of Teeth*. It begins with a wedding at sunset, and one question:

Will Neela kill the husband she was sold to?